

TOWARD A PRINCIPLED COMMUNICATIVE METHODOLOGY FOR TEACHING
THE BIBLICAL LANGUAGES

A Master's Thesis
Presented to
the Faculty of
Fresno Pacific University

In Partial Fulfillment
of the Requirements for the
Master of Arts Degree

By
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April 2017

Accepted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the Master of Arts Degree
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ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

I am grateful to Brian Schultz for his wisdom, experience, and vision for biblical language instruction as well as his supervision of this degree, to Doreen Ewert for her invaluable expertise and guidance in navigating the field of Second Language Acquisition, and to my sacrificial and supportive wife for making this work possible. I am also grateful to Fresno Pacific University for the opportunity to construct an interdisciplinary Individualized Master of Arts Program that combines both Second Language Acquisition and the biblical languages.

ABSTRACT

Very few learners of Hebrew and Greek ever reach the ability to read biblical texts fluently—that is, for pleasure, at a normal rate, for extended periods of time, and without frequent recourse to lexicons and grammar helps. The primary reason for this is because the current pedagogy used to teach the biblical languages—Grammar-Translation—is ineffective for language learning, as is evidenced by the fact that no research in the field of Second Language Acquisition (SLA) supports it. By contrast, learners of modern languages are able to reach proficient levels relatively efficiently. However, it is generally assumed that the principles that undergird modern second language instruction do not apply to the teaching of “dead” languages. Is this assumption warranted ... or is it misguided? This thesis seeks to answer the question: Can the same language teaching principles derived from modern Second Language Acquisition research be effectively applied to the teaching of the biblical languages? Based on a broad survey of SLA literature, ten principles for second language teaching will be summarized and evaluated concerning their applicability to the teaching of the biblical languages, Hebrew in particular. These principles represent an orientation towards language teaching that the field of second language teaching refers to as Communicative Language Teaching (CLT). Research suggests and experience demonstrates that implementing CLT in biblical language programs is indeed possible and that it will enable learners to reach higher levels of language proficiency, more efficiently, and with

greater long-term retention than the current Grammar-Translation approach is able to achieve.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

CLT	Communicative Language Teaching
FL	Foreign Language
GT	Grammar-Translation
L1	First Language
L2	Second Language being learned (i.e., target language)
SL	Second Language
SLA	Second Language Acquisition

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

Ancient languages function as windows into the past, through which civilizations and cultures may be observed by those peering backwards centuries and even millennia later along the timeline of history. The roots of modern thinking can be traced back to the literature preserved in these languages that were once used to trade pottery, tools, and food, to pray to deities, to express one's deepest emotions, and to wrestle with the basic questions of life that still occupy minds today. As time elapsed, however, languages have died, evolved, and even been born, forming a linguistic gulf between these once-spoken ancient languages and their distant descendants of today. What was once learned effortlessly by children playing at home now plagues college and graduate students who wrestle to grasp its meaning, yet modern students are no less competent at acquiring languages than children of the ancient past—indeed, *all* human beings are endowed with this remarkable gift. Why, then, does learning ancient languages prove to be such a difficult, inefficient, and seemingly insurmountable task?

There exists an entire field of study that is devoted to answering the question, “How do humans best acquire second languages?” Professionals have devoted their lives and careers to the discipline of language teaching. Furthermore, a vast amount of research has been and is being conducted in related fields such as cognitive science, applied linguistics, psycholinguistics, education, human psychology, and first language acquisition, in order to answer the same question and its logical counterpart, “In light of how human beings *learn* languages, what is the most efficient way to *teach* languages?”

The research conducted to answer these questions is being applied to modern language programs all over the world. Consequently, adult learners of second (or “other”) languages often reach near-fluent levels of language proficiency by the time they complete their master’s degree, and sometimes even their bachelor’s degree. These students are expected to be able to read and engage with the literature of their language with competence and efficiency, without relying heavily on the use of resources such as dictionaries and grammars.

In comparison, most students of ancient languages graduate from university, seminary, or graduate school with a language proficiency well below that of their modern language peers. In fact, they are *far* from fluent, and thus are *unable* to read and engage with the literature of their language competently or efficiently. Further, to the dismay of countless seminary and graduate students, the ancient languages—whose classes often require the most time, effort, and stress—are notorious for being quickly forgotten after the student’s formal training is complete. Again, the question must be asked: why is this the case?

While there are a number of reasons for this problem, it seems that the fundamental cause is pedagogical. In other words, the reason modern language learners generally reach a far superior command of their language(s) than ancient language learners do theirs is because the approaches with which the languages are taught are drastically different from one another. This should not come as a surprise when one considers the fact that the approaches to teaching modern languages have significantly evolved and progressed over the decades, while the same approach to teaching ancient languages has been used for nearly two hundred years, with little to no change (more on

this in Chapters 3 and 4). Perhaps this discrepancy in the approaches used for teaching second languages is due to the underlying assumption that “dead” languages *cannot* be taught similarly to “living” languages, but is this assumption warranted?

The preconceived notion that teaching ancient languages is fundamentally different from teaching modern languages has created an unfortunate gulf between the fields of ancient language instruction and Second Language Acquisition (SLA), with little to no cross-pollination. That is, neither field perceives the relevance of the latter for the former. It is as if ancient languages are not viewed as actual languages, but are placed in an entirely different realm of learning. It seems unfortunate, therefore, that a field such as SLA, which has potentially so much to offer for the benefit and success of students (and teachers) of ancient languages, should be immediately dismissed due to what could possibly be mere misguided (and/or unquestioned) assumptions.

Hence the question being investigated in this paper: *Can the same language teaching principles derived from modern Second Language Acquisition research be effectively applied to the teaching of the biblical languages?* If it is indeed possible for modern SLA principles to be applied to the teaching of ancient languages such that ancient language learners reach higher levels of competency and more efficiently, then it would behoove teachers of ancient languages not only to be aware of such principles, but also to incorporate them into their own teaching of ancient languages. The ramifications for both teachers and students of ancient languages could be tremendous.

CHAPTER 2: METHOD OF INVESTIGATION

Research Question

The question being investigated is: *Can the same language teaching principles derived from modern Second Language Acquisition research be effectively applied to the teaching of the biblical languages?* It is hypothesized that the field of SLA contains much research that is relevant for the teaching of ancient languages. If such research can indeed be applied to the teaching of ancient languages, then learners will achieve higher levels of proficiency in the target language, more efficiently, and with greater long-term retention.

Scope

Addressing the teaching of *every* ancient language lies beyond the scope of this paper, since the term ‘ancient language’ includes potentially dozens of common languages for study. For the present investigation, it is sufficient to home in on a subset of these languages as representative of the others. Classical (i.e., biblical) Hebrew and Koiné Greek, the two primary biblical languages, have been selected to fill this role, due to the present researcher’s experience teaching these two languages, as well as the number of pedagogical resources that exist for each of them. Accordingly, and for the purposes of this paper, the term ‘the biblical languages’ will refer to Hebrew and Greek and exclude Aramaic.

When it comes to evaluating the applicability of SLA research to the teaching of the biblical languages (Chapter 7), the scope will be narrowed even further to the teaching of biblical Hebrew alone. The rationale for this limitation is multi-faceted. First,

biblical Hebrew, in particular, seems to be experiencing what might be a renaissance in pedagogical practices, given the publication of a handful of innovative textbooks in recent years (more on this in Chapter 6). Second, the present author has had the most experience teaching biblical Hebrew and experimenting with the research findings. In other words, there is more data with which to work for biblical Hebrew. Third, Hebrew is commonly viewed as the more difficult of the two primary biblical languages. Therefore, if the question being researched applies to the teaching of Hebrew, then it should also apply to the teaching of Greek. Lastly, limiting the discussion to Hebrew will provide the added benefit of consistency for the reader when practical classroom applications of the SLA research are discussed (Chapter 7). Nonetheless, while the “test case” of the present research will be specific to the teaching of biblical Hebrew, the results should, in theory, be applicable to the teaching of other ancient languages as well.

Overview

The stark contrast between modern and biblical language instruction needs to be highlighted in order to demonstrate to the reader both the seriousness and perplexity of the issue at hand. To that end, Chapter 3 describes the current state of biblical language instruction, Chapter 4 describes the current state of modern language instruction (based on current SLA research), and then Chapter 5 *evaluates* the current state of biblical language instruction in light of modern SLA research. The following question will be addressed: Are current biblical language programs effectively meeting the needs of those who desire to access primary source documents for their particular purposes?

Chapter 6, then, both surveys and evaluates the more recent attempts to apply SLA principles to the teaching of the biblical languages. Both textbooks and institutes

that claim to follow modern language teaching principles will be discussed, with a particular focus on the consistency and thoroughness with which each does so.

After laying the necessary groundwork in Chapters 3–6, Chapter 7 addresses the research question directly: Can the same language teaching principles derived from modern Second Language Acquisition research be effectively applied to the teaching of the biblical languages? As stated above, the test case with which the question will be answered is specific to the teaching of biblical Hebrew. Accordingly, each of the SLA principles delineated in Chapter 4 are revisited and evaluated in light of their applicability to the teaching of biblical Hebrew. In addition to the evaluation, there is a discussion on the constraints and limitations of each principle, as well as some specific examples of classroom activities that follow each principle.

Chapter 8 discusses a way forward for biblical language instruction, first by considering some common questions concerning the value of the proposed approach, and then by addressing the question of what is needed in the field of biblical language instruction. Lastly, the issue of curriculum implementation will be addressed, which is perhaps the most daunting task in proposing what amounts to such a massive paradigm shift in the long-established field of biblical language instruction.

CHAPTER 3: THE CURRENT STATE OF BIBLICAL LANGUAGE INSTRUCTION

Introduction

In order to discuss the current state of biblical language instruction, it is important to understand where it falls within the broader history of second language (SL) teaching, which is marked by a plethora of varied approaches, methods, and techniques that vie for prominence today. Being aware of past trends—both successes and failures—will enable one to make more informed decisions and to engage more effectively in current discussions. Concerning the field of modern second language teaching, Celce-Murcia (2001) states that “very few language teachers have a sense of history about their profession and are thus unaware of the historical bases of the many methodological options they have at their disposal” (p. 3). This is perhaps even more true for instructors of the biblical languages, since very few (if any) have been dually trained in the field of SLA.

As such, it is as if the biblical languages—indeed *all* ancient languages—are placed in an entirely separate category from modern languages. However, it should be noted that ancient languages were not always ancient! At one point in time, whole civilizations learned what are currently termed “ancient languages” the very same way modern civilizations learn their first language(s). Likewise, countless people throughout ancient history learned these very same languages as second languages. It is therefore helpful to understand how languages—all languages—have been taught and learned

throughout history, and at what point once-“living” languages like Hebrew, Greek, and Latin began to be taught the way they are today—as “dead” languages.

A History of Second Language Teaching: From the Classical Period to the Nineteenth Century

Throughout history, there have been numerous pendulum swings in the field of second language teaching as new theories, methods, and fads have come and gone, often due to social, political, cultural, and intellectual influences. However, as Celce-Murcia (2001) explained, all these different theories and methods can be boiled down to two basic, alternative approaches to language teaching that have characterized the scene from antiquity: “*getting learners to use* a language (i.e., to speak and understand it) versus *getting learners to analyze* a language (i.e., to learn its grammatical rules)” (p. 3, italics original). These two approaches form the “great divide” in language teaching, as will be observed in the ensuing discussion.

During the classical Greek and medieval Latin periods, anyone wishing to engage in philosophy, religion, politics, or business would learn to speak, read, and write Greek and Latin fluently. Few, if any, formal approaches to language teaching were used at that time; rather, informal and *direct* approaches were employed. Celce-Murcia (2001) described the situation:

We can assume that the teachers and tutors ... used aural-oral techniques with no language textbooks per se, but rather a small stock of hand-copied written manuscripts of some sort, perhaps a few texts in the target language, or crude dictionaries that listed equivalent words in two or more languages side-by-side. (p. 3)

In other words, those whose mother tongue was not Greek or Latin (or any other ancient language, for that matter) did *not* attend grammar school in order to learn how to analyze these languages, because the primary focus was on getting learners to use the languages

for communicative purposes. Indeed, one questions whether speakers of ancient languages were even able to analyze their languages the way modern scholarship does in order to comprehend the very texts they penned.

Then, sometime during the Middle Ages a more formal study of Latin arose due to the realization that the grammar of the vernacular (i.e., vulgate) Latin that was being used as a lingua franca had diverged significantly over time from the grammar found in classical Latin texts. The focus thus shifted away from using the spoken dialect towards analysis of the classical written dialect, as monks in monasteries sought to preserve Latin as the primary medium for religion and scholarship (Pennycook, 1989). The invention of the printing press in the fifteenth century only fostered this formal study with the mass production of Greek and Latin grammar books.

As the European scene grew in the seventeenth century, Renaissance ideas spread and people realized their need to speak the newer, ever-developing languages in order to engage with the broader world. In order to help learners be able to utilize the European languages for real communication, a well-known Czech language teacher and methodologist by the name of Johann Amos Comenius (1592–1670) published books promoting an inductive approach to learning foreign language, which was the first of its kind. Some of the techniques he advocated included, “Use imagination instead of rules to teach a language,” and “Teach language through pictures to make it meaningful” (Celce-Murcia, 2001, p. 4; see also Pennycook, 1989, pp. 599–600). Comenius’ views had a profound impact on foreign language instruction for some time.

Consequently, what were once the “elite” lingua francas (i.e., classical languages) had been replaced by more prestigious and predominant European languages (most

notably French) as the primary medium for scholarly communication. People were now *using* the European languages and *analyzing* the classical languages that were cloistered in the formal language classes of the academy. Ironically, “the Renaissance preoccupation with the formal study of classical Latin may have contributed to the demise of Latin as a lingua franca in Western Europe” (Celce-Murcia, 2001, p. 4). This formal study of the classical languages then bled into the enlightenment era, and eventually the modern era, where “the study of classical languages was valued as training for the mind, an exercise in logical thought” (Savignon, 2007, p. 208). The Renaissance, therefore, had opposite effects on classical and modern languages.

Interestingly, however, the *modern* language teaching pendulum swung back to a more formal study at the beginning of the nineteenth century, as the same explicit study of grammar rules that had characterized classical Latin instruction was now also being used to teach modern languages in European academies. This analytical and systematic study of grammar is known as the Grammar-Translation Approach (GT), and was codified by Karl Ploetz (1819–1881), a German scholar who greatly influenced the language-learning scene during this period (Celce-Murcia, 2001).

What must be noted at this point is that the same formal (analytical) approach to teaching both classical and modern languages that was systematized in the nineteenth century has continued to characterize *ancient* language instruction up to the present time with little to no change (Rico, n.d.b). On the other hand, modern language instruction continued to evolve significantly throughout the last two centuries, as will be described below. First, a detailed look at the GT approach is needed.

A Description of the Grammar-Translation Approach

Introduction

Of the two fundamental approaches to language teaching—getting learners to use a language and getting learners to analyze a language—GT falls under the latter category. It has officially been used to teach both the classical and biblical languages since the nineteenth century, though formal study of these languages had been practiced long before this. The title “Grammar-Translation” is fitting since this approach believes that language learning is achieved by mastering the grammar rules of the target/second language (L2), which will then enable the learner to translate texts from the L2 into the learner’s first/mother/native language (L1) via written composition. It is a deductive, bottom-up process, whereby learners begin with the smallest units of the language (i.e., letters) and then work up, piece by piece, towards the whole (i.e., sentences and texts). Because reading literary texts and language analysis is seen as the primary goal of language learning, reading and (sometimes) writing are given primacy among the language skills. The following is a summary of what this approach typically looks like, which is then followed by some general characteristics.

The Language-Learning Process

The language-learning process begins by learning to read and pronounce the alphabet, followed shortly by memorizing the rules for syllabification and spelling.

After this fundamental component, courses/textbooks are generally divided into two *broad* sections: nouns/nominals and the verbal system. Because the former is typically viewed as the “easier” of the two, it often comes next in the presentation of the language system.

Learners are thus introduced to the noun system, along with the article, gender/number suffix endings, and the rules for morphological changes (i.e., how the various components of a word change, depending on its function and/or context in a sentence). Next, other grammatical topics like pronouns, adjectives, prepositions, conjunctions, and numbers are presented sequentially, though textbooks vary in the particular order. The emphasis is on grammatical parsing and labeling of these different forms. Consequently, learners are often required to memorize paradigms, or charts, of the various forms and be able to reproduce them from memory, as well as identify how these various language components function in a given sentence.

Finally, verbs are introduced one category at a time, beginning with the common/easier/“default” forms before examining the “more difficult” forms (e.g., subjunctive mood and participles for Greek, and derived stems and weak verbs for Hebrew). Again, learners are typically required to memorize verb paradigms.

Isolated vocabulary lists void of any context are presented from the very beginning for the learner to begin memorizing. The meaning of these words is accessed via glosses, or translations, into the learner’s L1. Vocabulary selection is typically based on an analysis of frequency, beginning with the most common words in the biblical corpora. Generally, about 300–500 words are taught/tested in a first year course (e.g., Mounce, 2009; Pratico & Van Pelt, 2007).

General Characteristics

Taught in L1. The first thing to mention regarding the characteristics of GT is the use of the learner’s L1. “Instruction is given in the native language of the students,” and because “there is little use of the target language for communication ... the teacher does

not have to be able to speak the target language” (Celce-Murcia, 2001, p. 6). As a result, the vast majority of material in GT textbooks, as well as the vast majority of instruction in class, is in the learner’s L1, and not in the L2.

Focuses on form. The GT approach places a large emphasis on the memorization of explicit grammatical forms, which are often void of any meaningful context. Highly analytical explanations of grammar concepts characterize classroom instruction and homework readings. Further, learners are expected to be able to parse the various grammar forms and inflections—whether in isolation or in context—in order to comprehend the meaning of the text. For example, a student of Greek would be expected to recall the following information upon reading the word ἦλθεν: This is a second aorist (tense), active (voice), indicative (mood), third (person), singular (number) verb form from the base verb ἔρχομαι, which means “I come/go”; thus, the word means “he/she/it came/went” (depending on the context).

Translates for meaning. Because the L2 is not used for communication in “live” settings, meaning can only be derived through translation into the learner’s L1. For instance, upon reading the word בית (bayit), a student could only understand the meaning of this word because she has also memorized the English equivalent “house” associated with that Hebrew term.

Organized by grammar. Grammar-Translation textbooks and courses universally follow a grammatical syllabus, which progresses through the language system in a linear sequence, one element at a time. Each lesson focusses on only one or a few grammar topics, and students are expected to master them before moving on to the next.

Uses authentic texts early on. It is often the case that beginning learners are introduced to authentic L2 texts (i.e., taken directly from the Bible) early in the language-learning process. Texts are used to highlight grammatical concepts or for practice translating into the learner's L1. Often, the sentence is the largest unit of language that is used for translation practice, though larger texts are sometimes used at more advanced stages of language learning.

Results in analytical skills. Naturally, because the language is not used to communicate throughout the instruction, learners do not internalize the language and are not able to communicate with the L2, even after years of advanced study in the language. However, communication is not the goal of GT, as stated above; reading and analyzing texts is. This analysis requires a slow and meticulous process of identifying the words in a sentence, parsing them, determining their use in the sentence, and then translating them into the learner's L1. Rico (n.d.b) has described the results of the GT approach this way:

This [GT approach] presents students with a reality quite foreign to them. The ancient languages become far removed from their everyday lives, and thus appear to them like phantoms issuing from a dead world. ... The study of these languages does not result in the fluid reading of texts, even for the teachers themselves. Many professors of Classics remain incapable of reading an ancient text with ease without the aid of a dictionary. Founded on translation, the acquisition of these languages is restricted to analysis and, viewed within individual phrases rather than in a living context, is regarded as an equation or a problem to be solved. (p. 1)

In other words, GT teaches one how to analyze and translate texts, not to read them fluently, despite what teachers or textbooks might claim in their learning objectives.

Conclusion

The GT approach may be summed up as a highly analytical process involving the rote memorization of vocabulary and explicit grammatical forms and rules that lead to an

ability to translate texts in order to comprehend meaning. As mentioned above, GT was systematized in the mid-nineteenth century, yet it has characterized ancient language instruction ever since.

The question is, why did modern language instruction undergo so many changes during that same time period?

CHAPTER 4: THE CURRENT STATE OF MODERN LANGUAGE INSTRUCTION

Introduction

As was seen in the previous chapter, language teaching has vacillated between getting learners to use the language and getting learners to analyze the language.

Pennycook (1989) summarized the general historical sweep of language teaching from the classical period to the nineteenth century:

Although oral approaches were originally employed with Latin, these changed once Latin was no longer used as a language of communication. This, in turn, affected the approach toward teaching modern languages until the 19th century, when these deviations were overcome and the reinstitution of the primacy of the oral over the written led to the opening up of the modern era. (p. 601)

Interestingly, the same pendulum swings that characterized the pre-modern era also describe the period from the nineteenth century to the present, though perhaps to an even greater extent. Historical, political, and social factors have had massive influences on the entire world that directly affected the goal of language learning, and, consequently, the way in which languages were taught (Celce-Murcia, 2001; Pennycook, 1989). At the same time, advances in technology have propelled fields like cognitive science and psychology far ahead of where they once were, providing insight into the human mind that has drastically changed language theorists' understanding of how languages are learned, and, therefore, how they should be taught.

A History of Second Language Teaching: From the Nineteenth Century to the Present

Grammar-Translation Approach

The GT approach espoused by Ploetz dominated both the classical *and* modern language learning scene during the nineteenth century. To reiterate what was described more fully above, this approach focuses on explicit grammar knowledge, with little or no use of the L2 for communicating. Instruction is given in the learners's L1, so teachers do not have to be able to speak the L2, nor do students learn to communicate using the language (Celce-Murcia, 2001).

Direct Method

At the end of the nineteenth century, however, there was another shift that took place as reformers like François Gouin (1831–1896) began recognizing that child L1 acquisition has great import for adult L2 acquisition. These reformers began publishing work that led to the Direct Method (Krause, 1916), which was a response to the GT approach that had preceded it. In the Direct Method, all instruction is given orally in the L2. Teachers, therefore, must not only be able to speak the L1 of the students, but must be fluent (or near-fluent) in the L2 as well. Grammar is learned inductively in meaningful contexts and the literature is read for meaning, not for grammatical analysis. The focus shifted back to language use. This method spread across Europe and into America, where it lost momentum due to a lack of language teachers who were fluent in the languages they taught (Celce-Murcia, 2001).

Reading Approach

The Modern Language Association of America responded to the dilemma of too few fluent teachers in the early twentieth century by endorsing the Reading Approach, which taught learners merely to read the language in order to study some of its great literary works. Another reason for the renewed focus on reading was because very few people were traveling abroad at that time (WWI) and there was, therefore, very little need to *speak* other languages. Similar to GT, this approach focused on the grammar rules, but only those necessary for reading comprehension. Translation exercises are common in the classroom, where focus is given only to the skill of silent reading (Celce-Murcia, 2001).

Audiolingual Approach

When World War II broke out in the late 1930s, the U.S. military found it necessary to train personnel how to communicate in various languages in international contexts in the most efficient manner possible. The Reading Approach's lack of focus on aural-oral skills was unsuitable for the task, so the U.S. government hired linguists to develop new curricula and to teach relevant languages. From this effort the Audiolingual Approach was born, which was based largely on principles drawn from B. F. Skinner's behavioral psychology—namely, that language is habit formation. Accordingly, learners memorize and mimic chunks of the L2. Grammatical structures are sequenced and the rules are taught inductively through the use of audio drills. Students begin by listening and speaking, and only later learn to read and write (Celce-Murcia, 2001).

Oral-Situational Approach

For the same historical pressures, linguists in Britain developed the Oral-Situational Approach, which differed only slightly from its trans-Atlantic counterpart. It

too was a reaction to the Reading Approach. Grammar and vocabulary are introduced and practiced orally in real-life situations before being presented in written form. Instruction is given in the L2 (Celce-Murcia, 2001).

These first five approaches developed more or less in response to the previous approaches due to historical, social, and political pressures. The following four, as will be shown, are based to a larger degree on internal developments within the field of language learning itself, as well as in related fields.

The Cognitive Approach

The Cognitive Approach was the result of new discoveries in the field of cognitive science, particularly through the work of Noam Chomsky who argued that language is *not* a behavioral skill (contra Skinner), but an innate ability. Consequently, the focus should be less on providing a standard set of drills in order to produce language habits, and more on the individual learners who will naturally reconstruct the L2 grammar on their own when placed in the appropriate learning environments. Grammar may be taught deductively or inductively, though perfection is not the goal; rather, mistakes are seen as learning opportunities. The instructor should not only be proficient in the L2, but should also be able to analyze the language (Celce-Murcia, 2001).

Affective-Humanistic Approach

Because the Audiolingual Approach and the Cognitive Approach did not take into account the affective and emotional factors that influence language learning, the field responded with the Affective-Humanistic Approach, which attempts to save-face for students by focusing instruction on meaningful communication, often in small groups or pairs. The language-learning environment is the most important thing, and it is the

instructor's responsibility to ensure that peer interaction and support are present in the classroom. Language-learning is understood to be a process of self-realization, and it is the instructor's role to facilitate this process. The instructor should be proficient in both the L2 and the L1 of the students since translation is often used, especially in the initial stages (Celce-Murcia, 2001).

Comprehension-Based Approach

The Comprehension-Based Approach was based primarily on the assumption that first and second language acquisition occur in the same way, which is known as the L1 = L2 Hypothesis. According to this theory, comprehension should precede production. Accordingly, the most significant factor—and therefore the central focus—of this approach, is on providing learners with comprehensible input, which is language input that is slightly above the level they are currently at (Krashen, 1982). Learners first listen to the language and respond nonverbally. Over time they will begin to speak, read, and write, but only when they are ready to do so, just as children learn their first language. Attention is given almost entirely to providing learners with opportunities to use the L2 for meaningful communication. “Error correction is seen as unnecessary and perhaps even counterproductive; the important thing is that the learners can understand and make themselves understood” (Celce-Murcia, 2001, p. 8). Proponents of this approach are careful to distinguish the terms ‘language learning’ from ‘language acquisition.’ The former is defined as “a conscious knowledge of a second language, knowing the [grammar] rules, being aware of them, and being able to talk about them,” while the latter is a process that is nearly identical to “the way children develop ability in their first language”—that is, a subconscious process that produces an implicit knowledge of the

grammar and an intuitive “feel” of the language (Krashen, 1982, p. 10). Explicit rule-learning is used only as a tool to monitor one’s output, not as a means to language acquisition (Krashen, 1982, p. 89).

Communicative Approach

Lastly, the Communicative Approach is based on the assumption that the goal of language learning is for learners to be able to communicate in the L2. Attention is given not just to linguistic structures, but also to pragmatics and social functions as learners interact and negotiate meaning by using the language in real-life situations. All four language skills (listening, speaking, reading, writing) are incorporated from the beginning. The instructor should be proficient in the L2 and be able to facilitate communication in the classroom between learners (Celce-Murcia, 2001).

It should be noted that while the Communicative Approach owes a great deal to the Comprehension-Based Approach, there is a fundamental distinction that must be maintained, and that is that the latter was based purely on a cognitive theory of language learning that did not take into account the social nature of language acquisition that subsequent research showed to be vital. As it turns out, language learning involves much more than merely an innate predisposition to acquire language when lots of comprehensible input is available. Learners will *not* reach a high level of competency under such conditions alone. The development of the Communicative Approach sought to address these key weaknesses (more on this in the next section).

Summary

To summarize, the first five approaches (Grammar-Translation, Direct, Reading, Audiolingual, Oral-Situational) developed more or less as a reaction to the previous

approaches, while the latter four approaches (Cognitive, Affective-Humanistic, Comprehension-Based, Communicative) were developed due to new theories in language learning and discoveries in cognitive science (but also somewhat in reaction to previous approaches). Celce-Murcia (2001) has provided a helpful summary of the central points of each of the last four approaches:

Cognitive Approach: language is rule-governed cognitive behavior (not habit formation). *Affective-Humanistic Approach*: learning a foreign language is a process of self-realization and of relating to other people. *Comprehension Approach*: language acquisition occurs if and only if the learner comprehends meaningful input. *Communicative Approach*: the purpose of language (and thus the goal of language teaching) is communication. (pp. 8–9, italics original)

Notice that the last four approaches that characterized the latter half of the twentieth century are all focused on getting the learners to use the language, *not* to analyze the language. The research and advances in cognitive science—most notably, Chomsky’s work—has led to an irreversible focus on language use when it comes to teaching modern languages. It should also be noted that the latter four approaches are *not* mutually exclusive. Indeed, as Celce-Murcia (2001) pointed out, an approach to language learning that combines elements from these approaches might be what is needed in the language classroom.

One final note is that different language theorists may not completely agree on the precise delineation of language teaching approaches above. Some have proposed different labels and/or variations, excluding some and including others. Pennycook (1989) highlighted six different lists, showing that no two are exactly the same (p. 602). Part of the reason for this is because there is not always a clear-cut distinction between many of the approaches/methods. Characteristics of preceding methods spill over into subsequent approaches. For example, elements of the Comprehension-Based Approach

were transmitted through the Communicative Approach and are still vital to SL teaching today. Pennycook (1989) thus highlighted the imprecise, confusing, and unhelpful nature of the concept of method that dominated the language learning scene, particularly during the 1970s and 1980s. Indeed, some were beginning to question the concept of method altogether.

The Postmethod Condition

As is clear, modern language instruction underwent numerous changes before reaching its current state. During the era of the Comprehension-Based Approach (1970s and 1980s), in particular, language theorists began producing various methods for language teaching, many of which were taught dogmatically by their creators as the “silver bullet” for acquiring languages. However, language theorizers in the late 1980s and 1990s began recognizing that these recurring pendulum swings amounted to nothing more than an endless cycle of repackaged methods (Kumaravadivelu, 1994). Indeed, Pennycook observed on a grander scale that the entire history of language teaching has been simply “a reordering of the same basic options ... to reflect the social, cultural, political, and philosophical environment” (1989, p. 600), and that none of these “basic options” were as new as they claimed to be. Consequently, Prabhu (1990) declared that “there is no best method” (p. 161), by which he meant “no single method is best for everyone” (p. 162). As it turned out, the very concept of ‘method’ was found to be fraught with both ambiguity and difficulties.

Regarding its ambiguities, Clarke (1983) noted that ‘method’ is a “label without substance” (as cited in Pennycook, 1989, p. 602), which Pennycook then expounded:

There are three important aspects to this: First, there is little agreement as to which methods existed when, and in what order; second, there is little agreement

and conceptual coherence to the terms used; and third, there is little evidence that methods ever reflected classroom reality. (1989, p. 602)

As noted above, the mere description of the history of language teaching is not completely agreed upon, precisely because of the ambiguous nature of the term “method.” When did one method end and another begin? Which methods contain overlapping features? Of course, the question that die-hard believers of particular methods inevitably find themselves asking after a period of strictly implementing their newfound “solution” is, “Why did this method not work for all my specific learners in my specific context?” These questions all reveal the ambiguity and unhelpfulness of the concept of method.

Concerning the difficulties of method, the idea that a “one-size-fits-all” approach to language learning has proved to “negate the very essence of intellectual inquiry” (Kumaravadivelu, 1994, p. 28) as each new method essentially abandoned the previous ones altogether rather than building upon them, a phenomenon that is foreign to other sciences. Pennycook (1989) likewise noted the “serious consequences that [method] has in limiting the potential of scientific investigation” (p. 597) because of its tendency to prescribe inevitably problematic solutions to a chronically recurring problem.

Kumaravadivelu (1994) aptly described this vain obsession with finding the best method as “an unending search for an unavailable solution” (p. 28). Similarly, Prabhu (1990) wrote:

If we regard our professional effort as a search for the best method which, when found, will replace all other methods, we may not only be working toward an unrealisable goal but, in the process, be misconstruing the nature of teaching as a set of procedures that can by themselves carry a guarantee of learning outcomes (p. 175).

In other words, there is no “trick” to language learning that applies to all people in all contexts all the time. Therefore, the claims of the language *theorists* of the 1970s and 1980s to have found such led countless language *practitioners* into a state of bewilderment and confusion. The language theorists of the late 1980s and 1990s quoted above rightly identified the inherent flaws in the concept of method, and thus its incapacity to form a viable framework for the complexity of language learning. Something needed to happen.

For Kumaravadivelu (1994), the only way to “salvage the situation” was to break free from the endless method-cycle by jettisoning the concept of method entirely. He claimed that the field of SL teaching had reached what he termed a “postmethod condition,” in which an entirely new framework was needed. Hence the postmethod pedagogy, which seeks to lessen the gap between theorizers and practitioners of language teaching, and to “empower practitioners to construct classroom-oriented theories of practice” (p. 29). For too long, theorizers had been creating methods in non-classroom environments and then expecting practitioners to implement them in actual classroom settings, but this usually resulted in a form of teaching that was too mechanical and artificial, or the teacher’s practice of the method did not reflect the principles contained therein, even if the practitioner had received extensive training in the method. In the same vein, Prabhu (1990) noted that when a teacher attempts to follow a prescribed set of procedures with the expectation that faithful and precise implementation of it will result in predictable success, the teaching process becomes routine and the teacher becomes disengaged from the teaching and from the learners.

Kumaravadivelu's (1994) postmethod pedagogy is shaped by three parameters that seek to involve and empower language practitioners: 1) it seeks to find an alternative to method rather than an alternative method; 2) it gives teachers the autonomy they need for effective pedagogical practices; and 3) it utilizes principled pragmatism.

First, a postmethod pedagogy recognizes the reality that there can be no one-size-fits-all approach to learning languages, no universal set of principles and procedures (let alone method), that applies to all learners in all contexts at all times. Rather, there is a particularity required for every teaching context. Kumaravadivelu (2001) stated, "Language pedagogy, to be relevant, must be sensitive to a particular group of teachers teaching a particular group of learners pursuing a particular set of goals within a particular institutional context embedded in a particular sociocultural milieu" (p. 538). In other words, teachers need to take into account the sociocultural reality that shapes the classroom. The varied experiences that learners bring to the language classroom must be considered and tapped into in a postmethod pedagogy in order for it to be effective at all. In other words, linguistic needs will only be satisfied when social needs are satisfied (p. 544).

Second, a postmethod pedagogy seeks to minimize the theory/practice dichotomy that has had harmful effects on teachers and teacher education. Often, the theorists are the knowledge "producers," while the teachers are the knowledge "consumers," but as Kumaravadivelu (2001) has pointed out, "No theory of practice can be useful and usable unless it is generated through practice" (p. 541). A postmethod pedagogy allows—indeed enables—practitioners to "devise for themselves a systematic, coherent, and relevant

alternative to method that is informed by principled pragmatism” (Kumaravadivelu, 1994, p. 31).

Third, a postmethod pedagogy, while emphasizing teacher autonomy, is also marked by principled pragmatism, which is based on the idea that theory and practice can only relate to and inform each other in the actual context of teaching. Kumaravadivelu’s concept of “principled pragmatism” derived from what Prabhu (1990) called a teacher’s “sense of plausibility,” or subjective understanding of teaching, which, when engaged in the teaching process, involves both the teacher and learner and creates a lively, productive learning environment rich with teacher-student rapport. As Hargreaves (1994) pointed out, teachers have a “powerful sense of what works and what doesn’t” (as cited in Kumaravadivelu, 2001, p. 542), and they should be encouraged and empowered to harness and employ that knowledge for their context-specific teaching purposes.

Kumaravadivelu (2001) went on to describe how a postmethod pedagogy might be actualized by the postmethod learner, the postmethod teacher, and the postmethod teacher educator. For the former two, he emphasized the need for autonomy, where learners take on learning for themselves and teachers are free to explore the pedagogic possibilities based on both research and their own experience. In fact, he stated that “teacher autonomy is so central that it can be seen as defining the heart of postmethod pedagogy” (p. 548). For the latter (i.e., teacher educator), he emphasized the need to recognize teacher’s voices and visions. As these qualities begin to characterize the respective parties involved in language learning and teaching, and as the previously mentioned parameters are followed, language teaching will enter a whole new era of improvement and effectiveness.

Kumaravadivelu's (1994) postmethod pedagogy takes all of the above into account and offers a pedagogic framework that is comprised of ten macrostrategies constituting broad guidelines—not rigid, dogmatic methods—that are open-ended in regards to their specific application, or microstrategies. In short, what Kumaravadivelu (1994, 2001, 2006), Prabhu (1990), and other theorists have proposed is a shift from a myopic, one-size-fits-all method, to a more principled and holistic approach to language teaching. Kumaravadivelu (2006) referred to this revolution in the profession as a transition from a period of awareness (pre-1990) to a period of awakening (post-1990).

The paradigm shift proposed by Kumaravadivelu (1994, 2001, 2006) and Prabhu (1990) coincided with a broader shift that had already been taking place in the field of education—a shift from behaviorism to cognitivism, from positivism to post-positivism (Jacobs and Farrell (2001). They have noted some of the contrasts between these two paradigms:

Positivism:

1. Emphasis on parts and decontextualization
2. Emphasis on separation
3. Emphasis on the general
4. Consideration only of objective and the quantifiable
5. Reliance on experts and outsider knowledge—researcher as external
6. Focus on control
7. Top-down
8. Attempt to standardize
9. Focus on the product

Post-Positivism:

1. Emphasis on whole and contextualization
2. Emphasis on integration
3. Emphasis on the specific
4. Consideration also of subjective and the non-quantifiable
5. Consideration also of the “average” participant and insider knowledge—researcher as internal
6. Focus on understanding
7. Bottom-up

8. Appreciation of diversity
9. Focus on the process as well (Jacobs & Farrell, 2001, p. 2)

This paradigm shift in the field of education helped steer the field of second language teaching away from previous methods and towards a more robust approach that is specifically characterized by eight qualities: learner autonomy, cooperative learning, curricular integration, focus on meaning, diversity, thinking skills, alternative assessment, and teachers as co-learners (Jacobs & Farrell, 2001, p. 4). The reason, they argued, that these changes took place much later in the field of second language teaching than it did in other fields was because language practitioners attempted to understand and implement these eight changes in isolation, rather than as one interconnected and holistic approach to teaching second languages (p. 2).

This broad shift in thinking has generated a number of specific changes in the way language teachers view their profession (Jacobs & Farrell, 2001). For instance, there is a greater focus on the learner rather than on the teacher and/or the method(s) (p. 3). Cognitive science has revealed the incredible capability of the human mind to acquire a language, even with less than ideal learning conditions. Consequently, learner-oriented and learning-oriented strategies have replaced the former teacher-oriented instruction. In addition, there is a greater emphasis on understanding meaning rather than on drills and rote memorization (p. 3). Along these lines, comprehending meaning is viewed from whole-to-part rather than from part-to-whole (p. 3). Another change is to view learning as a lifelong and social process rather than an individual, decontextualized process with the purpose of achieving a good grade (p. 3). Learning has become a bottom-up endeavor in which diverse students bring unique strengths to the learning environment, and these strengths are harnessed in order to enhance the learning experience for everyone

involved. This view is in contrast to a top-down approach, in which the teacher enters the learning environment with a rigid model for teaching (p. 3). These are just a few of the implications of this paradigm shift.

What many educators don't like about this change is that it requires far more work from the teacher, who cannot simply "regurgitate" material from a textbook uniformly to all students and expect learning to take place. Jacobs and Farrell (2001) quoted Oprandy (1999), who did a study on these new trends. Oprandy (1999) stated:

The communicative approach requires complexity in terms of planning and a tolerance for messiness and ambiguity as teachers analyze students' needs and design meaningful tasks to meet those needs. The pat solutions and deductive stances of audiolingual materials and pedagogy, like grammar-translation texts and syllabi preceding them, are no longer seen as sensitive to students' needs and interests. Nor are they viewed as respectful of students' intelligence to figure things out inductively through engaging problem-solving and communicative tasks. (as cited in Jacobs & Farrell, 2001, p. 3)

In other words, no single method could possibly encapsulate this new pedagogical orientation, nor could any of the previous approaches to language teaching prior to the 1990s, let alone the GT approach that preceded them. A different framework altogether was needed.

The methodology that emerged from this paradigm shift in the field of SL teaching came to be known as Communicative Language Teaching (CLT). Its fundamental goal is to develop communicative competence in all four language skills in order to prepare the learner for real world language use (Savignon, 1990).

Kumaravadelu (2006) stated that the main emphasis of CLT is "competence in terms of social interaction" (p. 60). Language is a social phenomenon, and therefore *must* be learned within a social environment. To this end, meaningful interaction in the L2 is crucial. Learners (and teachers) are encouraged to

ask for information, to seek clarification, to use circumlocution and whatever other linguistic and non-linguistic resources they could muster to negotiate meaning, to stick to the communicative task at hand, ... to take risks, to speak in other than memorized patterns. (Savignon, 2007, p. 209)

This approach thus stands in stark contrast to the traditional GT approach in particular. It fosters “creative, unpredictable, and purposeful use of language as communication” in all four language skills (Kumaravadivelu, 2006, p. 61). And communicative activities in the classroom are intended “to promote grammatical accuracy as well as communicative fluency” (p. 61). CLT quickly dominated the language teaching profession.

However, this shift towards understanding the whole meaning rather than precise control over the individual parts and explicit grammar knowledge had both benefits and drawbacks. Ironically, CLT, was soon criticized for following the same cyclical pattern that most previous teaching methods and approaches had followed: first they are proposed, then accepted, then applied, then criticized. Indeed, some theorists began raising the question whether “CLT signal[s] a meaningful and lasting reorientation of classroom language, or does it represent but yet another swing of the pedagogy pendulum?” (Savignon, 2007, p. 208). Much of the early criticism of CLT centered around two issues: “(a) the linguistic content base of CLT and (b) the pedagogical treatment of linguistic forms in CLT” (Celce-Murcia, Dörnyei, & Thurrell, 1997, p. 142).

First, the linguistic content base of CLT consisted primarily of *language functions* (e.g., agreeing, inviting, explaining) which were applied in the classroom through *language notions* (e.g., ways of expressing location, time, degree). However, this functional approach to language teaching was subsequently shown to be insufficient to account for the complexity of communicative language use in the real world, because underneath the functional syllabus lurked a grammatical syllabus organized by small

clusters of forms that made up the various language functions. The “functional syllabus” thus proved to be merely a form-focused syllabus but at the speech act level. It did not, therefore, address some crucial components of language, particularly at a higher level than mere words, phrases, and sentences. When the principles of CLT were being developed, issues such as discourse analysis, pragmatics, and sociolinguistics, among others had not received the amount of research they now have, which meant that CLT was not based on a coherent model or description of what competent language use ought to look like. What was the result? “The lack of firm linguistic guidelines led to a diversity of communicative approaches that shared only a very general common objective, namely, to prepare learners for real-life communication rather than emphasizing structural accuracy” (Celce-Murcia, Dörnyei, & Thurrell, 1997, p. 143). In short, CLT meant different things to different people. Subsequent research has attempted to remedy this problem by describing the content elements of CLT in a more comprehensive and systematic way.

Second, the pedagogical treatment of linguistic forms in CLT was seen to be insufficient in light of current research. Communicative Language Teaching developed out of a dissatisfaction with previous methods of language teaching that emphasized grammatical forms, and, consequently, produced learners who found themselves unable to communicate in the L2 when placed in an L2 context. Understandably, the field was initially skeptical of the value of explicit grammar instruction for language acquisition (Krashen, 1982). This is why the principles of CLT, as mentioned above, were based heavily on notional and social-functional aspects in order to help learners be able to communicate in the L2. However, this neglect of explicit grammar instruction was soon

shown to be naive and incapable of producing proficient L2 users. While this will be discussed in greater length below, suffice it to say that research in cognitive science, psychology, and other fields subsequently showed the value—indeed, the necessity—of explicit grammar instruction for adult learners of second languages, though only at later stages of language learning (Doughty & Williams, 1998; N. Ellis, 2005; Ellis, R., 2006).

Celce-Murcia, Dörnyei and Thurrell, therefore, suggested that CLT had reached a turning point in which more focus should be given to explicit grammar instruction. They labelled this new approach a *principled communicative approach*, as it seeks to combine the communicative classroom practice with the current research on what constitutes communicative competence. “Therefore, rather than being a complete departure from the original, indirect practice of CLT, it extends and further develops CLT methodology” (Celce-Murcia, Dörnyei, & Thurrell, 1997, p. 148).

Celce-Murcia, Dörnyei and Thurrell’s *principled communicative approach* is more or less harmonious with Kumaravadivelu’s (1994) postmethod pedagogy described above, which is also a more balanced, robust approach to language teaching than earlier methods were. Kumaravadivelu’s principled pragmatism and its list of macrostrategies, which are intended to give the teacher more freedom and power to make informed and strategic decisions about the specific teaching practices (i.e., microstrategies) employed in the classroom, are essentially the “guiding principles” that Celce-Murcia, Dörnyei and Thurrell argued that CLT was in need of. “Therefore, the concept of CLT construed as a general approach rather than a specific teaching method might be useful in providing language practitioners with some important guidelines even at the time of the postmethod condition” (Celce-Murcia, Dörnyei, & Thurrell, 1997, p. 149). This is a crucial point to

understand. CLT stands distinct from both the Comprehension-Based Approach *and* the Communicative Approach in that each of the latter two are intimately connected to the method-era described above. Communicative Language Teaching, by contrast, is *not* a method or an Approach (with a capital “A”), but rather an *orientation*, a *methodology* (not to be confused with method), or an *approach* (with a lowercase “a”) to teaching languages.

In conclusion, the field of SL teaching has entered a postmethod condition, wherein teaching practices are defined not by strict procedural methods, but by guiding principles that enable teachers to make informed and principled decisions in conjunction with their own sense of plausibility about what works in particular socio-historico-political contexts of language teaching. This creates a more realistic learning environment marked by greater rapport between teachers and students, and yet one that is grounded in research on what it means to develop true communicative competence. Before surveying the characteristic principles of this approach, a few salient terms must be defined.

Defining Terms

In light of the above discussion, it is imperative to define terms so as to avoid confusion when discussing the following summary of second language teaching principles. Celce-Murcia (2001) cited Anthony (1963) who clarified three terms that are pertinent to the discussion, yet are often confused or used erroneously: “approach,” “method,” and “technique.” While the distinctions may not be hard-and-fast, for the purposes of this paper, these definitions will be adhered to:

An approach to language teaching is something that reflects a certain model or research paradigm—a theory, if you like. This term is the broadest of the three. A *method*, on the other hand, is a set of procedures, i.e., a system that spells out rather precisely how to teach a second or foreign language. It is more specific

than an approach but less specific than a technique. Methods are typically compatible with one (or sometimes two) approaches. A *technique* is a classroom device or activity and thus represents the narrowest of the three concepts. Some techniques are widely used and found in many methods ... ; however, some techniques are specific to or characteristic of a given method. (as cited in Celce-Murcia, 2001, pp. 5–6, italics original)

Communicative Language Teaching, therefore, is an example of an approach/methodology, while an example of a method would be Total Physical Response (TPR) (Asher, 2009). Examples of techniques/classroom activities include role-playing, jigsaw, and extensive reading (described in more detail in Chapter 7).

With these definitions in mind, a summary of second language teaching principles from SLA research will now be examined in order to describe the current state of modern language instruction. The following list of principles is largely adapted from Kumaravadevelu (1994) and Jacobs and Farrell (2001). It should be noted that while there may not be a universal approach to teaching every language to every learner in every context, language acquisition is still “a basic human attribute” and thus contains certain similarities in all contexts (Prabhu, 1990, p. 166). These general principles may, therefore, be implemented directly or modified for particular socio-historico-political contexts (see Chapter 7).

A Summary of Second Language Teaching Principles Derived from SLA Research

Teach How to Use the Target Language in the Target Language

In one sense, this is the fundamental principle of second language teaching and is therefore foundational to all that follow. Indeed, in the field of modern second language teaching, it is simply assumed and therefore is not frequently or explicitly discussed at length in the current literature. However, GT does not follow this principle (as described in Chapter 3), and therefore, it must be stated up front in order to orient the reader to one

of the primary distinctions between GT and CLT. Grammar-Translation is based on the principle that language learning occurs by talking *about* the L2 in the L1, whereas CLT operates according to the principle that “we learn language by using language” (N. Ellis, 2005, p. 306). In Krashen’s (1982) words, “Language acquisition occurs when language is used for what it was designed for, communication” (p. 1). Because a teacher’s primary role is to facilitate the language acquisition process for learners, language teaching requires that instruction be executed in the target language as well. There are more descriptive and technical reasons for this that will be discussed below (see this chapter, “Utilize Implicit Instruction as Much as Possible”), but for now this principle must be understood in order to form a framework for the additional principles that follow.

Celce-Murcia, Dornyei, and Thurell’s (1997) description of CLT is helpful to demonstrate the necessity of teaching how to use the target language in the target language:

CLT highlights the primary goal of language instruction, namely, to go beyond teaching of the discrete elements, rules, and patterns of the target language and to develop the learner’s ability to take part in spontaneous and meaningful communication in different contexts, with different people, on different topics, for different purposes; that is, to develop the learner’s communicative competence. (p. 149)

Developing communicative competence requires that the learner actually *communicate* in the target language in order to accomplish some legitimate task. Therefore, instruction ought to foster the use of the target language as much as possible (see this chapter, “Facilitate Language Production via Negotiated Interaction” below).

Another benefit of using the target language to teach target language is the added provision of vast amounts of comprehensible input, which leads to much faster acquisition of the L2. Saffire (2006) has provided some enlightening anecdotal evidence:

In terms of quantity alone, it is possible to present an extraordinary amount of ancient Greek in a short time by speaking. Reading, on the other hand, is very slow in the beginning. As Peterson (87) says, “no other type of language input is as easy to process as spoken language, received through listening.” A two-minute interchange from the fourth day of my beginning Greek class is transcribed later in this chapter. During those two minutes, 155 Greek words (based on 13 lexical entries) were used by teacher and students, 149 correctly (The teacher spoke at normal conversational pace, the students much more slowly) Imagine how many Greek words could be read in two minutes by the fourth day of class. Considerably less! (Saffire, 2006, Kindle locations 2411–2414)

Using the target language for instruction simply provides more L2 input than other modes of teaching. The more time spent in the learners’ L1 is less time spent acquiring the L2.

The American Council on the Teaching of Foreign Languages (May, 2010) has provided a helpful recommendation for identifying how much one should aim to use the target language in the classroom:

Research indicates that effective language instruction must provide significant levels of meaningful communication and interactive feedback in the target language in order for students to develop language and cultural proficiency. ... ACTFL therefore recommends that language educators and their students use the target language as exclusively as possible (90% plus) at all levels of instruction during instructional time and, when feasible, beyond the classroom. (American Council on the Teaching of Foreign Languages, May, 2010)

According to the American Council on the Teaching of Foreign Languages (May, 2010), the goal for language teachers should be to maintain use of the target language at least 90 percent of the time. This allows for brief comments and/or explanations in the learners’ L1, but the *vast* majority of instructional time is spent teaching how to use the target language in the target language in order to develop language proficiency most efficiently.

This principle is true not just of language learning, but of nearly every other area of learning. For instance, a language learner cannot develop “communicative competence” without actually using the target language any more than a pianist can develop “performance competence” without actually laying his fingers on the keys.

Likewise, one cannot merely instruct a child how to ride a bike while inside and expect her to then go outside, hop on, and pedal away. Humans learn *by* doing, *by* applying, *by* constructing, *by* creating in the world around them (Hall & Verplaetse, 2000). This broader perspective on how human beings learn when engaged in constructive activities and by interacting in social contexts reflects the central tenet of what modern research terms usage-based linguistics, namely, that “language structure emerges from language use” (Tomasello, 2005, p. 5). Note, it is *not* the case that learning language structures leads to language use, such as previous “formal” theories of language learning had posited. In short, any successful approach to teaching languages must teach how to use the target language in the target language.

Utilize Implicit Instruction as Much as Possible

The need for implicit instruction can hardly be overstated. As Chomsky pointed out half a century ago, the poverty of the stimulus—that is, the insufficiency of the language input received—is utterly inadequate to account for the high level of proficiency that *all* L1 learners reach. This observation led him to conclude that the human brain is *not* merely a “blank slate” (contra Skinner), but is endowed with a natural capacity to acquire languages, given the right linguistic environment (Tomasello, 2005, p. 2; Gass, Behney, & Plonsky, 2013, pp. 160–163). While debate has ensued as to what this “natural capacity,” or set of innate properties actually is and how much of the totality of the L2 acquisition process it accounts for, its influence in L2 acquisition is undeniable, and tapping into “it” is crucial for successful language teaching. Kumaravadivelu (1994) referred to this “tapping in” as “activat[ing] intuitive heuristics” (p. 36). These intuitive heuristics aid the learner by utilizing the brain’s natural ability to acquire language when

provided with implicit instruction. Although few today claim that implicit instruction alone is sufficient for language acquisition (see this chapter, “Foster Language Awareness” below), empirical research from cognitive science shows that “the bulk of language acquisition is implicit learning from usage. Most knowledge is tacit knowledge; most learning is implicit; the vast majority of our cognitive processing is unconscious” (N. Ellis, 2005, p. 306). What, then, is implicit learning?

Implicit learning is the unconscious cognitive processing that takes place when the brain receives signals that then spark a vast and complex network of other signals, creating a “spreading activation” of interconnected thoughts in the brain. This implicit process takes place *instantaneously* and *effortlessly* (N. Ellis, 2005, p. 307). One might compare this complex process to all the intricacies that take place simultaneously in an engine in order to make a car run smoothly. Every piece and every system must work together perfectly and efficiently, yet none of these systems are directly, or “consciously,” controlled by the driver. Likewise, implicit learning is mental activity that takes place “under the hood,” as it were. It is subconscious. Krashen (1982) called this *language acquisition* and sharply distinguishes it from *language learning*. He described it as

a subconscious process. Language acquirers are not usually aware of the fact that they are acquiring language, but are only aware of the fact that they are using the target language for communication. The result of language acquisition, acquired competence, is also subconscious. We are generally not consciously aware of the rules of the languages we have acquired. Instead, we have a “feel” for correctness. Grammatical sentences “sound” right, or “feel” right, and errors feel wrong, even if we do not consciously know what rule was violated. (Krashen, 1982, p. 10)

What Krashen termed *language acquisition*, N. Ellis called *implicit learning*. Their point is that most of what human beings know is not a result of conscious learning, but

unconscious learning. What, then, does “unconscious learning” look like in a language classroom?

In order for language learning to take place “unconsciously,” the focus of instruction must be kept on *meaning*, and *not form*. While the Comprehension-Based Approach of the 1970s failed to account for the social component of language learning (it was purely cognitive), and thus could not be sustained as a legitimate theory/model for language learning in light of subsequent research, it did make important contributions to the field in this area, particularly the emphasis on comprehending meaning when teaching languages. For too long, approaches to language teaching had been characterized by explicit instruction with focused attention on grammatical forms, but these approaches did (and do) not lead to efficient acquisition of the target language. Jacobs and Farrell (2001) stated:

Research from cognitive psychology tells us that we learn best when we connect and store information in chunks. While rote drills and memorization might be of benefit for short-term learning, long-term learning and the extension of the learning require that students focus on the meaning of the language they are using. (p. 8)

When new knowledge is “chunked” and combined with existing knowledge to form new pathways in one’s brain, it results in a more robust and longer-lasting knowledge. Rules of the language are acquired intuitively and naturally. Shaffer (1989), for instance, has conclusively shown that when learners are required to self-discover rather than being presented with explicit information, they experience greater comprehension and retention (as cited in Kumaravadivelu, 1994, p. 36). The Comprehension-Based Approach, the Communicative Approach, and CLT all prioritize comprehension of meaning in the

language teaching process, but how does one comprehend meaning in a language he/she does not yet understand?

According to Krashen's (1982) input hypothesis, in order for a learner to progress from his current level of language (i) to the next level ($i + 1$), he must be provided language input that is just above his level of comprehension. That is, he understands *most* of the input, and can derive the meaning of that part which he does not from the context. In Krashen's words, "a necessary (but insufficient) condition to move from stage i to stage $i + 1$ is that the acquirer understand input that contains $i + 1$, where 'understand' means that the acquirer is focused on the meaning and not the form of the message" (p. 21). The human mind is masterful at comprehending meaning from whatever scarcity of clues it is given, even if they are non-linguistic. "We also use context, our knowledge of the world, our extra-linguistic information to help us understand language directed at us" (p. 21). By focusing on meaning, learners not only fulfill their communicative purposes, but they also establish implicit knowledge of the linguistic forms as a by-product. In Krashen's (1982) words:

Our assumption has been that we first learn structures, then practice using them in communication, and this is how fluency develops. The input hypothesis says the opposite. It says we acquire by 'going for meaning' first, and as a result, we acquire structure!" (p. 21)

In other words, languages ought to be taught (primarily) implicitly from whole to part, with a focus on comprehending meaning the entire time. Perhaps Jacobs & Farrell (2001) stated it most clearly:

In communicative language teaching, the focus lies in using language, not in language use (Breen & Candlin, 1980; Widdowson, 1978). Even though recent years have seen a greater role for explicit grammar instruction, this explicit instruction still takes place within the context of whole texts, i.e., beginning with an understanding of the text and its communicative intent, then looking at how the

grammar aids the accomplishment of that intent within the specific context from which that intent derived (Long, 1991). (Jacobs & Farrell, 2001, p. 8)

The reason why focusing on meaning via implicit instruction is so crucial is because language is a highly complex activity that includes both bottom-up and top-down processes (Perfetti, 1985, as cited in Hudson, 2007, pp. 50–51). Bottom-up processing involves “[constructing] meaning from letters, words, phrases, clauses, and sentences, by processing the text into phonemic units that represent lexical meaning, and then builds meaning in a linear manner” (Hudson, 2007, p. 33). Top-down processing begins with an expectation of a text’s meaning via background knowledge, discourse structure, literary genre, etc. and works down to the text level, but only as far as needed to either confirm or reject that anticipated meaning, creating somewhat of a “psycholinguistic guessing game” (Goodman, 1976). By itself, bottom-up processing is severely insufficient to enable one to read, but when combined with top-down processing, the entire process is *much* more efficient because the reader does not rely as heavily on every minute aspect of the printed text for comprehending meaning (Hudson, 2007; Scovel, 1998).

If lower-level processes are not automatized, then higher-level processes will not be able to engage and contribute to comprehension. Or, as Bernhardt (1991) put it, “Readers who do not have automatic processing are doomed to fretful decoding with little effort left over for trying to understand a message” (as cited in McCaffrey, 2006, Kindle location 1689). Pressley (1998) has elaborated on this important concept:

[D]ecoding and comprehension compete for available short-term [memory] capacity. When a reader slowly analyzes a word into component sounds and blends them, a great deal of capacity is consumed, with relatively little left over for comprehension of the word, let alone understanding the overall meaning of the sentence containing the word and the paragraph containing the sentence. In contrast, automatic word recognition...consumes very little capacity, and thus, frees short-term capacity for the task of comprehending the word and integrating

the meaning of the word with the overall meaning of the sentence, paragraph, and text. (as cited in Grabe and Stoller, 2002, p. 21)

The importance of automatizing the lower-level processes for fluent reading cannot be overstated (Grabe 2004, 2010; Schultz, 2016, November 16). Grabe (2010) has summarized the issue well:

Many reading skills—automatic word recognition, a large recognition vocabulary, skilled grammatical processing, and the formation of basic meaning proposition units for reading comprehension—only emerge as an outcome of implicit learning (rather than explicit learning of aspects of language knowledge)” (p. 73).

Hence the importance of utilizing implicit instruction as much as possible.

These two ideas—*implicit* language acquisition and *explicit* language learning—are thus rightly distinguished, and the former ought to dominate L2 teaching. However, much research in the last couple decades has been consumed with addressing the question of whether or not there is any interaction between these two types of knowledge (N. Ellis, 2005), and if so, what is the role of explicit instruction in a CLT approach (Hulstijn, 2005; Ellis, R., 2006)? This leads to the next principle.

Foster Language Awareness

In light of the previous principle, it would be easy to conclude that explicit grammar teaching has no place in language instruction. Current research, however, precludes such an assessment and supports the value of fostering language awareness. In short, language awareness is meant to draw learners’ attention to formal properties of the L2, which can serve to accelerate learning, increase the level of linguistic competence, and prevent fossilization, or stabilization, from occurring (Kumaravadivelu, 1994, p. 37; Doughty & Williams, 1998; Spada & Lightbown, 2008). Still, the role of explicit grammar teaching in the acquisition process has been one of the most controversial

aspects of SLA. R. Ellis (2006) has commented that “Most SLA researchers agree that competence in an L2 is primarily a matter of implicit knowledge. ... Whether there is any value in teaching explicit knowledge of grammar has been and remains one of the most controversial issues in teaching grammar” (pp. 95–96).

Krashen (1982) contended that explicit knowledge of grammar does not aid one’s acquisition of the language, a view known as the *noninterface* position (i.e., explicit and implicit knowledge do not interact). However, later theorists began noticing that Krashen’s naturalistic/indirect approach to teaching failed to produce linguistically competent L2 users, which led them to believe that implicit instruction is necessary but insufficient for adult SL learning (Doughty & Williams, 1998; Ellis, R., 2006). Spada and Lightbown (2008) helpfully explained:

SLA research shows that some linguistic features are acquired *incidentally*, that is, without intentional effort or conscious awareness by learners or guidance from teachers. However, it is also evident that some language features develop very slowly, or not at all, in the absence of guided attention and that some types of [form-focused instruction] can increase the likelihood that learners will make progress in learning these features. (p. 194, italics original)

In other words, while implicit knowledge does account for the vast majority of language learning, “nevertheless ... many aspects of a second language are unlearnable—or at best are acquired very slowly—from implicit processes alone” (N. Ellis, 2005, p. 307).

Hulstijn (2005) argued that the added role of explicit learning was the key distinction between L2 acquisition and L1 acquisition, the latter of which consists almost entirely of implicit learning. Gass, Behney, and Plonsky (2013) likewise pointed out that language awareness in the form of negative evidence (i.e., the explicit stating of what cannot be said in an L2) is essential for adult learners to fully acquire the L2 (pp. 360, 362, 375, 410).

Why this sudden shift in thinking from the early days of CLT when explicit grammar teaching was shunned? Celce-Murcia, Dörnyei, and Thurrell (1997) identified the reason for this shift in thinking among the profession:

Many CLT proponents neglected linguistic competence and accepted the premise that linguistic form emerges on its own as a result of learners' engaging in communicative activities. As Schmidt (1991) summarizes in his critique of CLT, "a general principle of CLT is that language learners gain linguistic form by seeking situational meaning, that is, the linguistic form is learned incidentally rather than as a result of focusing directly on linguistic form" (p. 1.2.2). However, this argument from CLT is not in accordance with the principles of cognitive psychology. (as cited in Celce-Murcia, Dörnyei, & Thurrell, 1997, p. 145)

It was the development of research in fields such as cognitive psychology, neurobiology, and psycholinguistics that has provided linguists with a greater understanding as to what is going on in the brain during the learning process. Specifically, it has been shown that explicit knowledge and implicit knowledge do indeed interact with one another (contra Krashen).

N. Ellis (2005), for instance, stated that, "implicit and explicit learning are dissociable but cooperative" (p. 305). He further claimed that "a wide range of empirical research over the last 30 years ... demonstrates that language acquisition can be speeded by explicit instruction" (p. 307). It may take hundreds, or even thousands of exposures (or instantiations) of a particular word or structure before it is thoroughly acquired through natural language learning. Providing a brief explanation of a word or grammatical structure may bypass this long and inefficient process, assuming the explanation is still embedded in a communicative context.

According to N. Ellis (2005), "At any one time, our state of mind reflects complex dynamic interactions of implicit and explicit knowledge" (p. 313). When language is being used fluently, "Our implicit systems automatically process the input,

allowing our conscious selves to concentrate on the meaning rather than the form” (p. 308), but when there is a glitch in this fluent processing—a stuttering of speech, an unfamiliar word, an awkward phrase, complicated poetic language—our explicit systems become more highly engaged in order to assist our comprehension of meaning. These explicit systems may include drilled patterns, conjugations, declensions, mnemonics, and other metalinguistic pedagogical guides that have been memorized previously (N. Ellis, 2005, pp. 328, 330). Specifically *at later levels of proficiency*, “Learners can utilize this metalinguistic knowledge at points of dysfluency—when they do not yet have the implicit fluent knowledge, when they cannot access a low-frequency form, or when ... they monitor their own erroneous output” (p. 330). This, then, can open the pathway to “resume” implicit, fluent, unconscious processing.

In addition to helping when fluency fails, N. Ellis (2005) explained another benefit of explicit knowledge:

Compared to the vast number of unconscious neural processes happening in any given moment, conscious capacity evidences a very narrow bottleneck. However, the narrow limits of consciousness have a compensating advantage: Consciousness seems to act as a gateway, creating access to essentially any part of the nervous system. Consciousness creates global access. (p. 312)

What N. Ellis was saying is that although conscious knowledge is slow and inefficient, it may serve to trigger other parts of the brain’s neural pathways that will aid the language user in ways that implicit knowledge alone could not do in order to comprehend meaning in certain contexts.

Why is this research into cognitive psychology, neurobiology, and psycholinguistics significant for the principle at hand? It ultimately comes down to the central role of *attention* in L2 learning, which Gass, Behney, and Plonsky (2013) defined

as “the orientation of mental powers; the way we focus on and process elements of our surroundings” (p. 520). At points of disfluency (e.g., unknown word), when one’s implicit processor has failed, attention is immediately drawn to the unknown aspect of the language. This is a crucial moment for acquisition, since it is then that conscious resources become more engaged in the mental processing. As N. Ellis (2005) stated, “Input functions as intake to the learning of higher-level L2 material when you experience comprehension problems that are perceived as deficits in your knowledge structure rather than in the input” (p. 316). These “deficits of knowledge” must be noticed, or brought to one’s conscious attention, so that it can be processed via other, more explicit means and then stored in long-term memory. This is the basic idea behind Schmidt’s (1990) noticing hypothesis (as cited in Ellis, R., 2006). According to Schmidt, comprehensible input is not enough for learners to learn all the linguistic cues contained therein; rather, learners’ attention *must* be concentrated on particular L2 forms via attention to form (i.e., language awareness). In other words, comprehensible *input* does not become comprehensible *intake* until particular forms are noticed, or brought to one’s conscious attention (Gass, Behney, & Plonsky, 2013, p. 265). Doughty and Williams (1998) likewise contended that drawing explicit attention to some forms is necessary to “[engage] the cognitive processing ability of the learners” (p. 205). In short, if L2 learners do not actively attend to forms, learning will not take place (Gass, Behney, & Plonsky, 2013, p. 265).

Part of the reason for this reality is that comprehension of language comes from many different sources, not just linguistic cues. For example, previous background knowledge, pragmatic cues, sociolinguistic cues (e.g., members of different castes may

speak to one another in specific ways), and, as is often the case with the biblical languages, one's knowledge of the English text, can all narrow the options, or even determine the meaning of any given phrase in a particular context. However, even among linguistic cues, the human mind automatically hones in on the most salient cues, often overlooking other cues that are just as much a part of the L2 system. In fact, learners "might never get around to noticing low-salience cues, particularly when the interpretation accuracy afforded by the other more obvious cues does well enough for everyday communicative survival" (N. Ellis, 2005, p. 323). One example of this would be the relatively minor morphological inflection of a particular verb form going unnoticed due to the more explicit time marker (an adverb, for instance) or the explicit pronoun associated with the verb. Consequently, many cues are never absorbed into the learner's L2 system.

In N. Ellis' (2005) words, "The remedy is to bring the issue into the light of consciousness" (p. 324). By fostering language awareness, learners are able to make the connection between linguistic cues and their meaning, which leads to more awareness of the cue in subsequent input and output processing. Once forms have been brought to attention, then much more input is helpful for solidifying that form in the learner's mind. This is true particularly among more proficient learners.

It has been definitively proven that some form of language awareness, explicit instruction, or grammar teaching, is necessary for adult L2 learners to attain high levels of linguistic competence. R. Ellis (2006) has defined grammar teaching as

any instructional technique that draws learners' attention to some specific grammatical form in such a way that it helps them either to understand it metalinguistically and/or process it in comprehension and/or production so that they can internalize it. (p. 84)

Within a CLT framework, this drawing of learner's attention to specific forms has variously been labeled "consciousness raising" (Rutherford, 1987, as cited in Kumaravadivelu, 1994), "Focus on Form" (contra "Focus on FormS") (Long, 1991, as cited in Ellis, R., 2006), "input enhancement" (Sharwood Smith, 1991, as cited in Kumaravadivelu, 1994), "language awareness" (Kumaravadivelu, 1994), and "form-focused instruction" (Spada & Lightbown, 2008). All of these concepts represent viable and helpful ways to teach grammar forms within a communicative context. The natural questions, then, become which grammar forms should be taught, and when, and how?

First, regarding *which* grammar forms should be taught, it is certainly the case that not every form should be attended to in the same manner or to the same degree. To reiterate, much L2 grammar can and should be taught implicitly, because implicit instruction results in much faster processing, and "learners are clearly capable of learning a substantial amount of the L2 grammar without [explicit] instruction" (R. Ellis, 2006, p. 88). In the context of fostering language awareness, however, the most immediate and obvious suggestion when determining which forms to focus on is to choose the forms that prove to be the most difficult for comprehension and/or production (i.e., meaningful communication) (Doughty & Williams, 1998), or that are known to cause errors in learners' interlanguage (Ellis, R., 2006).

The concept of interlanguage is important in SLA studies. Gass, Behney, and Plonsky (2013) explained:

The basic assumption in SLA research is that learners create a language system, known as an interlanguage (IL). This system is comprised of numerous elements, not the least of which are elements from the NL [i.e., native language] and the [target language]. There are also elements in the IL that do not have their origin in either the NL or the [target language]. What is important is that the *learners*

themselves impose structure on the available linguistic data and formulate an internalized system (IL). (p. 11, italics added)

Two ideas are important here. First, the language that nonnative learners produce is *not* the L2. Rather, it is a new system that is based on L2 input but also influenced by other factors including, but not limited to, the learner's L1. It is the linguistic structures in learners' interlanguage which deviate from the L2 that Doughty and Williams (2008) and R. Ellis (2006) have argued require Focus on Form instruction. A second key concept is that learners construct a language system in their minds based on the available linguistic data—that is, L2 input. This is another reason why the target language *must* be taught in the target language; otherwise, learners will be deprived of the L2 linguistic information their minds need to hypothesize about how the L2 works. If they only receive a description of the L2 in the L1, then their interlanguage will differ drastically from the L2.

However, it can still be a challenge to choose which structures are “easy” and which are “difficult”—that is, they tend to cause errors in learners' interlanguage—because it depends on a number of factors. Even once criteria have been established for this classification, the question still remains whether to teach the difficult structures and allow learners to acquire the easy ones with continued input, or to teach the easy forms since they are likely to form the foundation for the acquisition of more difficult ones. Doughty and Williams (1998) suggested that, “When class time is limited, but input is available, learners can be left to discover certain [easier] rules on their own, and teachers can concentrate on guiding learners to acquiring more difficult ones” (p. 225). This requires time, experience, and attention to learner errors.

Next, concerning *when* to teach grammar forms, Doughty and Williams (1998) discussed whether it is more helpful to be *proactive* or *reactive* in focusing on form. The question here is whether the teacher should plan in advance to focus on particular forms (proactive) or to wait until consistent errors emerge during learners' use of the L2 and then to focus on those forms (reactive). Long (1991, as cited in Doughty & Williams, 1998, p. 205) apparently had in mind a reactive position when he envisioned the concept of Focus on Form, and it is this position that seems to be most harmonious with the overall CLT approach. Both positions, however, may be helpful, depending on the context and learning situation. Doughty and Williams (1998) have pointed out the benefits and challenges of each position:

Reactive focus on form involves developing the ability to notice pervasive errors and have at the ready techniques for drawing learners' attention to them. On the other hand, proactive focus on form emphasizes the design of tasks that ensure that opportunities to use problematic forms while communicating a message will indeed arise. (p. 211)

In other words, merely waiting for difficult structures to arise before addressing them with Focus on Form techniques does not guarantee that all of the difficult or "problematic" structures will actually arise. Doughty and Williams, therefore, opted for a proactive stance that plans to attend to particular forms during class instruction.

Lastly, regarding *how* to teach grammar forms, the question is whether to teach grammar forms in isolation or integrated into communicative activities? Long's primary purpose for developing the concept of Focus on Form was to distinguish his view of grammar instruction from the traditional view, which he termed 'Focus on FormS.'

Doughty and Williams (1998) explained the difference:

Language use tends to be of two types—highly skilled and effortless versus halting and deliberate. The processes by which deliberate language use can be

automatized are far from well known. However, it is already clear that the starting point for discovering them is the distinction between *focus on form* and *focus on formS*, the latter entailing the well-known pitfall that too much attention to form results in deliberate rather than automatic language use. Long's operationalization of focus on form is an attempt to draw a line between traditional grammar teaching and [Focus on Form] instruction, which is integrated into communication-oriented instruction. (p. 229)

This distinction between Focus on Form and Focus on FormS is maintained by virtually all language theorists today. Its importance cannot be underscored enough. R. Ellis (2006), for instance, explained that Focus on FormS involves “a structure-of-the-day approach, where the students’ primary focus is on form (i.e., accuracy) and where the activities are directed intensively at a single grammatical structure” (p. 100), while Focus on Form emphasizes the meaning and only attends to the form when it arises out of the communicative activity (p. 101). Kumaravadivelu (1994) further expounded on the fundamental differences between Focus on Form—that is, language awareness (LA)—and traditional grammar teaching:

The concept of LA treats grammar as a network of systems to be interacted with rather than a body of structures to be mastered. ... The traditional grammar teaching is teacher-oriented, linear, and hierarchical; LA-based teaching is learner oriented, cyclic, and holistic. Grammar-based strategies emphasize memory, specific rules, and rule articulation; LA-based strategies emphasize understanding, general principles, and operational experience. (p. 37)

Gass, Behney, and Plonsky (2013) succinctly explained that Focus on Form refers to “a need for meaning-focused activity into which an attention to form is embedded,” while Focus on FormS refers to “earlier teaching methodologies in which the main organizing principle for language classrooms was the accumulation of individual language items (e.g., plural endings, passives)” (p. 407). In other words, the basic idea of language awareness is to facilitate form-meaning connections by drawing attention to linguistic forms in the context of real, meaningful communication. This form of language

awareness is clearly different from traditional approaches to grammar teaching, such as GT.

Doughty and Williams (1998) likewise argued that linguistic forms should *not* be taught in isolation—that is, devoid of any communicative and meaningful context. At the same time, they acknowledge that some degree of explicit segmentation is inherent in the very notion of Focus on Form. This highlights the potentially fuzzy line between Focus on Form and Focus on FormS that may occur, for instance, if too much attention is given to the linguistic feature at hand without integrating it into a communicative activity. Accordingly, they emphasized the absolute necessity for *form* to be connected with *meaning*.

The aim of [Focus on Form] tasks and techniques is to engage learner attention to facilitate more effective noticing of these form-function-meaning relationships. To achieve this, learner attention must be engaged at some point for a communicative purpose, either immediately or eventually. (p. 245)

By integrating attention to form within a communicative context, less attentional resources are required to process the linguistic information, and the form being focused on will be quickly engaged in further mental processes and ultimately encoded into long-term memory (pp. 248–249). Similarly, Long (1991) stated that Focus on Form “overtly draws students’ attention to linguistic elements as they arise incidentally in lessons *whose overriding focus is on meaning or communication*” (as cited in Gass, Behney, & Plonsky, 2013, p. 407, italics added). While some would disagree over Long’s use of “incidentally” in the preceding quote, arguing that a more deliberate approach is necessary (e.g., Spada & Lightbown, 2008), the key idea is that the form-meaning connection is essential.

Doughty and Williams (1998) have proposed two viable models for integrating form and meaning. The first model entails “brief, explicit instruction of formal knowledge” followed by “[Focus on Form] activities with signals and brief interventions” (p. 250). In other words, a particular form is introduced, and then immediately used in communicative activities, or vice versa (Spada & Lightbown, 2008, p. 186). An example of such *intensive* instruction is the traditional *present-practice-produce* (PPP) model of teaching grammar. The idea behind this is that if students can practice a new form or structure enough, then it will eventually become automatized. It’s a “practice makes perfect” mentality. One concept should be presented at a time and students should master that concept before moving to the next (i.e., “rifle” approach). Intensive instruction can also help learners crystallize their understanding of forms they have already learned to some extent through implicit means.

In the second model, “Attention to form and meaning [are] integrated at all times, with or without explicit instruction” (Doughty & Williams, 1998, p. 250). Examples of such *extensive* instruction include highlighting a particular word or grammatical construction while reading a text (explicit), or asking for a confirmation check that requires the learner to rethink a misspoken phrase (implicit). One advantage of *extensive* instruction is that a teacher can cover much more of the L2 grammar than she can with an intensive instruction approach. The reason is because teachers can address specific questions regarding various grammar topics raised by learners in the context of teaching (i.e., “shotgun” approach). This way, the teacher does not waste time on information learners may already comprehend.

It seems that incorporating a cyclical combination of both intensive and extensive grammar instruction is the most effective way to foster language awareness. While intensive instruction may help with the understanding of complex grammatical structures, learners certainly need to receive instruction on the breadth of grammar topics that will inevitably surface through the course of study. The class, therefore, needs some level of extensive instruction as well.

Of course, the danger of form-focused instruction lies in the potential for teachers to teach too much explicit grammar, and/or in isolation from meaningful contexts, and thereby revert back to a focus on getting learners to analyze the language, but that is *not* what these theorists are arguing for. Spada and Lightbown (2008) made this clear:

We find no evidence to support a suggestion that isolated grammar lessons without opportunities for communicative language use should again become the dominant approach to language instruction. Isolated lessons are a starting point or a follow-up for communicative or content-based activities. (p. 201)

It is thus beyond question that the Focus on Form being advocated here is not a remnant of older methods of grammar instruction (namely, GT). Rather, fostering language awareness is a principle that is fully in keeping with the SLA research, since it takes place within, or closely connected to, communicative activities where the primary focus is on meaning and the bulk of learning still takes place implicitly.

Facilitate Language Production Via Negotiated Interaction

The role of speaking in language acquisition was not always viewed as important as it is now. Krashen (1982), for instance, so emphasized the role of comprehensible *input* that he neglected the role of *output*, except as an indirect way to elicit more input from others (p. 60). He even went so far as to state, “It is, in fact, theoretically possible to

acquire language without ever talking” (p. 60)! However, both current research and experience seem to counter this claim.

For example, Swain (1985, 1995) recognized the necessary role of language production in her output hypothesis, which had a massive influence on the field of SLA. According to Swain, output offers three learning functions: 1) a noticing function, which is necessary for adult language learners; 2) a hypothesis testing function, which may attract feedback leading to a re-processing of linguistic data and restructuring of one’s interlanguage; and 3) a reflective metalinguistic function, which allows the learner to control and internalize linguistic knowledge. Hall & Verplaetse (2000) expounded on these three functions:

During the time that a learner is required to process input only, he or she may not need to attend to all features of language to comprehend the content. However, at the point when he or she must produce output, the learner may first notice that a gap of linguistic knowledge exists between what he or she wants to convey and his or her ability to convey it. When the learner attempts production, using what linguistic knowledge is currently available in his or her interlanguage, the learner tests out hypotheses about the organization of the language system. Finally, through the learner’s output and the interlocutor’s response to that output, the learner can reflect on and ultimately modify his or her language use. (p. 4)

In other words, it is only by output—whether speaking or writing—that one is able to find out what he *really* knows of the language. The moment he opens his mouth to speak, for example, it becomes immediately apparent what aspects of the language have truly been acquired and what gaps there are in the interlanguage. Kumaravadivelu (1994) similarly argued that “production, as opposed to comprehension, may very well be the trigger that forces learners to pay attention to form, to the relationship between form and meaning, and to the overall means of communication” (p. 34). It is easy to assume one

truly knows a language until she is required to open her mouth and speak. In doing so, it pushes her to a higher level of language control.

Another—perhaps more important—function that output has is that it “may force the learner to move from semantic processing to syntactic processing” (Swain, 1985, p. 249). Why is this the case? As discussed above (see this chapter, “Utilize Implicit Instruction as Much as Possible”), one can often comprehend input via other language cues without the use of syntax (Gass, Behny, & Plonsky, 2013, p. 356). The semantic meaning of words combined with knowledge of the real world is usually enough to convey meaning. For example, take the following list of words: lunch, I, for, yesterday, sandwich, eat, a. No matter what order these words are presented in, a proficient English speaker could construct the following sentence with little effort: I ate a sandwich for lunch yesterday. How does one know “eat” should have been “ate”? Because of the explicit time marker “yesterday.” But if one were required to speak this sentence, she is forced to put the words in a particular syntactic order and to inflect the words in some way. This pushes the learner to convey her intended message in a way that is comprehensible to her listeners. This theory is called comprehensible output. Swain (1995) explained:

Output may stimulate learners to move from the semantic, open-ended, non-deterministic, strategic processing prevalent in comprehension to the complete grammatical processing needed for accurate production. Output, thus, would seem to have a potentially significant role in the development of syntax and morphology. (p. 128)

Because of the important role of speaking the target language, students must be given numerous opportunities to produce the language if they are to reach a high level of language competence.

The combination of comprehensible input and comprehensible output, along with the feedback one receives from this communicative exchange, creates interaction in the target language. Types of interaction include negotiation of meaning when communication breaks down, recasts (rephrasing a statement for clarification), requests (“Can you tell me...?”), reacting, turn taking, clarification requests (“What did you say?”), confirmation checks (“Do you mean...?”), and comprehension checks (“Do you understand what I’m saying?”) (Gass, Behny, & Plonsky, 2013, p. 349–350).

Kumaravadivelu (1994) has cited overwhelming evidence to suggest that negotiated interaction is a catalyst for comprehension and production. Therefore, language classes should be teeming with both student-teacher *and* student-student interaction in the L2. The teacher should *not* be the only one talking in a CLT classroom, nor should interaction be limited to teacher-student interaction, since this means only one person in the class is speaking at any given time. Rather, teachers should facilitate authentic language production via negotiated interaction among and between learners.

Integrate Language Skills

The four language skills are traditionally identified as speaking, listening, reading, and writing. Historically, various approaches to language teaching have tended to highlight certain skills over others, depending on the overall goal of the approach (see “A History of Second Language Teaching” in both Chapters 3 and 4), yet current research suggests that all four language skills should not only be learned, but integrated from the very beginning of instruction (Hinkel, 2006). Kumaravadivelu (1994) plainly stated that, “All available empirical, theoretical, and pedagogical information points to the need to integrate language skills for effective language teaching” (p. 39). It is not uncommon in

language classes to begin teaching the students the skill of listening, followed by speaking, then reading, and lastly writing. However, Kumaravadivelu suggested that this is due “more for logistical reasons than for logical reasons” (p. 39). To isolate and sequence the four language skills as the basic organizing principle for a curriculum serves to deconstruct the integrative nature of language, and may even hinder the acquisition process. Kumaravadivelu has explained:

Skill separation is in fact a remnant of the audiolingual era and has very little empirical or theoretical justification. It is a pedagogical artifact that has been shown to be inadequate for developing integrated functional skills (Swaffar, Arens, & Morgan, 1982; Titone, 1985). Its inadequacy arises because language skills are essentially interrelated and mutually reinforcing. Fragmenting them into manageable, atomistic items runs counter to the parallel and interactive nature of language and language behavior” (as cited in Kumaravadivelu, 1994, p. 39).

It should be noted that the integration of all four skills from the beginning is one distinction between L1 and L2 learning. For L1 learning, the natural sequence of development for these skills is listening, speaking, reading, then writing, but this is because infant/child cognitive capabilities are not fully developed, nor do they already possess an L1 to aid in the acquisition of L2 (via language transfer). Early approaches to language teaching that adhered to the L1 = L2 Hypothesis of language learning, presented the four skills in the above sequence, advocating for a “silent period,” wherein learners develop listening skills before attempting to speak (Krashen, 1982). In this view, “Speaking ability emerges on its own after enough competence has been developed by listening and understanding” (p. 27). However, this does not take into account the fact that adult L2 learners approach the task with a fully-developed brain, complete with a robust language system already in operation, and, for those who are literate, with the cognitive awareness that written words represent actual realities in the real world. They

do not have to make the cognitive steps from hearing to speaking to reading to writing, as do children. Consequently, if the four skills are mutually reinforcing, and adult literate L2 learners have the cognitive capacity to acquire all four skills simultaneously, then all four skills should be incorporated from the very beginning of the language learning process. What role do each of these skills play in the language learning process?

Concerning listening, Vandergrift (2004) argued that comprehending aural input at a fluent rate of speech increases one's automatic word recognition and frees up one's working memory to attend to other aspects of the language. "Listeners with more language knowledge (and more automated processes) have more room in working memory to retain all information and make necessary revisions or inferences as they listen" (p. 6). A key way to increase learners' automaticity, and thereby freeing up working memory, is by developing their phonological loop, which can only happen through listening. Even if one's ultimate goal is to read a text, learning to hear the language spoken at a normal rate of speech increases one's ability to recognize and comprehend words immediately. It also allows one to interact in the L2, which leads to greater syntactic processing and language control (Swain, 1985), thereby benefitting one's reading ability.

The role of speaking has already been discussed at length (see the section "Facilitate Language Production via Negotiated Interaction" above). However, one additional note to make is that listening and speaking might potentially be labeled as the *sin quo non* of language knowledge, without which one cannot truly claim to know a language. Pinker (2010), for instance, described a situation in the 1920s where Michael Leahy, an Australian prospector in search of gold, discovered a stone age people in the

highlands of New Guinea who had been isolated from the rest of the world for as long as anyone could tell. Surprisingly, however, this indigenous people group possessed a fully-functioning language that was just as sophisticated as any other “modern” language. As it turned out, this particular language was only one of eight hundred languages that would be discovered in that region over the next fifty years. Accordingly, Pinker stated that “No mute tribe has ever been discovered” (Pinker, 2010, p. 13), but each one of them possesses a fully-formed, robust language. This reality leads linguists to believe in the “universality of complex language.” In Pinker’s (2010) words, “There are Stone Age societies, but there is no such thing as a Stone Age language. ... Edward Sapir wrote, ‘When it comes to linguistic form, Plato walks with the Macedonian swineherd, Confucius with the headhunting savage of Assam’” (Sapir, 1921, as cited in Pinker, 2010, p. 14). However, while no mute people group has ever been discovered, there are numerous people groups with no *written* language whose people, consequently, cannot read or write. Similarly, one needs only to consider the human race before the development of writing (fourth millennium BC)—listening and speaking form the core of how human beings communicate with one another, and it has been this way since the beginning of time.

While listening and speaking are absolutely indispensable to language learning, reading and writing also play an important role, and for many of the same reasons as listening and speaking. That is, both listening and reading are considered modes of input, while speaking and writing are both modes of output. The benefits of both input (Krashen, 1982) and output (Swain, 1985, 1995) have already been discussed. Nation (2007) emphasized the fact that both input and output must be meaning-focused in order

for learning to occur, and argued that each of the skills ought to be integrated throughout the course of instruction.

Because most adult L2 learners are already literate in their L1 (unlike child L1 learners), L1 reading and writing skills can transfer to L2 literacy skills. Interestingly, however, studies show that learners must first possess a certain level of proficiency (i.e., listening and speaking) in the L2 before L1 literary skills (i.e., reading and writing) begin to transfer (Alderson, 1984; Eisterhold, 1990). This provides yet more support not only for the necessity of listening and speaking the target language, but for the integrative nature of all four skills within language learning.

Hinkel (2006) has stated that “in an age of globalization, pragmatic objectives of language learning place an increased value on integrated and dynamic multiskill instructional models with a focus on meaningful communication and the development of learners’ communicative competence” (p. 113). She thus discusses the integration of language skills from a pedagogical standpoint, showing the advantages of holistic approach to language teaching that “follows the principles of the communicative approach” (p. 113). In real world communication, she contends, people use multiple language skills in the same context; therefore, instruction ought to reflect that integration in order to prepare learners for it.

Maintain Curricular Integration

Language teaching should not be isolated from other subjects of teaching, particularly teaching on the L2 culture (Kumaravadivelu, 1994). Jacobs and Farrell (2001) pointed out that

when various subject areas are taught jointly, learners have more opportunities to see the links between subject areas ... [and] develop a stronger grasp of subject

matter, a deeper purpose for learning and a greater ability to analyze situations in a holistic manner. (p. 6)

The more connected the language is with other areas of learners' knowledge, the more robust the knowledge system will be. While a full-fledged immersion education program may not be necessary or realistic in many contexts, an increasingly popular method to teaching second languages is called Content-Based Instruction (CBI), which integrates both language and content, using "language as a medium for learning content, and content as a resource for learning language" (Stoller & Grabe, 1997, p. 78). This integration, however, proves to be both helpful and difficult. According to Snow (2001), one of the greatest challenges to CBI is trying to find the right balance between content teaching and language instruction. What does CBI look like practically?

While Content-Based Instruction has taken on many forms over the years, Stoller (2002) offers three distinctives that she believes ought to characterize a CBI course. First, CBI should promote the acquisition of non-language knowledge, not just language knowledge. To this end, learners must be exposed to various sources of content (not just a single textbook, for instance), must revisit content for different purposes, and must synthesize information that originates from different sources. Second, CBI should promote the development of expertise in order to prepare learners for engagement in other subject areas. Third, the CBI class should be seamless and coherent in its flow, primarily between themes throughout the course.

In order to ensure such course coherence, Stoller (2002) follows the Six-T's approach, a model of CBI suggested by Stoller and Grabe (1997). The six T's are: themes, texts, topics, threads, tasks, and transitions. One must begin with the themes that will be covered in the course. Sometimes the themes will be determined by the text(s)

used, and sometimes the text(s) will be determined by the themes that need to be covered (usually there is more than one theme in the course of a semester). Either way, these two are generally interrelated. The topics are then chosen based on the themes. Topics are subunits that will be covered throughout each theme. Threads link the various topics and themes by requiring students to process the information in different ways and make connections between them, which provides a sense of coherence throughout the course. They are often recurring in order to help students recall past information. Tasks (i.e., techniques) are what comprise each day-to-day class period, and are chosen based on the topics that must be covered. Lastly, transitions serve to provide coherence through each task, topic, and theme. They may be very short (e.g., a minute or two), or be as involved as performing another task in order to make connections between topics.

Though the two are not synonymous, the underlying principles of CLT are present in CBI, including meaning-focused activities, opportunities to use the language and negotiate meaning, and opportunities to incorporate Focus on Form instruction. How CBI differs from structural, communicative, and task-based approaches is that it “views content (in essence, defined by the theme, texts, and topics) as driving all curricular decisions” (Soller & Grabe, 1997, p. 86). The choice of themes and/or texts, therefore, becomes the paramount factor in CBI. This is perhaps the best and most robust way in which to maintain curricular integration.

Maximize Learning Opportunities

Perhaps one of the greatest weaknesses of older behaviorist approaches to language teaching is that the onus is placed on the teacher to create just the right learning environment to ensure that acquisition takes place. This view inevitably produces a

teacher-oriented approach that provides few opportunities for learners to engage with the L2. The paradigm shift that took place in the field of education, however, resulted in a more learner-oriented strategy (Jacobs & Farrell, 2001). In this framework, teachers still have the responsibility to create learning opportunities, but they must also be keenly aware of the learning opportunities created by the learners themselves, and be ready to capitalize on them in order to maximize learning opportunities (Kumaravadivelu, 1994).

In a postmethod pedagogy, “it is crucial that teachers strike a balance between their role as planners of teaching acts and their role as mediators of learning acts” (Kumaravadivelu, 1994, p. 33). If teachers are the only ones who create learning opportunities, then the class will surely be deprived of the rich learning resources that students are able to contribute to the language environment. As Kumaravadivelu has pointed out, “Creation of effective learning opportunities thus entails a willingness on the part of teachers to modify their lesson plans continuously on the basis of feedback” (p. 33). While most language teachers are required to use a predetermined syllabus, this must be viewed merely as a springboard into more specific and spontaneous learning activities in the actual classroom setting. Likewise, teachers must remain continually conscious of learners’ engagement and attentive to their feedback in order to adapt their lesson plans accordingly and on-the-fly.

Because the postmethod condition understands both teachers and learners to be creators of learning opportunities, teachers must recognize unplanned learning opportunities when they arise, and be able to exploit them for learning purposes. One way this can be done is by utilizing learner errors. Kumaravadivelu (1994) noted that

in a class of learners with near-homogenous language ability, every time a learner indicates any difficulty in understanding linguistic or propositional content of the

lesson, we can assume that there may be other learners who experience a similar difficulty. Therefore, not bringing a particular learner's problem to the attention of the class indicates a failure on the part of the teacher to utilize the learning opportunity created by the learner. (p. 33)

In other words, questions from students, looks of confusion, and misspoken expressions should prompt the teacher to draw greater attention to the issue. This does *not* mean that every error should be corrected, but only those that may helpfully contribute to the development of the learners' interlanguage.

Another way to maximize learning opportunities is to utilize small group work to ensure that learners are given ample opportunities for language production via negotiated interaction (McCarthy & O'Keeffe, 2004). If the teacher is the only one talking during class, or if teacher-learner interaction is the only interaction happening, that means that the vast majority of learners are hardly given opportunities to speak, and therefore to learn.

Lastly, repetition is key for maximizing learning opportunities. When information is presented once and never brought up again, it is unlikely to be remembered. Rather, knowledge of content is reinforced and comprehended more thoroughly when it has been revisited and reprocessed in new ways. In vocabulary acquisition, for instance, it is crucial to retrieve (or "recycle") vocabulary in order to strengthen the pathways and connections within one's brain (Stoller, 2002). Maximizing learning opportunities can take many forms, but it is necessary in order to steward the precious few hours allotted to language classes.

Aim for Fluency Before Accuracy

The field of psycholinguistics provides a helpful framework with which we can understand the mental processes that occur when speaking (or reading) a language. There

are two basic processing types: automatic and controlled. Automatic processing results when certain nodes of memory are consistently activated “in a particular pattern by the same type of input ... over time” (Wood, 2001, p. 579). When certain words or cues in the language are received through input, it triggers a vast network of information stored in the long-term recesses of the mind that may be accessed and retrieved instantly and without cognitive effort. Wood stated, “This process is extremely rapid and requires little or no effort or attention” (p. 578). In contrast to automatic processing, which is not limited by the short-term working memory, controlled processing is slow and inefficient, requires effort, and is limited by short-term memory capacity (p. 579). This type of processing does not lead to fluency in the L2.

Even if one’s primary goal is to read the target language, the research on the role and benefits of speaking in L2 acquisition make it abundantly clear why speaking is essential to developing fluent reading skills. Simply put, building spoken fluency in the L2 produces a greater amount of automaticity than any of the other language skills. Language is a highly complex cognitive system that requires vast amounts of attentional resources and processes. The more processes that can be automatized, and thus the more working memory that can be freed up, the more fluent one will become, whether speaking or reading (Wood, 2001).

Developing L2 fluency requires the use of implicit instruction, as discussed above (Grabe, 2004; see this chapter, “Utilize Implicit Instruction as Much as Possible”). It also requires the limited use of grammar instruction, particularly at early stages of the learning process. Regarding Focus on Form instruction, R. Ellis (2006) raised the question whether it is “best to teach grammar when learners first start to learn an L2 or to wait

until later when learners have already acquired some linguistic competence?” (p. 84).

While there are arguments for both positions, R. Ellis favored the latter.

It seems to me that a task-based approach that caters to the development of a proceduralised lexical system and simple, naturally acquired grammatical structures will ensure a threshold communicative ability and, therefore, is to be preferred to an approach that insists on grammatical accuracy from the start and that, as a consequence, may impede the development of this communicative ability. (p. 91)

In other words, teachers should focus on developing fluency and a certain level of communicative competence before teaching grammar via Focus on Form instruction.

Indeed, according to R. Ellis, Focus on FormS will actually *impede* language acquisition.

Why not focus on both fluency *and* accuracy? It is because language learners cannot focus on fluency (capacity to produce speech at normal rate and without interruption), accuracy (successful avoidance of errors), and complexity (advanced language use) all at the same time to the same degree (Skehan, 2009). Given the assumption that human’s attentional capacity and working memory are limited, it is natural that there exists a tension between these three measurements of language performance, particularly at the early stages of language learning. This tension may be described using the Trade-off Hypothesis, “which would predict that committing attention to one area, other things being equal, might cause lower performance in others” (p. 511). In other words, if a learner commits greater attention to form (either complexity or accuracy), then it is likely that his fluency will suffer. Conversely, if fluency is the primary goal, many learners tend to compromise either accuracy and/or complexity. This competition for attentional resources not only requires teachers to choose which measurement of language performance is being emphasized at the task level, but it also requires teachers to choose which measurement of language performance is emphasized

at the broader approach level. According to SLA research, it is wiser to aim for fluency before accuracy, partly because fluency has actually been shown to lead to greater accuracy (Nation, 2007). Consequently, as learners progress in fluency, explicit instruction becomes more useful for L2 acquisition, particularly to increase the complexity of one's output.

Nation (2007) has insisted that learners should try to be fluent with what they already know at every level of language proficiency. To this end, he suggests that 25 percent of every class be devoted to fluency-building activities. The criteria for a fluency activity are four-fold:

- (1) All of what the learners are listening to, reading, speaking or writing is largely familiar to them. That is, there are no unfamiliar language, or largely unfamiliar content or discourse features.
- (2) The learners' focus is on receiving or conveying meaning.
- (3) There is some pressure or encouragement to perform at a faster than usual speed.
- (4) There is a large amount of input or output. (Nation, 2007, p. 7)

Nation went on to explain how much class time ought to be devoted to fluency-building:

The fluency strand should make up about one-quarter of the course time. It is time out from learning new items and is a time for getting good at what is already known. ... In most language courses not enough attention is given to fluency development, possibly because it does not involve the learning of new language items and thus is not seen as moving the learners forward in their knowledge of the language. (Nation, 2007, p. 8)

In a way, devoting time specifically for fluency-building goes back to maximizing learning opportunities, as discussed in the previous principle. A postmethod pedagogy that is learner-oriented will provide opportunities for learners to get good at what they already know, rather than trying to fill their heads with explicit knowledge they will likely not remember. This is best done by aiming for fluency before accuracy.

Promote Learner Autonomy

Jacobs and Farrell (2001) have shown how the broad paradigm shift from positivism to post-positivism that took place at the end of the 20th century resulted in greater emphasis on the learner and less focus on the teacher. Learner autonomy reflects this shift not only by extending more choices to learners in the curriculum, but also by placing more of the responsibility of learning on their shoulders. “A form of democratization takes place with students taking on more rights and responsibilities for their own learning” and for the learning of others (p. 5). Learners must be motivated to own the learning process, or acquisition will never happen.

Promoting learner autonomy involves more small group activities (which necessarily means less direct teacher oversight). It involves allowing students to choose readings that interest them. It involves self- or peer-assessment. It involves “handing the reigns over,” as it were, to students and letting them make mistakes. It involves helping learners identify their learning styles and playing to those strengths. In short, “it involves helping learners learn how to learn” (Kumaravadivelu, 1994, pp. 39–40).

The natural corollary to emphasizing the role of the student in the learning process is to de-emphasize the role of the teacher. Too often in language classes (or any class for that matter), the teacher is viewed as “the expert” with all the answers, and students come and learn in order that that knowledge might be imparted to them. In contrast, “The current paradigm sees teaching and learning as social processes where the students are active co-constructors of knowledge with their teachers. The teacher is more of a facilitator and fellow learner alongside the students” (Jacobs & Farrell, 2001, p. 12). Students bring a wealth of knowledge and diversity into the learning context; this should

be tapped into in order to create the most effectual learning experience possible.

Adopting the view of teachers as co-learners, as Jacobs and Farrell (2001) suggest, will help students feel that they are bringing their strengths and ideas to the table, rather than the teacher being the only “expert” in the class. Students become sources of learning in addition to the teacher. Further, they are more engaged in the learning process, which increases their motivation and lowers some of the trepidation that causes negative affect in the learning process.

Ensure Social Relevance

The social context in which languages are taught is often overlooked in second language teaching. According to Kumaravadivelu (1994), however, teaching will be ineffective without a proper understanding of the social dynamics that exist between teacher-students, and students-students. Specifically, the learning purpose must be understood by both the teacher and the students, and instructional tasks ought to reflect that overall purpose, because “learning purpose and language use are perhaps most crucial in determining the social relevance of an L2 program” (p. 42). The material taught in class must be meaningful to learners not only in the sense that they comprehend the content, but that they know why they are learning it and have a desire to do so.

Though interaction has long been considered important for L2, language learning and language use have generally been understood to be two separate and distinct phenomena. But, as Meskill and Anthony (2015) have pointed out,

historical shifts away from teaching language in the abstract to teaching language *in use* have been significant. Where language was once treated as a subject area, the substance of which was to be *talked about*, contemporary views see the goal of language instruction to be active, productive use of the new language. (p. 11, italics original)

Similarly, based on empirical research, Hall & Verplaetse (2000) have attempted to reconceptualize the language learning process using a “broader, sociocultural perspective of language learning” (pp. 1–2), wherein language development includes areas such as discourse and sociolinguistic competence, and not merely “comprehension or use of grammar” (p. 6). Of particular importance to acquisition is the non-native speaker’s role in the interaction process, since it is only through negotiating meaning that the input is sure to become comprehensible.

Building off the work of Vygotsky (1978, as cited in Hall & Verplaetse, 2000), who claimed that all learning is socially mediated, Hall & Verplaetse (2000) delineated three sociocultural principles of language and learning, all of which follow the basic tenet that our language development is intricately linked with our engagement in sociocultural activities. The first principle is, “The mind is created in the pursuit of action in our material and social worlds” (p. 8). The very process of attempting to meet some need by engaging in the world around oneself *is* how the mind develops. Second, “Our participation and subsequent development are mediated by the symbolic tools and resources constitutive of these environments” (pp. 8–9). These “tools and resources” are referring the communicative and social activities in which one engages and which actually “shape and transform” one’s individual development (p. 9). Third, “The study of individual development is the study of the processes by which mind and external worlds are linked” (p. 9). By studying how the human mind engages and interacts with the world outside of itself, one can see how the actual process of learning and development takes place. These three premises are then applied to SL learning, particularly to the role of classroom discourse, which becomes all the more crucial in light of this research.

This emphasis on sociocultural interaction is *not* a return to behaviorism, where one's mental framework is shaped almost entirely by the world around herself. Hall and Verplaetse (2000) have explained:

The inherited biological characteristics of language constitute only the necessary preconditions for the capacity and ability to learn. The fundamental core of what gets learned and the shape it takes are defined by the environment, constituted by the myriad activities available to us and our particular ways of participating in them. (p. 8)

Language learning involves both a biological/cognitive ability that is innate within every human being, and also an intimate social engagement with the world around oneself.

Such a sociocultural view of language learning requires that the act of teaching is socially relevant for a particular set of learners in order to facilitate cooperative/collaborative learning designed to increase student-student interaction. "Cooperative learning acknowledges the place of affect in education, highlighting the importance of positive interdependence, the feeling among group members that the group sinks or swims together" (Jacobs & Farrell, 2001, p. 6). Participating in a social environment thus increases student motivation and lowers the effect of feeling isolation and/or incompetent for the language learning task.

Summary and Conclusion

Current SLA research supports a communicative methodology to teaching languages. It is an approach characterized by interaction in the target language with a focus on meaning the entire time that seeks to develop fluency before accuracy. It involves predominately implicit instruction, though explicit attention to grammar is given when necessary and always in the context of meaningful communication. It incorporates all four language skills from the beginning and maximizes learning opportunities in order

to create the most efficient learning process for adult L2 learners. The teaching of the target language is integrated with other subjects in order to maintain curricular integration, and the learner is viewed as more autonomous and less dependent on the teacher, contributing significantly to the learning process. Lastly, a communicative approach is socially relevant. It meets the needs of a specific audience and is tailored to the sociocultural context in which it is being employed. These principles characterize the current state of modern language instruction.

CHAPTER 5: AN EVALUATION OF THE CURRENT STATE OF BIBLICAL LANGUAGE INSTRUCTION IN LIGHT OF SLA RESEARCH

Introduction

It is necessary to evaluate the current state of biblical language instruction (see Chapter 3) in light of SLA research (see Chapter 4) in order to ascertain whether or not it reflects sound pedagogical principles. The reason this is important is because the traditional GT approach described in Chapter 3 has by far been the most prevalent approach used to teach the biblical languages since the nineteenth century, and very few, it seems, have questioned this practice. Grammar-Translation will, therefore, be evaluated according to each of the teaching principles detailed in Chapter 4.

An Evaluation of the Grammar-Translation Approach

Teach How to Use the Target Language in the Target Language

Because the GT approach utilizes learners' L1 rather than the L2 for instruction, teachers do not need to be able to speak the L2 in order to teach the L2. However, merely talking *about* the L2 *in* the L1 does not lead to acquisition of the L2 because there is very little L2 input, which is an absolutely necessary ingredient for language acquisition. If it is true that "language acquisition occurs when language is used for what it was designed for, communication" (Krashen, 1982, p. 1), then *not* using language for communication does *not* lead to acquisition. (A rationale for why *communication* is indeed the purpose of learning the biblical languages will be discussed in Chapter 7.) In fact, using the L1 inevitably interferes with the actual meaning of the L2, because there is no exact L1-to-

L2 correlation between any two languages. Utilizing the L1 for instruction, therefore, proves to be doubly unhelpful.

Teaching how to use the target language in the target language also largely precludes a grammatical syllabus which is part-and-parcel of the GT approach. In this syllabus structure grammar forms are introduced one at a time and learners are expected to master each before proceeding to the next. However, this structure does not help learners communicate effectively because real communication requires numerous aspects of a language, even at an elementary level. For instance, it is common for biblical language textbooks not to introduce verbs until nearly halfway through the book (Mounce, 2009; Pratico & Van Pelt, 2007)! However, it is very difficult to use a language effectively for communication without verbs.

Even when verbs *are* introduced, however, language use involves much more than merely piecing together grammatical building blocks. Rather, “Sentence comprehension and production ... involve rapid and simultaneous integration of syntactic, semantic, pragmatic, and discourse phenomena” (Kumaravadevelu, 1994, p. 38). In other words, languages must be taught holistically, integrating all levels—phonology, morphology, syntax, discourse, pragmatics—from the very beginning in order to create authentic and meaningful communication in the classroom. As Kumaravadevelu (1994) stated, “Introducing isolated discrete items will result in pragmatic dissonance, depriving the learner of necessary pragmatic cues and rendering the process of meaning making harder” (p. 38). Communication is inherently two-way. It involves two interlocutors (even if one of them is a text). One cannot reach a high level of

linguistic control without using the L2 for communication. Kumaravadivelu (1994)

expounded on this:

Studies in L2 development show that acquisition of syntax is constrained in part by pragmatics (Zobl, 1984), that the phonological forms L2 learners produce depend crucially on the content of discourse (Avery, Ehrlich, & Yorio, 1985), and that syntactic, semantic and pragmatic features cannot be understood as isolated linguistic components with a unidirectional information flow (Gass, 1986). (p. 38)

Therefore, not teaching how to use the target language in the target language is not an effective strategy for L2 acquisition.

Utilize Implicit Instruction as Much as Possible

The sole use of explicit instruction, along with the emphasis on rote memorization of vocabulary and grammar rules makes GT a highly analytical process that caters to the learning style of very few students. It is not a natural way to learn languages, because languages are meant to be learned from whole to part, not from part to whole (Jacobs & Farrell, 2001). Such detailed analysis—or, in Doughty and Williams' (1998) words, deliberate processing—of “raw” information takes vast amounts of cognitive effort and puts much strain on one's working memory. According to N. Ellis (2005), compared to how much one is able to acquire through implicit learning, one's conscious capacity is “a very narrow bottleneck” in language acquisition (p. 312). Consequently, if the entirety of one's instruction is explicit, then the learning process is severely crippled and one cannot expect learners to excel very far in their proficiency of the biblical languages.

Foster Language Awareness

While CLT indeed places a certain degree of emphasis on fostering language awareness, or Focus on Form, the vast amount of instruction is implicit with a focus on meaning. Grammar-Translation, on the other hand, places nearly all of its emphasis on

learning explicit grammar forms (i.e., Focus on FormS). According to Doughty and Williams (1998), this traditional grammar teaching “results in deliberate rather than automatic language use” (p. 229). R. Ellis (2006) likewise made clear that the “traditional approach to teaching grammar based on explicit explanations and drill-like practice is unlikely to result in the acquisition of the implicit knowledge needed for fluent and accurate communication” (p. 102). It is therefore crucial to maintain the distinction between Focus on Form and Focus on FormS, and to ensure that one’s grammar teaching is accomplished via the former. If the overall aim of language acquisition is to communicate meaning—whether people-to-people or text-to-people—then developing fluency and automatic processing ought to be a priority for instruction, but this cannot happen efficiently in a GT class where attention is given solely to explicit instruction. In contrast to such Focus on FormS instruction, R. Ellis has highlighted the need for forms to be connected to their meaning at all times during instruction and “any reference grammar that fails to describe the form-meaning connections of the target language must necessarily be inadequate” (2006, p. 87). This describes traditional biblical language grammar books whose instruction consists primarily of decontextualized grammar forms that are not connected to meaning.

Facilitate Language Production via Negotiated Interaction

Because GT uses learners’ L1 as the language of instruction, there is very little opportunity for learners to produce the L2. While some GT classes require composition in the L2, it usually consists of one-sentence translations from the learner’s L1, not free composition for communicative purposes. And there certainly is no spoken interaction or negotiation of meaning interaction in the L2.

This lack of output is one of the most glaring voids in biblical language instruction. It is erroneously believed that the L2 can be learned through explicit grammar instruction alone. However, *no one* in the field of SLA makes this claim. On the contrary, as discussed above (see Chapter 4, “Facilitate Language Production via Negotiated Interaction”), Swain (1985, 1995) and others have argued that language production, or output, is essential for advancing learners to a high level of linguistic competence, because it forces learners to process the language on a syntactic level. Gass, Behny, and Plonsky (2013) likewise made the point:

It is quite trivial to state that there is no better way to test the extent of one’s knowledge (linguistic or otherwise) than to have to use that knowledge in some productive way—whether it be explaining a concept to someone (i.e., teaching) or writing a computer program, or, in the case of language learning, getting even a simple idea across. (p. 356)

A sobering demonstration of this truth is to ask the average Hebrew or Greek teacher to speak a simple sentence in the language that they teach. Most find it extremely difficult to do so. This is because GT’s lack of L2 production and interaction does not produce higher-level processing skills among learners.

Those who simply “read” the L2 may be able to comprehend texts, but whether they realize it or not, comprehension can often be achieved simply by understanding the basic meanings of words in combination with other background knowledge, including one’s knowledge of the English text (at least in the case of the biblical languages) (Anderson, 2009, pp. 119–120). For instance, one might be able to “read” the creation account in Genesis 1–2 in Hebrew, not because she knows all the Hebrew vocab and grammar, but because she is likely very familiar with the story in English. While this background knowledge can be important for reading, too much dependence on the L1 can

function as a crutch since there are certainly details from the L2 account that remain unnoticed. Similarly, one is able to function adequately in a foreign country with only a limited L2 “survival vocabulary” but this does not mean he is competent in the L2. Such dependence on L1 knowledge is all too common in GT classes because the only source of L2 input is the biblical text. Interacting in the L2 and negotiating meaning in “extra-biblical” contexts, however, reveals what is lacking in one’s interlanguage and causes learners to focus attention on certain forms that are unknown, which, in turn, leads to greater communicative competence (including L2 *reading* skills).

Integrate Language Skills

The GT approach cannot integrate language skills because reading is the only skill taught. Consequently, adult learners of the biblical languages are deprived of the mutual-reinforcement of other modes of learning that more effectively develop automatic word recognition and syntactic parsing, which are both necessary for reading fluency.

Kumaravadivelu (1994) points to several studies that demonstrate how “[skill separation] is a pedagogical artifact that has been shown to be inadequate for developing integrated functional skills” (p. 39). Even if one’s purpose is only to read the biblical text, his functional ability to do so is severely crippled by neglecting the other three language skills. Concerning the common dichotomy between “active” skills (speaking and writing) and “passive” skills (listening and reading), Savignon (1990) stated, “lost in this encode/decode message-sending representation is the collaborative nature of meaning-making” (p. 207). In other words, comprehension of meaning is best achieved through the integrated use of multiple language skills. Language is a complex, integrative, holistic

system that cannot be stripped apart into individual skills and be expected to function just as well—yet GT does just that.

Maintain Curricular Integration

Theoretically, GT *can* maintain curricular integration by including other areas of study in the language classes. For instance, higher level biblical language classes—typically called exegesis—often include theology, historical backgrounds of the text, homiletics, etc. Usually, however, these topics are only indirectly integrated into biblical language courses, and not holistically integrated into the curriculum as Content-Based Instruction seeks to do. Especially at lower levels of language learning, the focus is almost entirely on the language itself, in isolation from other subject areas. This not only makes it difficult for learners to learn certain aspects of the language (for example, how were kings viewed in the ancient Near East and how did this compare to the Israelite’s concept of מֶלֶךְ *melekh* [“king”]?), but it also precludes the learner from benefitting from the L2 language/culture connections.

Maximize Learning Opportunities

Nation (2007) suggests that a balanced integration of meaning-focused input, meaning-focused output, language-focused learning, and fluency-building is the key to developing the most efficient language learning program. By focusing on only one of these strands (i.e., language-focused learning), and by severely misconstruing it (i.e., the explicit instruction is void of any communicative context), GT seriously cuts down on learning opportunities. As has been discussed, SLA research shows that while explicit grammar teaching has a role in language learning, by itself, explicit instruction does not lead to language acquisition (R. Ellis, 2006; Doughty & Williams, 1998). In this sense,

GT offers very few opportunities for learning in the truest sense of the word. Further, because the only L2 input for a typical first-year learner is a limited number of examples in a grammar book, learners are deprived of the massive amount of comprehensible input—the most significant amount of which comes through *listening*—that is absolutely necessary for language acquisition to take place. Learners are simply not able to reconstruct the L2 without sufficient input and without opportunities to test their L2 hypotheses via output. Without teaching the target language in the target language, without implicit instruction, and without L2 production and interaction, learning opportunities simply cannot be maximized.

Aim for Fluency Before Accuracy

The GT approach offers virtually no opportunity for fluency development, because all of the attention is focused on grammatical accuracy. Learners are expected to memorize and reproduce forms correctly, but they are not given the opportunity to use them for spoken communication. Ironically, it is GT's priority on understanding "every detail" of the L2 that prevents functional use of the L2 by its learners. This is because the sole focus on explicit grammar provides no opportunity for developing automaticity of lower-level language processes (word recognition, syntactic parsing, etc.), which is absolutely essential for both speaking *and* reading fluency. Contrary to the core notion of GT, learner errors are actually signs that learning is taking place and are not to be corrected every time. A child who erroneously says, "I goed to school yesterday," demonstrates that she is learning the most common pattern of past tense in English and is hypothesizing how to use that with new verbs. This learner error (note, not "mistake")

will work itself out over time with more comprehensible input and interaction in the L2. Such learner errors should therefore not be “penalized” in a language class.

Of course, assessment is a significant factor here, for it is much easier to assess whether learners can reproduce a verb paradigm than to assess whether they can use the verbs correctly (both syntactically and pragmatically) in actual spoken discourse.

Promote Learner Autonomy

In one sense, there is some measure of learner autonomy in GT, in that learners are typically required to spend vast amounts of time learning material covered in lectures or in textbooks. In this way, they must take on responsibility for their own learning. However, this is not entirely what learner autonomy means.

Learner autonomy also involves tapping into the resources of learners, identifying and incorporating what each has to offer to the learning process. Learning opportunities are to be created not just by the teacher but also by the learners themselves. In a GT class, however, it is usually the teacher and/or the textbook that is viewed as the expert with all the knowledge. Students come to “be fed” this knowledge and do not usually contribute significantly to the learning content of the language class. This can leave learners feeling inferior to the teacher and/or to other students. In other words, GT most often promotes *learner dependency*.

Ensure Social Relevance

If it is true that “learning purpose and language use are perhaps most crucial in determining the social relevance of an L2 program” (Kumaravadivelu, 1994, p. 42), then these two factors become the primary criteria of whether or not a particular approach to teaching languages is indeed socially relevant. The learning purpose of GT classes is to

enable learners to read texts and analyze their grammar. The question is whether GT realistically fulfills this purpose? Certainly, students learn the grammar of the L2, but this knowledge is not functional because fluent reading skills are not developed. As discussed in the introduction of this paper, most graduates of university, graduate school, or seminary are not able to pick up their Hebrew and Greek Bible and simply read a passage at a natural pace, for pleasure, and for extended periods of time. One could potentially argue that this is not the goal of exegesis. However, what learner of *any* language would deny that fluent reading ability is not only highly desired, but also highly advantageous for interpretation? Those who study the biblical languages would be greatly served by developing fluent reading abilities, yet GT is unable to fulfill this learning purpose, at least in an efficient manner.

Another reason why GT is not meeting learner needs is because it caters to very few learning styles. Because excessive attention to grammatical forms demands massive amounts of cognitive processing, it makes biblical language classes notoriously difficult. Usually, it is only the analytical students—the math majors, the computer programmers, etc.—who enjoy and/or excel in GT classes. In her discussion of cognitive style and Latin instruction, Deagon (2006) discussed the ineffectiveness of GT for the vast majority of ancient languages learners:

Traditional Latin instruction, emphasizing a strong orientation to grammar and meticulous attention to detail, favors a particular kind of student: one who learns well sequentially, is field independent (i.e. sensitized to subtle differences such as case endings), puts high value on memory work and rules, prefers abstractions to concrete realities, and prefers to study alone. Students who measure high in the “introverted,” “sensing,” “thinking,” and “judging” scales of the MBTI, “abstract sequentials” in the Gregorc scale, and who are operation learners are well suited to study according to the grammar-translation method. But *such students are a minority* of those we are likely to get in our classrooms today: *as few as 10 percent* (Moody 392-3). (Deagon, 2006, Kindle locations 477–481, italics added)

Because GT caters to the learning style of so few learners, some students try to avoid having to take them altogether (e.g., choosing their major based on whether or not they have to take Hebrew or Greek). Others fail to complete biblical language programs as is evidenced by unusually high attrition rates among biblical language learners, and the majority of those who do persevere through the entire language program eventually “lose” the language after their formal training is complete. Deagon (2006) described the negative effects of GT for learners:

The brightest students with these [abstract] learning styles will be able to adapt to the needs of a traditional course, but others will become bored and not want to continue, or become alienated from a language they may have initially been interested in learning, describing it as “too hard” or “useless.” This situation must be remedied if Latin is to be taught effectively, and, bluntly, if it is going to continue to be a viable language in today's schools and universities. (Deagon, 2006, Kindle locations 484–487)

While Deagon was describing Latin instruction specifically, the same is undeniable true of the biblical languages. Such results force one to question the approach with which the biblical languages are taught. It seems that if GT only caters to a fraction (less than 10 percent, according to Deagon) of learners’ learning styles, then it is not meeting the needs of learners, and, therefore, is not socially relevant.

The other measure of social relevance is language use. How is the language to be used by learners? If it is true that language learning is fundamentally sociocultural in nature (Hall & Verplaetse, 2000), then it *must* be used in social contexts in order for learning to take place. Therefore, the lack of social interaction in the L2 that characterizes GT makes learning the L2 very difficult. Proponents of GT may argue that their goal of reading is primarily individual—not social—in nature. However, even if this is the case (this claim will be countered later), one must question whether learners’ end knowledge

of grammar is able to help them functionally read and engage with the biblical text long-term in a meaningful, efficient, and enjoyable manner. From all that has been described thus far concerning GT, it does not appear to be socially relevant.

Conclusion

In conclusion, it is clear that SLA research does not support GT as an effective way to teach second languages. There simply exists no theoretical basis for it—neither when it was formalized by Karl Ploetz in the nineteenth century nor today in light of modern research. GT has, therefore, been rejected by all language theorists today as an effective way to teach second languages because it does not teach how to use the target language in the target language, it utilizes more explicit instruction than implicit instruction, it focuses on language forms more than meaning, it does not facilitate language production or provide opportunities for learners to negotiate meaning, it does not integrate language skills, it often fails to integrate other subject areas into its curriculum, it limits learning opportunities by restricting instruction to the teacher, it focuses on accuracy instead of fluency, it promotes learner dependency rather than learner autonomy, and it is not socially relevant. This approach, however, has been used to teach all ancient languages, including the biblical languages, for nearly a millennium, again, largely based on the assumption that no other approach is possible.

Further, GT textbooks continue to be published by the droves, many claiming to be unique, innovative in design, more useful/practical for learners, more intuitive, etc., yet ultimately, they all follow the same ineffective principles inherent to the GT approach. In 2006, Dallaire (2006, November) recorded that 23 beginning Hebrew grammars (not to mention intermediate textbooks, software, and online resources) had

been published in the 15 years prior to the time of her writing, the vast majority of which are strictly GT. Even more have been published since that time. While Dallaire (2006, November) offered reasons for why more introductory textbooks continue to be published, she also identified why it is that most of them continue to follow the same old approach: “It is well known in education that faculty members tend to adopt the default position of teaching the way they were taught, using of the same textbooks they utilized in their initial acquisition of the material” (p. 7). By and large, this is absolutely true, and it has been going on for generation upon generation. The current state of biblical language instruction is not heartening, and this is the nature of the language education that is preparing future biblical scholars and Church leaders. Perhaps what is most shocking is that *very* few in the field recognize the bleak situation...and very few seem to mind.

However, as the next chapter details, there are some biblical language instructors and textbook authors who have been attempting to implement a different approach to teaching the biblical languages.

CHAPTER 6: A SURVEY AND EVALUATION OF BIBLICAL LANGUAGE
MATERIALS AND INSTITUTES AFFIRMING COMMUNICATIVE
METHODOLOGIES

Introduction

While GT has undoubtedly been the predominant approach to teaching the biblical (indeed, all ancient) languages since the nineteenth century, as of late, there exists a growing interest among biblical language teachers in exploring the value that SLA research might have for the teaching of the biblical languages. This phenomenon is evidenced by a smattering of textbooks that have been published in the last decade or so that all claim to follow CLT principles, the emergence of several institutes that teach the biblical languages using communicative methodologies, and continual research being presented in the “Applied Linguistics and the Biblical Languages” sections of both the Evangelical Theological Society and the Society of Biblical Literature annual meetings. Each of the textbooks and institutes referred to above are undergirded by varying degrees of SLA research, though none of the authors or instructors (to the present author’s knowledge) are SLA professionals by training. Therefore, the degree to which their pedagogical principles are consistent with SLA research stands as an open question for others to investigate with the goal of pushing the field in a positive and forward direction.

The following evaluation is divided into three parts. The first category to be evaluated is published biblical language textbooks that claim to employ communicative methodologies. These resources will be evaluated externally based on their self-

descriptions as well as internally based on their content (following McDonough & Shaw, 2003). It should be noted that it is impossible to evaluate how these textbooks are *actually used* by teachers in the classroom. Studies not only show that the actual practice of teachers in the classroom often differs (sometimes drastically) from the stated pedagogical claims of the textbook or curriculum they are “utilizing,” but also that teachers’ practices themselves often differ from their own stated pedagogical beliefs (Freeman & Johnson, 1998). Mackey (1965), therefore, warned against

confus[ing] the text used with the teacher using it, or the method with the teaching of it. Method analysis is one thing, therefore; teaching analysis, quite another. Method analysis determines how teaching is done by the book; teaching analysis shows how much is done by the teacher. (as cited in Kumaravadivelu, 1994, p. 28)

A textbook may be well-written and follow sound SLA principles, but if the teacher using it does not properly implement CLT in the classroom then the textbook can lose its effectiveness. Conversely, even though a textbook may lack completely sound pedagogical principles, a teacher might be able to redeem it (or portions of it) and use it for effective language teaching. This touches on the issue of whether a textbook is more useful as a self-study resource, as a resource to be integrated into a classroom context, or both. A brief assessment of this will be provided when appropriate.

The second category to be evaluated is institutes with established biblical language programs that claim to employ CLT principles. Again, it is impossible to assess how classes are *actually run* in these institutes without experiencing them oneself. Consequently, each institute will be evaluated solely from its self-description on its website or in other published literature.

The third category to be evaluated is the present author's personal experience with two of the institutes in the previous section—namely, BLC and FPU—which enables him to conduct a more detailed and “accurate” evaluation of what actually takes place behind the walls of these particular biblical language programs. Such classroom research is crucial for assessing the validity of the claims made by proponents of using CLT for the teaching the biblical languages.

What follows is a survey of these works as well as a general evaluation of how closely each textbook and institute adheres to the SL teaching principles detailed in Chapter 4. Because some of the principles are more relevant for the teacher than for the textbook (e.g., promote learner autonomy), while others apply equally to both the teacher and the textbook (e.g., utilize implicit instruction as much as possible), not every principle will be addressed in each evaluation.

Textbooksⁱ

Living Biblical Hebrew (Buth, 2006a, 2006b) and Living Koiné Greek (Buth, 2008a, 2008b, 2008c)

Buth's Living Biblical Language textbooks (2006a, 2006b, 2008a, 2008b, 2008c) were truly the first of their kind among Hebrew and Greek textbooks as they seek to introduce beginning learners to the target language in the target language. To this end, Part One of each series (Buth, 2006a, 2008a) consists of 1,000 illustrations with accompanying audio that describes the pictures solely in the L2. The picture descriptions consist of individual words, phrases, sentences, and sequences of events that create simple vignettes. The pictures and several hours of audio provide much comprehensible input and implicit instruction that scaffolds in complexity throughout the book, enabling

learners to comprehend meaning directly in the L2 and not via their L1. Listening and reading fluency is the focus (even in the quizzes) rather than assessing grammatical accuracy. Part One ends with an introduction to the morpheme-sound relationships of the language via para-discrimination lists, where learners listen to Hebrew sounds and have to choose between two letters/morphemes, only one of which represents the sound. This progresses until the learner is reading whole words in Hebrew. Following this introduction to reading is the written text of each picture description, thereby enabling learners to begin reading and comprehending material they have already internalized without having to learn the alphabet and spelling rules first. Also included in Part One is a brief summary of the basic grammar concepts, some of which are illustrated from phrases taken from the picture lessons. Learners acquire an immense amount of implicit grammar knowledge and roughly 250 vocabulary words in Part One alone. (Part One usually covers about one month of class time, or one college unit.)

Part Two of each series (Buth, 2006b, 2008b, 2008c) utilizes short dialogues which contain intentional vocabulary and grammar that prepare learners to read biblical texts. The dialogues are to be memorized and performed from memory. Grammar topics are then introduced in English inductively from these dialogues, followed by audiolingual drills that require the learner to listen to a phrase and then manipulate it orally using a cue provided by the recording (e.g., changing the person and number of a verb in a sentence based on the pronoun cue). Lastly, each chapter contains a passage from the book of Jonah that is accompanied with audio and is annotated with English glosses and (“optional”) technical linguistic footnotes. Each chapter concludes with written exercises that require grammatical and literary analysis of the biblical text covered in that chapter.

Parts One and Two together contain about 14 hours of L2 audio content which is the most aural input of any biblical Hebrew resource available.

The most significant weaknesses of these resources are twofold. First is that the dialogues and audiolingual drills in Part Two do not themselves elicit opportunities for dynamic, negotiated interaction in the L2 since memorization and recitation is different from real language use. The audiolingual drills, in particular, do not reflect authentic communication, nor do many of them prove to be meaningful input because a significant amount of the vocabulary used in the drills is new to that drill and never used again. Learners must rely on the corresponding list of English glosses provided for each drill in order to comprehend meaning. Many of these drills, therefore, essentially consist of concurrent translation and/or pronunciation practice, and thus, are unhelpful for acquiring the L2. In other words, the textbook does not maximize learning opportunities and is not consistently socially relevant because it fails to provide meaningful input for learners.

The second and most serious weakness is that Parts One and Two of each series are highly unbalanced in their use of implicit and explicit instruction. Part One contains 1,000 pictures with L2-only audio; Part Two consists largely of explicit instruction in English with virtually no pictures. Consequently, learners using these textbooks are often jolted when transitioning from the “passive,” implicit instruction of the picture book to the text-based, explicit instruction contained in Part Two. Further, the bulk of text on each page is grammar discussions in English, even though they tend to be less abstract than typical grammar textbooks and contain more “practical” information that relates directly to the dialogues and text as well as a plethora of L2 examples drawn from them.

Nevertheless, there is still an excessive amount of explicit instruction that consumes much space/time that could be spent with implicit instruction in the L2.

Related to this is the fact that the textbook is arranged grammatically, which is immediately visible from the table of contents. Granted, the order of grammar forms does not reflect traditional biblical Hebrew textbooks because they are intimately connected to the dialogues that begin each chapter and the biblical text that concludes each chapter. In this sense the grammar instruction is one step closer to Focus on Form, though still not as described in Chapter 4 (see “Foster Language Awareness”). The addition of illustrations, the inclusion of more Hebrew text and less English text, and more Focus on Form instruction (i.e., grammar instruction embedded in communicative contexts) would greatly benefit this resource.

Despite these weaknesses, Buth’s Living Biblical Language textbooks remain perhaps the most helpful introductions to the biblical languages currently available, especially for use as a self-study curriculum (i.e., not accompanied by a teacher or classroom setting). Part One of each series is particularly helpful for learning the target language in the target language and can even serve as a supplement to other required textbooks and/or classes in order to enhance one’s implicit knowledge of the biblical languages. When using Part Two, however, learners must depend on the English glosses that accompany all the Hebrew text in order to comprehend the meaning of the L2.

Beginning Biblical Hebrew: A Grammar and Illustrated Reader (Cook & Holmstedt, 2013)

Cook and Holmstedt’s (2013) text is a hybrid between a traditional grammar and an illustrated reader, though each part is completely distinguished from the other. The

authors claim to incorporate “modern methods for teaching languages” (Cook & Holmstedt, 2013, p. 9) in response to their dissatisfaction with most biblical Hebrew textbooks. In their words:

We avoid using the model that dominates in other textbooks: the grammar-translation model. Instead of teaching Hebrew as an object to be decoded and then recoded into the students’ native language (e.g., English), the goal of this textbook is to provide the student with competency in reading, listening, and even producing Hebrew. In other words, rather than mastering Hebrew for translation, our aim is that students achieve the ability *to comprehend Biblical Hebrew texts*. (p. 9, italics original)

This goal is apparently to be achieved through the illustrated reader (as opposed to the grammar portion), which is based on three episodes from Genesis. This part of the textbook is particularly helpful since it includes numerous pictures, interactive writing and speaking exercises, simplified texts, and a few slightly-modified biblical texts. The wealth of illustrations in the vocabulary activities, the grammar drills, the stories, and the texts provides a significant amount of implicit L2 instruction with a focus on meaning. Audio files containing vocabulary, sentences, and readings can be accessed online in order to increase vocabulary memorization and comprehension of texts. Further, the textbook is designed to facilitate either a “text-based atmosphere, focusing on the given exercises, or ... a conversation-based atmosphere, in which the given exercises are used as a platform for extemporaneous modification (and thus greater competency in the productive aspect of learning Hebrew)” (p. 10).

This portion of the textbook, however, comprises only 90 pages of the 324 total pages. The remainder of the book (i.e., the first part) consists of 50 short grammar lessons whose “organization ... centers around discrete grammatical issues” (p. 10), which contradicts their claim to “avoid using ... the grammar-translation model” (p. 9). In these

explicit grammar lessons, Cook and Holmstedt (2013) include a “minimal” amount of grammar with the rationale that this will enable a learner to approach the biblical text without getting lost in too much linguistic jargon. They state, “To put it in SLA terms, our selection of grammar in the textbook has been guided by the goal of *acquiring* the ancient Hebrew language as opposed to simply *learning* its grammar” (p. 10). None of the SLA research, however, supports the notion that merely presenting *less* Focus on FormS (not Focus on Form) instruction will enable learners to acquire the L2.

In conclusion, while the illustrated reader portion of Cook and Holmstedt’s (2013) textbook is an excellent resource for learning biblical Hebrew, the grammar-translation portion dominates the text as a whole. Overall, therefore, it does not represent a thoroughly principled communicative methodology.

Learning Biblical Hebrew Interactively (Overland, 2014)

Learning Biblical Hebrew Interactively (Overland, 2014) is the product of the Cohelet Project, a three-year project funded by the Wabash Center for Teaching and Learning in Theology and Religion that took place from 2006–2008. It was conducted by a team of scholars, including an SLA consultant, a Computer-Assisted Language Learning consultant, and nine biblical Hebrew instructors who field-tested the book over the course of the study. The stated goals of this project were:

1. To explore strategies for adapting to Biblical Hebrew advances arising from the field of Second Language Acquisition (including Communicative Language Teaching).
2. To develop and field-test communicative materials for the Hebrew classroom.
3. To assess these materials’ effectiveness with a view to extending their use among both English-speaking and non-English-speaking students of Hebrew. (Overland, n.d.)

The results of this study were published in an article titled “Can Communicative Principles Enhance Classical Language Acquisition?” (Overland, Fields, & Noonan, 2011) while the primary teaching resource produced from it was *Learning Biblical Hebrew Interactively* (Overland, 2014), though this textbook was not written by the entire research team, but by Paul Overland alone.

The most helpful features of this textbook are twofold. The first is an illustrated, serialized ‘Jonah Story’ that is based on the biblical text and that runs central throughout each chapter. This component offers the most amount of implicit instruction and comprehensible input of any part of the book. An online companion contains videos with the ‘Jonah Story’ being read aloud, which integrates aural skills with reading skills.

The second most helpful aspect of this textbook is the inclusion of numerous “interactive skills,” or communicative activities, that are to be conducted in a classroom setting, which, if executed properly by the teacher, provide excellent opportunities for learners to produce the L2 via negotiated interaction. Overland (2014) states that the book is designed in such a way that someone with no prior training in SLA is able to teach the course using a communicative pedagogy (p. xiii) and he attempts to accomplish this goal by incorporating pedagogical tips and instructions for the interactive activities throughout each unit. These features certainly provide more learning opportunities than traditional GT textbooks as they focus on meaning over form. The book also incorporates helpful background essays that situate the language in its cultural and historical settings, thereby maintaining curricular integration.

However, while the textbook certainly incorporates some principles drawn from SLA research, it does not do so consistently or sufficiently given its own pedagogical

claims, let alone what SLA research would recommend for effective language teaching. For one, Overland attempts to create a hybrid approach or, in his words, “a ‘both-and’ second language acquisition biblical Hebrew textbook” (2014, pp. xii) that lacks theoretical justification. He tries to retain key elements from traditional GT grammar books—vocabulary lists, grammatical explanations, paradigms—while also incorporating SLA principles, yet the former approach lacks a research basis while the latter approach boasts quite a robust one. This is plainly evidenced by the fact that Overland’s (2014) list of “New components integrated for Second language Acquisition” contains a plethora of footnotes citing SLA research while his list of “Traditional elements retained” (i.e., GT components) contains *absolutely no footnotes* with supporting research (p. xii)! As discovered in Chapter 4, this is because there is none. The integration of these two approaches, therefore, demands justification but none is given. Nor is any criteria provided for when the traditional elements are employed versus when the communicative components are employed. It seems that the retaining of certain “traditional” features necessarily jeopardizes a consistent and effective approach that is based on SLA research, rendering the textbook’s claim to be an “SLA format,” an “SLA approach,” and an “SLA pedagogy” (Overland, 2014, pp. xii–xiii) rather misleading.

Second, underlying the purported functional syllabus appears to be little more than a grammatical syllabus with communicative tasks superficially tacked on. Consequently, the “functions” are somewhat artificial and do not represent a natural sequence for acquiring a language in regular social contexts. For instance, the “functions” in Unit 3 are “designating an object and who owns it,” “discussing job descriptions,” “describing what people are doing,” and “designating a recipient” (p. vi). This unnatural

and awkward sequence of functions is certainly due in part to the fact that the “functions” are simply a veneer for a linear sequence of *grammar concepts*, despite the author’s claim. Surprisingly, the book doesn’t even try to hide this fact. In the table of contents, the grammatical concept being introduced is stated underneath each “function.” For example, in Unit 4 one can plainly see the grammatical sequence underlying the “functions,” as the third person future tense forms are introduced one by one: “describing what a group (men or men and women) is about to do ... *qal* בְּיָנִין, יִקְטֹל 3mpl,” “describing what a man will do ... יִקְטֹל 3ms,” “describing what a group of women will do ... יִקְטֹל 3fpl,” and “describing what a woman will do ... יִקְטֹל 3fs” (p. vii). *LBHI* is thus a prime example of why the functional syllabus has been so critiqued within SLA literature—namely, that functions “do not do justice to the ‘whole complex business of communication’” (Widdowson, 1978, as cited in Celce-Murcia, Dörnyei, & Thurrell, 1997, p. 143) and are often not presented with any more coherence than a grammatical syllabus. Even more fundamentally, as has been shown, the “functions” often prove to be nothing more than a grammatical form—or a small cluster of grammatical forms—anyway.

Third, the vast majority of the material in the textbook is explicit grammatical explanations *about* Hebrew but written in English. This disproportionate amount of L1 material to L2 material is perhaps the clearest way in which the textbook contradicts SLA principles because the L1 content drastically limits the amount of comprehensible input and implicit instruction possible. Even though the grammar discussions are related to the interactive skills and loosely incorporated into the Jonah story, they are still too extensive (they consume the majority to the text) and they are entirely in the L1, which means they

resemble traditional Focus on FormS rather than Focus on Form instruction (Doughty & Williams, 1998; Spada & Lightbown, 2008).

Regarding the use of this curriculum in an independent study context, the book states:

While intended for group learning and conversation, *this textbook would be sufficient for independent students*—especially if they take advantage of the segment-by segment instructional videos. In addition, they should secure the help of a skilled tutor who will be able to review homework. (Overland, 2014, p. xiv, italics added)

In a later “note to the student,” however, Overland (2014) correctly identifies the “secret to language learning” as “look[ing] for ways to actually communicate with it, whether to express your opinion, to accomplish tasks, or to ask others to do something” (p. xvii) but this seems to be an unrealistic goal for a student using this textbook by herself. Indeed, the effectiveness of this textbook is largely dependent on whether the learner is using it in the context of a class with other learners and whether the teacher of that class has been educated in SL teaching principles. If either of these conditions are not met, then the book drastically loses its efficacy, because at that point the learner is restricted to mostly explicit grammar instruction and is dependent on English translations for comprehension.

In conclusion, Overland’s (2014) book is certainly another step in the right direction with regards to biblical language instruction in that it incorporates such communicative elements as the use of all four languages skills, interactive tasks, and an illustrated, serialized story that provides implicit instruction. It can also potentially be used quite effectively in a classroom context with a teacher who has been trained in SL teaching principles because of the numerous interactive skills included. Nonetheless, the presence of so many “traditional grammar elements” in the textbook itself results in a

communicative approach that is neither consistent nor principled. Research from the field of SL teaching has much to offer to make this textbook more principled and robust in its implementation of CLT principles.

Speaking Ancient Greek as a Living Language (Rico, 2015)

Rico's (2015) text is a product of the Polis Institute (described below in the section "Institutes") and is designed to introduce beginning learners to the Greek language directly, without the need for translation. To this end, the book is written almost entirely in Greek, including a simple Greek-Greek lexicon at the end of each chapter that defines words based on their usage in the dialogues and communicative tasks throughout the chapter. Extensive dialogues and songs are utilized throughout with accompanying audio recordings. Listening, speaking, reading, and writing are all integrated in meaningful and engaging tasks. Language production is facilitated through the dialogues, as well as functional tasks, some of which incite open-ended interaction and negotiation of meaning. The most significant feature of this textbook that makes it distinct from all other biblical language textbooks is its effective use of Focus on Form instruction. That is, language awareness is brilliantly fostered through a plethora of inductive and implicit grammar discussions/exercises in the L2 that focus on meaning since they are intimately connected with the dialogues.

The most significant weakness of this textbook is the scarcity of pictures, which renders most of the L2 input *incomprehensible* apart from a teacher who is able to introduce vocabulary through some other means not contained in the textbook. In other words, *Speaking Ancient Greek as a Living Language* is virtually inaccessible for learners with no prior Greek knowledge or who are not accompanied by a teacher and/or

class to learn with. This precludes its use as a self-study textbook. In this sense, learning opportunities are not maximized, though in nearly every other sense, they are. With a teacher who is well-trained in SL teaching principles and who has at least some communicative capacity in Koiné Greek, this textbook is perhaps the most thoroughly consistent with SL teaching principles and, therefore, the most helpful one available for Koiné Greek, particularly in a classroom context.

Biblical Hebrew: A Living Language (Dallaire, 2016)

Dallaire's (2016) textbook is the most recently published Hebrew textbook that incorporates communicative principles. It includes a variety of activities that encourage listening, speaking, reading, and writing in the L2, including simple dialogues, songs, and exercises that are suggested for classroom use. Dallaire (2016) helpfully provides a list of some Hebrew expressions for classroom interaction in order to remain in the L2. An accompanying CD includes teaching PowerPoints, visual vocabulary PowerPoints, and a whole host of teaching resources that range from grammar summaries to place names in the Hebrew Bible to labeling parts of the body.

Dallaire (2016) explained her purpose behind the textbook:

The primary goal of the textbook is to develop reading competency in the Hebrew Bible at the intermediate level. Since reading proficiency in a foreign language can only be achieved when one hears himself/herself pronounce words out loud, the author chose to include a variety of oral exercises that can be done in class and/or at home. Secondary objectives include proficiency in listening comprehension, writing and speaking. These goals are achieved through a variety of functional activities done in the classroom and/or at home. (p. i)

Such goals are praiseworthy and her rationale is consistent with SLA research. However, as is the case with Overland (2014), her textbook fundamentally follows a grammatical syllabus and most of the “functional” activities are merely tacked on to explicit grammar

explanations which are presented in English, similar to traditional grammar books. All of the instructional material and most of the instructions for activities are in English (though the section headings contain both Hebrew and English and some Hebrew instructions are utilized later in the textbook). Further, many of the activities throughout the text require learners to translate between the L1 and L2 or to parse verbs, which are both characteristics of GT. These observations render this resource lacking to qualify as a thoroughly principled communicative approach for biblical language teaching.

GlossaHouse

GlossaHouse is a publishing company founded by Michael Halcomb and Frederick Long in 2012 that seeks to produce materials in language, hermeneutics, and pedagogy, with a particular emphasis on the acquisition of the biblical languages. Currently, GlossaHouse offers a number of series that vary both in purpose and methodology, though only two are relevant for the current discussion. The first is Accessible Greek Resources & Online Studies (AGROS), which is a

tiered curriculum suite featuring innovative readers, grammars, specialized studies, and other exegetical resources to encourage and foster the exegetical use of biblical Greek. ... There are also two resource tracks: Conversational and Translational. Both involve intensive study of morphology, grammar, syntax, and discourse features. *The conversational track specifically values the spoken word, and the enhanced learning associated with speaking a language in actual conversation.* The translational track values the written word, and encourages analytical study to aide in understanding and translating biblical Greek and other Greek literature. The two resource tracks complement one another and can be pursued independently or together. (Long, 2015, p. xv, italics added)

While the above description mentions a “conversational track,” the primary grammar book appears to be strictly GT-oriented and highly focused on discourse grammar specifically, leaving the “conversational” elements to other resources (see this section,

below). One strength of Long's (2015) grammar book is its integration with cultural artifacts (curricular integration):

Chapters will usually have a least one image of ancient realia, i.e., remnants of Mediterranean material culture including biblical and non-biblical papyri fragments, vase paintings, coins, bas-reliefs, an imperial seal, inscriptions, funerary stele, statues, gems, temples, maps, and reconstructed scenes of life in the polis. The language and syntax of the Greek NT is contextually located in these worlds at some level. (Long, 2015, p. xix)

As in Overland's (2014) book, these could be converted into the Content-Based Instruction recommended by Stoller and Grabe (1997) or Spada and Lightbown (2008) to align them with CLT principles, though this does not seem to be the focus of the "translational" track.

The AGROS series also contains a number of resources that foster communicative language use, including a picture vocabulary book, a conversational phrasebook, a short illustrated story, video files, and audio companions.

The second relevant resource that GlossaHouse produces is the *Illustrated Biblical Texts* series, which contains the biblical text formatted in an illustrated comic book-style that is colorful and attractive. This resource is particularly helpful for accumulating vocabulary and can be used for building reading comprehension and fluency. However, because the biblical text is usually too difficult for beginning learners, this book would be more appropriate extensive reading material for intermediate learners. Currently, only the book of Mark is available.

Overall, the various resources from GlossaHouse seem somewhat eclectic and divided as to their pedagogical approach, some proving to be more helpful than others. And there does not appear to be one *primary* Greek textbook that thoroughly incorporates

CLT principles. Nonetheless, there are certainly some helpful (albeit isolated) resources that can serve to supplement a communicative Koiné Greek class.

Conclusion

All things considered, Buth's *Living Biblical Hebrew: Introduction Part One* (Buth, 2006a) follows SL teaching principles more closely than any available biblical language curricula, particularly as a self-study textbook since learners are introduced to the L2 directly in the L2, receive much implicit, comprehensible input, and begin learning to read the L2 without having to translate into their L1. *Living Biblical Hebrew: Introduction Part Two* (Buth, 2006b) has some helpful characteristics—namely the dialogues which can be adapted/expanded for real language use—but it also has significant room for improvement, particularly for use in a classroom. Overland's (2014) *Learning Biblical Hebrew Interactively*, on the other hand, offers more interactive activities that facilitate language production, making *that aspect* more beneficial for classroom use. Concerning Greek textbooks, Rico's (2015) *Speaking Ancient Greek as a Living Language* and Buth's (2008a) *Living Koiné Greek, Part One* are the most consistent with SLA principles. The former is best for use within a classroom with a teacher who is skilled in SL teaching, while the latter is best used as a self-study textbook (or as supplement in a classroom context) because of the amount of comprehensible input. Together, these two textbooks compensate for the other's weaknesses (discussed in this chapter, in their respective sections above) and provide a significant amount of excellent learning material for learners of Koiné Greek.

Institutes and Language Programs

To reiterate, the following evaluations of biblical language institutes and programs are limited to what is stated about them on their websites, regardless of the present author's personal involvement with various ones which enable him to further expound on the strengths and weaknesses of some. The goal, however, is to remain as objective as possible.

Polis: The Jerusalem Institute of Languages and Humanities

The Polis Institute seeks to reconnect Western Civilization with its roots in the Judeo-Christian tradition and Hellenic-Roman culture by imparting fluent reading abilities in the primary ancient languages, including, but not limited to, Greek, Latin, Aramaic, Hebrew, and Arabic. The goal is for students to be able to access primary source documents without the need for translation or consultation of grammar books. In response to the traditional approach to teaching these ancient languages, the institute developed the Polis Method (Rico, n.d.b) which teaches the ancient languages as living ones, using full immersion in the L2. This makes the Polis Institute “one of the very few institutions in the world that teach the so-called dead languages (e.g., Koine Greek, biblical Hebrew, and Latin) as modern languages” (Rico, 2015, p. XIII-XIV). Rico (n.d.b) described the Polis Method this way:

From the first day, teachers transform the class into a monolingual space where only the target language is used by the students as well as the teachers. It is no longer possible to ask questions in another language, the students do not speak amongst themselves or with the teacher except in the target language, as is commonly the case for the acquisition of modern languages. ... [The Polis Method] consists essentially of Total Physical Response, on interactive narrative, on Story Building, on pair-work etc. with recourse to images, props and songs. (p. 2)

The institute claims that this approach “enables students after two years of study (or the equivalent in two summers of intensive courses) to read and understand a simple ancient text with no need of a dictionary or translation” (Rico, n.d.a), which seems very reasonable given the nature of the program.

One relatively minor weakness is the adherence to a silent period, wherein learners do not speak for the first parts of the course, though it is not stated how long the period is. Rico (n.d.b) reasons that, “According to the natural order of native language acquisition, one ought to be able to speak before learning to read” (p. 1). This is reminiscent of Krashen (1982) and others who maintained the L1 = L2 Hypotheses of language acquisition, which most current researchers now discount as relevant for SLA, especially among adult learners. Also, the strict adherence to L2-only instruction does not necessarily guarantee the most efficient learning for adult L2 learners who can greatly be helped by *brief* comments, explanations, and/or glosses in the learners’ L1 (Nation, 2001, pp. 85–86, 90).

Nonetheless, from its description, the Polis Method closely reflects the SLA research, specifically the ten principles discussed in Chapter 4. Therefore, from a CLT perspective, the Polis Institute appears to be one of the most robust and comprehensive ancient language learning programs available.

The Conversational Koine Institute

The Conversational Koine Institute (CKI) is an online institute founded by Michael Halcomb. While the institute claims to be “on the cutting-edge of language teaching” and “grounded in solid language-learning theory,” no research is cited and only this description of the program is provided:

When paired with hearing, speaking is not just a quick tool to help learners “memorize,” but rather, a tried-and-true approach that helps them “internalize” a language. That, by the way, makes it much more fun than the rote memorization of vocab words! When one takes this kind of approach, languages come alive! At CKI we strive to bring languages to life for learners, which is part of the reason we're fond of saying, at CKI “We Are Living Language!” (Halcomb, n.d.)

While the language certainly points to a communicative methodology, the brevity and vagueness of this description precludes a detailed assessment of how well CKI’s pedagogical approach truly reflects each of the SL teaching principles from Chapter 4.

Institute for Biblical Languages and Translation

The Institute for Biblical Languages and Translation (IBLT) is a new initiative designed to equip Bible translators (in particular) with the Hebrew language. There are two levels to this program. The first is a one-month intensive Introduction to Biblical Hebrew course, 90 percent of which is taught in biblical Hebrew. Students

quickly and effectively learn biblical Hebrew within a naturally enjoyable learning process. Using oral teaching methods is known to be the best way in which a language is learned, even when reading is the primary goal. Students of this course have the opportunity to lay a foundation for true internalization of the biblical language. (Institute for Biblical Languages & Translation, n.d.b)

The lack of detail in this description (e.g., “naturally enjoyable learning process” and “oral teaching methods”) precludes an accurate assessment of whether or not this program follows each of the CLT principles discussed in Chapter 4, though the language seems to suggest that it does, at least in general.

The Introduction to Biblical Hebrew course, which is the equivalent of one full year (6 units) of seminary level Hebrew, fulfills the prerequisite for the next level of the program, the School of Biblical Hebrew, which is an 8-month program that is designed “to equip participants with the skills necessary for proficiency in translating the Old Testament directly from the source language” (Institute for Biblical Languages &

Translation, n.d.d). This program is unique in several ways. First, it takes place in Israel, the land of the Bible, thereby integrating the historical, geographical, linguistic, and cultural settings of the texts being studied. Second, while this program incorporates the use of modern Hebrew for the most efficient internalization of biblical Hebrew, even the biblical Hebrew dialect is taught using communicative methodologies. According to the institute,

Language instruction utilizes a variety of techniques drawn from current research in the field of second language acquisition (SLA), so that learners find themselves in a language-rich, meaning-focused environment with lots of opportunities to interact with one another, negotiate meaning, and communicate ideas all in biblical Hebrew. Some techniques include picture storyboards, Total Physical Response (TPR), role-playing, and Teaching Proficiency through Reading and Storytelling (TPRS). These language teaching techniques and questions and answers in Hebrew on the biblical texts fill the classroom with understandable biblical Hebrew as the oral medium from the first lessons. (Institute for Biblical Languages & Translation, n.d.e)

This description very much reflects the principles that SLA research suggests are needed for efficient language acquisition.

The Institute for Biblical Languages and Translation also offers a Biblical Hebrew Fluency and Pedagogy Workshop, where participants are equipped with the pedagogical framework to teach biblical Hebrew using CLT. The program believes that “efficient language learning ... requires rapid oral communication in the new language” and that a classroom marked by such communicative activity “greatly widens the gate for more students to experience success in learning biblical Hebrew and makes language learning more naturally enjoyable” (Institute for Biblical Languages & Translation, n.d.a). These statements coincide with facilitating language production, aiming for fluency before accuracy, and ensuring social relevance. The various programs offered by the Institute for Biblical Languages and Translation, particularly the 8-month flagship School of Biblical

Hebrew program, make it the first of its kind in the history of biblical language instruction. It should, however, be reiterated that this institute has not quite been fully launched.

Biblical Language Center

The Biblical Language Center offers intensive immersion courses in biblical Hebrew and Koiné Greek, where the spoken target language is used for more than 90 percent of class instruction. The courses are usually run in Israel, where learners are able to experience the land of the Bible, thereby integrating the L2 with its historical geography. Each course is taught by two instructors, which provides more natural opportunities for comprehensible input. Meaningful interaction in the language is fostered by creative activities, dialogues, Total Physical Response (TPR), Teaching Proficiency through Reading and Storytelling (TPRS), and other tasks that require the use of the target language. Learners begin to read and discuss biblical texts in the language with immediate comprehension and without the need for translation. According to the Biblical Language Center,

We have found that a successful language learner already starts to think in and to understand a language before literacy. An effective audio and oral internalization of a language is necessary to enhance reading comprehension and speed, and to boost long-term retention. One cannot fluently read the Bible in its original languages, without those very languages living inside of them. (Biblical Language Center, n.d.a)

The courses are also designed to be relaxing and fun, in order to lower the affective filter for adult language learners. For homework, learners use *Living Biblical Hebrew* (Buth, 2006a, 2006b, 2006c) and/or *Living Koiné Greek* (Buth, 2008a, 2008b, 2008c), which were described in the previous section. The immersion courses and fluency workshops offered by the Biblical Language Center stand with the Polis Institute as being the most

thoroughly communicative biblical language programs available. However, in general, only one beginning courses (and sometimes a Hebrew intermediate course) are offered only once a year during the summer.

Fresno Pacific University

Finally, Fresno Pacific University's (FPU) Hebrew program has been a work in progress for nine years. Brian Schultz, the professor in charge of Hebrew classes/programs at FPU, uses a communicative methodology to teach biblical Hebrew at both the undergraduate and graduate levels. This program "goes beyond teaching you how to decode and translate biblical Hebrew. It aims at making the language 'living' inside of you so that you can read the Bible fluently without needing to translate it" (Schultz, n.d.). Minimal focus is placed on learning explicit grammar rules and vocabulary lists; rather, learners are encouraged to use the language in meaningful contexts from day one. Using CLT to teach the biblical languages is almost unheard of among American institutions of Christian higher education, which makes the Hebrew program at FPU unique.

Personal Experiences

The rationale for this section, as stated in the introduction of this chapter, is to provide a more detailed evaluation of BLC's and FPU's biblical Hebrew programs based on the present author's first-hand experience. Consequently, the SL teaching principles delineated in Chapter 4 will be more specifically addressed in this section.

Biblical Language Center

BLC's six-week Hebrew immersion course consisted of both a beginning and an intermediate course (8 units total), which involved 4 hours of instruction per day, five

days a week. This was the present author's first experience learning biblical Hebrew with CLT. He had studied Hebrew for three years prior to this as well as taught beginning Hebrew one year, all under a GT approach. However, being immersed in a classroom that was filled with 90+ percent of spoken biblical Hebrew proved to be a *very* different experience. This is because the target language was taught in the target language through the use of Total Physical Response (responding physically to verbal commands in the L2), interactive storytelling, games, songs, activities, and discussions about various topics, stories, and biblical texts. There was a vast amount of implicit instruction, as the classroom was filled with props and pictures and the teachers took the students on frequent excursions to explore the outdoors. Language production was facilitated primarily through questions and answers over stories and biblical texts that prompted negotiation of meaning. Language awareness was fostered (both intensively and extensively, proactively and reactively—see Chapter 4, “Foster Language Awareness”) as grammar instruction was embedded in communicative examples from class activities. Language skills were integrated throughout the course (though writing was noticeably the least emphasized). Cultural and curricular integration were maintained partly because the course took place in the land of the Bible which provided opportunities for field trips and valuable instruction outside the classroom. Learning opportunities were maximized to a large extent as everything became a teaching opportunity, including speaking Hebrew during lunches. The presence of two teachers also maximized learning opportunities and provided the facilitation of smaller group work, not to mention created. Class time was focused more on communicating meaning than on explicit grammatical accuracy which led to greater L2 fluency, even though specific fluency-building activities as described by

Nation (2007) were lacking. Learner autonomy was promoted through learners' participation in the story-telling activities, though students were still quite dependent on the instructors for learning to take place. Lastly, the course proved to be socially relevant as the focus remained on meaning-making and learners participated in a language-rich social environment. In short, BLC's immersion course was an excellent example of how CLT can effectively be applied to the teaching of biblical Hebrew.

The results of this learning experience are crucial to highlight. The present author found that the Hebrew being used to communicate, play games, interact, accomplish tasks, and tell stories in this learning context did not at all contradict the explicit knowledge he had learned from biblical Hebrew GT textbooks prior to this experience, as some skeptics claim is the case with communicative biblical language classes. Rather, the immense amount of comprehensible input/output quickly led to an implicit knowledge of the language that essentially overshadowed the pre-existing explicit knowledge and produced an automaticity that had never been there before, even after three years of studying and one year of teaching Hebrew. This implicit knowledge of the L2 system rendered much of his explicit knowledge largely *unnecessary* because the lower-level text processing that used to consume his working memory had become automatized, making him a *much* more fluent reader of the text than he was previously. This massive increase in L2 proficiency took place in only six intensive weeks of instruction.

Fresno Pacific University

The author's second experience of learning biblical Hebrew communicatively was a result of his studies in Ancient Language Acquisition through FPU's Individualized Master of Arts Program under the supervision of Brian Schultz. It was here where a 10-

day Hebrew fluency workshop was held in conjunction with BLC which involved 8 hours of instruction per day for all ten days. In many ways, this experience proved to be similar to the previous immersion course except for two key distinctions. First, small groups, each led by a language facilitator, were utilized much more during the fluency workshop than during the six-week course. This served to increase the opportunities for learners to produce the language and prompted more interaction among learners and teachers. Another key distinction was the utilization of fluency-building activities that included repetition of familiar language and time constraints which forced learners to produce the L2 faster than they normally would have (Nation, 2007; Wood, 2001). This workshop proved to be yet another valuable example of how “dead” languages can indeed be taught as “living” languages.

Finally, the author’s first-hand experience both as a teaching assistant and as an adjunct professor of Hebrew at FPU provides further support that CLT principles can be effectively applied to the teaching of biblical Hebrew. Brian Schultz, who leads the Hebrew program at FPU, has been teaching biblical Hebrew communicatively there for nine years. Similar to BLC’s courses, these classes consist of interaction in the L2, TPR, Teaching Proficiency through Reading and Storytelling (TPRS), reading and discussing biblical texts, the daily use of props, the performance of dialogues, songs, and cultural explanations/celebrations of Jewish feasts and holidays. Based on students’ request, Schultz even runs an annual Hebrew retreat where students spend three days at a cabin in the mountains and are encouraged to speak only Hebrew for the majority of the time. Games are conducted in Hebrew, and a traditional Passover meal is sometimes held (though not necessarily in Hebrew). The present author’s role as a teaching assistant to

Schultz for one year greatly increased the learning opportunities for students as more small group activities could be facilitated, thereby increasing student interaction and output. Even when there is not a TA, however, it is not uncommon for upper level Hebrew students to voluntarily attend the beginning Hebrew class, which not only serves to increase those students' fluency but also allows Schultz to leverage their higher skills for teaching the beginning students. This Hebrew program has flourished in the years that Schultz has been teaching. (See Schultz, 2014, November 25, for an extended reflection on his experience at FPU.) The Hebrew program at FPU is yet another helpful example of how CLT is being applied to the teaching of biblical Hebrew and is being met with great success.

Conclusion

As is evident, there certainly exists a growing interest in the application of SLA research to the teaching of the biblical languages. Textbooks and institutes that affirm the value of SLA principles are becoming more and more popular within the field of biblical language pedagogy. In this way, great strides have been made towards a more holistic approach that acknowledges the need to incorporate all four language skills in the teaching of the biblical languages in order to produce more fluent readers of the biblical text.

Such efforts, however, still remain on the fringe of the field at large and the extent to which—or the consistency with which—these resources implement CLT principles clearly varies. Some of the efforts prove to be unprincipled at best, while others follow more or less sound principles. Other isolated efforts seem to have evolved primarily from teacher practice, creating a “do-what-works” mentality. While this is not entirely a bad

thing, it must again be pointed out that most teachers of the biblical languages have never been exposed to SLA literature, and therefore they do not tend to think in terms of CLT practices. Even those who have experimented with CLT have often learned what they know simply from experiencing it themselves via intensive courses or fluency workshops that the Biblical Language Center runs, for instance, and not through primary research of the SLA literature. Again, this is not inherently wrong—experiencing the methodology is often more beneficial than learning about it—but neither is it sufficient to sustain the development and credibility of the CLT movement among biblical languages.

Part of the reason for this irregularity in effective implementation is that the textbooks and institutes do not appear to be based on any common body of research that is acknowledged by the movement at large. Independent research has and is being done and isolated efforts are being made, but this often results either in the reinvention of the wheel or in disparate teaching practices among various textbooks and institutes. This is not at all surprising. Savignon (2007), for instance, points out that in the context of CLT in the 21st century, “when it comes to curricular design and implementation, there persists widespread confusion and debate” (p. 208). If this is true of modern language practitioners who have had much more access to the SLA research, then it is not surprising that “confusion and debate” exists among biblical language teachers who have not.

In short, there exists no extensive treatment of how SLA research can effectively be applied to create a more *principled communicative methodology for teaching the biblical languages*. If such an approach can be constructed, then it seems reasonable that teachers of the biblical languages should not only be aware of the principles contained

therein but should incorporate them into their own teaching of the biblical languages.

They are, after all, teaching “second” languages.

ⁱ Two examples of *classical* Greek and Latin textbooks that implement aspects of CLT are *Ancient Greek Alive* (Saffire & Freis, 1999) and *Lingua Latina per se illustrata, pars 1: Familia Romana*, 2nd ed. (Ørberg, 2011). Also, *When Dead Tongues Speak: Teaching Beginning Greek and Latin* (Gruber-Miller, ed., 2006) pertains to the need for CLT among classical Greek and Latin, though it is not a textbook per se.

Ancient Greek Alive (Saffire & Freis, 1999) implements “conversational” Greek for the first nine lessons (covering two weeks of class). The integration of written, oral, and aural language skills from the beginning is helpful, as are the opportunities for interaction among learners. Saffire (2006) stated regarding her approach, “I believe that production enhances learning, from the beginning” (Kindle location 2451), a principle supported by Swain (1985, 1995), Kumaravadivelu (1994), Nation (2007), and others. The book also contains numerous stories—some of which are tales from other cultures translated into Greek, while others are authentic Greek texts selected from a variety of sources—that provide helpful reading material that is appropriate for beginning learners.

Negatively, the fact that the dialogues are scripted mostly precludes the necessity for negotiation of meaning as well as the opportunity for natural communication to take place, despite the authors’ claim to create “*spontaneous, conversational ancient Greek*” (Saffire, 2006, Kindle location 2335, italics added). Additionally—and most seriously—after the first nine lessons, “conversation and other oral practices are ... phased out, almost entirely. The two weeks provide an introduction to Greek grammar, which helps the students learn throughout the year. (Saffire, 2006, Kindle locations 2342-2343). While their desire to employ CLT is praiseworthy, the brevity with which they use it is severely inadequate. One wonders, if interacting in the L2 works so well, why stop doing it? Saffire explains why, seemingly contradicting her earlier arguments for the validity and efficiency of interaction in the L2:

In a nutshell: time. I have been unable to shake my conviction that college students should master the paradigms of common nouns and the entire normal verb during the first year of Greek. And it seems to me there is not time for them to do this and keep talking. Another reason is that once we begin systematic learning, with complete paradigms, our ability to read ancient Greek forms rapidly outpaces our ability to produce them. (Both forms and accent shifts are difficult.) And finally, it becomes harder and harder to find conversational contexts for all the words, as the vocabulary becomes more abstract. (Saffire, 2006, Kindle locations 2607-2611)

Saffire (2006) clearly does not represent a robust understanding of what CLT entails in a principled form. This sentiment is revealed when she states that dropping translation work from the class in order to continue speaking Greek would be “Loosen[ing] my standards” (Saffire, 2006, Kindle locations 2613). In conclusion, while the first nine lessons of this textbook may be moving closer to what is needed in ancient Greek classes, the textbook as a whole does not follow a principled communicative methodology for teaching ancient languages.

Lingua Latina per se illustrata, pars 1: Familia Romana, 2nd ed. (Ørberg, 2011) is a Latin textbook written entirely in Latin. The meaning of all new words and forms is immediately understandable based on the context as well as marginal notes (in Latin) and/or illustrations. It is based on an intentionally graded and entertaining story about a Roman family situated in the second century AD, which beautifully integrates cultural and historical backgrounds. The book introduces 1500 words and Latin grammar is taught implicitly in meaningful contexts throughout. Each section concludes with a brief grammar explanation in Latin that discusses the forms introduced in that section, all with a focus on meaning (i.e., Focus on Form). This textbook represents an ideal book for learning ancient languages communicatively, and without the need for grammatical analysis or translation.

CHAPTER 7: TOWARD A PRINCIPLED COMMUNICATIVE METHODOLOGY FOR TEACHING THE BIBLICAL LANGUAGES

Introduction

Thus far, the history of language instruction has been laid forth including a description of the GT approach (Chapter 3), a summary of SL teaching principles derived from current SLA research has been detailed (Chapter 4), GT has been evaluated in light of that SLA research (Chapter 5), and the recent textbooks and institutes that claim to implement communicative methodologies to the teaching of the biblical languages have been summarized and briefly evaluated (Chapter 6).

It has been concluded that the GT approach is two centuries behind the latest SLA research and therefore is not characterized by the principles that SLA research shows are required for effective language acquisition. Despite the claims of authors of GT textbooks to have produced a more innovative textbook that makes learning the biblical languages easier (e.g., Mounce, 2009; Fuller & Choi, 2006), their approaches are merely repackaged forms of the age-old GT which has a poor track record for producing competent users of the biblical languages. Moreover, some of those who claim to have implemented CLT principles to the teaching of the biblical languages have been shown to be inconsistent and/or unprincipled as well. What is needed is a more principled communicative methodology for teaching the biblical languages.

To this end, all of the SL teaching principles derived from SLA research that were discussed in Chapter 4 will now be evaluated in regards to their applicability to the

teaching of the biblical languages, specifically biblical Hebrew. This evaluation will be based primarily on two sources of data. The first is the SLA research summarized in Chapter 4 which forms the bedrock of data. The plausibility of applying this research to the teaching of the biblical languages will be discussed generally under “The Purpose” (this chapter, below) and more specifically under “Teach How to Use the Target Language in the Target Language” (this chapter, below).

The second source of data is drawn from the present author’s first-hand experience both as a student and as a teacher. The former of these experiences was described above (see Chapter 6, “Personal Experiences”). The latter has consisted of extensive first-hand experience implementing and experimenting with these principles while teaching biblical Hebrew for various programs over the last seven years. These teaching contexts include:

- The Bethlehem Institute: 3-unit course, taught 1 time and co-taught 2 times
- Teaching assistant at FPU: 6-unit course, co-taught 1 time
- BLC: 6-unit course (1-month intensive), co-taught 1 time
- Adjunct professor at FPU: 8-unit course, taught 1 time
- Teaching Online: taught beginning and intermediate levels intermittently for 4 years
- Grace Clovis Presbyterian Church: 3-unit course, taught 1 time

All this teaching (except one year of teaching for The Bethlehem Institute) was conducted using communicative methodologies, though admittedly, the approach has been more thoroughly executed in some contexts than in others. Nonetheless, it has provided the opportunity for considerable classroom research to be conducted. Much

work has therefore been exerted towards creating a principled communicative methodology for teaching biblical Hebrew based on both SLA research and classroom research.ⁱⁱ

It is on the basis of these two sources of data that the applicability of the ten SL teaching principles for teaching biblical Hebrew will be evaluated. After each evaluation, specific examples of how these principles can be implemented in a communicative biblical Hebrew class will be provided, particularly so that those with no SLA background can get a sense of what a CLT class *can* look like. Lastly, constraints and limitations, if any, of the applicability of each principle to the teaching of biblical Hebrew will be addressed. First, a few important preliminary considerations must be attended to.

Preliminary Considerations

The very notion of teaching a “dead” language as a “living” language has been met by many within the field of biblical languages with great skepticism. Some may acknowledge the vision but deny the possibility of such an endeavor, while others fail to see the advantages it offers for those whose primary goal is only to read ancient texts. Concerning the latter objection, hopefully it is clear from the SLA research why a CLT is indeed beneficial, even for those who do not intend to communicate with a broader L2 community. To recap, CLT leads to more fluent reading skills than GT primarily because it develops automaticity of lower-level processes that tend to consume one’s working memory when learning via GT (see Chapter 4).

However, while the argument that CLT is a better way to teach the biblical languages may be theoretically intriguing, the objection still stands whether or not it is even possible. Can one legitimately apply the same research, virtually none of which was

conducted with ancient languages in sight, to the teaching of the biblical languages? To state the question differently, is it possible to teach a now “fossilized” language—or, only that portion of the language that is preserved in the literature—the same way one teaches a modern “living” language? Most assume it is *not* possible because there is no living community that speaks “dead” languages and therefore no one knows how they were spoken or what they sounded like. Three points will be addressed in response to this question and its assumed answer.

First, it should be noted that learning ancient languages rather than modern languages does not alter the way the human brain learns languages best. As stated above, empirical research from cognitive science and psychology demonstrates that the brain learns most knowledge implicitly (N. Ellis, 2005). This reality does not depend on the content of that knowledge, in this case whether one is learning an ancient or modern language. This means the second language *acquisition* research equally applies to the *learning* of both modern and ancient languages. It is the second language *teaching* research where one might expect the greatest differences (see third point below).

Second, while it may be the case that very little SLA research has been applied to the teaching of the biblical languages, there is *no* research suggesting it *cannot* be done. Indeed, the possibility of recovering a language that was once learned and used as a “living” language is not as unreasonable of an idea as some claim—or assume—it is. However, even if there remain some differences between teaching ancient and modern languages, the idea should not be dismissed altogether. That is, it should *not* be assumed that *none* of the SLA research applies to the teaching of the biblical languages. It seems that such a significant field of study as SLA is entitled to a more thoughtful consideration

and research-based response than one based on what could possibly be mere misguided assumptions.

Third, teaching a language communicatively when there is no living community is not much different than the way modern languages are taught in foreign language (FL) contexts—that is, teaching a language in the context of a culture in which the L2 is *not* the dominant language (e.g., learning Mandarin Chinese at an American university).

According to Ellen Jackson, the International Language and Culture Learning Coordinator for the Summer Institute of Linguistics (SIL), “Every language is dead in the classroom; it is up to the teacher to create a living environment” (E. Jackson, personal communication, November 17, 2010). In other words, the argument that the biblical languages cannot be spoken because there is no living language community that uses them is a moot point inside the FL classroom where there is no living language community even for modern languages and where the teachers often are not native speakers of the target languages themselves. Therefore, if modern languages can be taught by a single non-native teacher in a FL context using an approach that is supported by SLA research, then it seems reasonable that the biblical languages can as well.

Further, the fact that the entire language systems of the biblical languages are not preserved for modern readers does not preclude the teaching of what *is* preserved via CLT any more than a first year Spanish class does not preclude the teaching of only that portion of Spanish “preserved” in beginning Spanish curricula via a communicative approach. In this respect, the context for teaching biblical language classes resembles FL classes more than many people realize. Certainly, there are some pedagogical limitations which will be addressed in the discussions of each principle below (specifically see this

chapter, “Teach How to Use the Target Language in the Target Language”), but in theory, there is no reason why modern SLA research cannot and should not be applied to the teaching of the biblical languages.

In conclusion, the fact that relatively little of the SLA research is specific to the *biblical* languages does not preclude the present investigation for the three reasons stated above. Indeed, the assumption that the biblical languages cannot be taught similarly to modern languages is just that—an assumption. If it can be shown that the SLA research can effectively be applied to the teaching of the biblical languages, then it behooves ancient language instructors to study the literature. Not to do so would be irresponsible and a disservice to students. Nonetheless, even if it cannot be proven that such a task is feasible with the biblical languages *to the same degree* that it is with modern languages, there may still be an abundance of pedagogical principles that apply which would improve the overall experience and outcome for biblical language students.

Identifying the Sociocultural Context and Purpose

The sociocultural nature of language teaching has already been argued for in Chapter 4 (see “Ensure Social Relevance”; Hall & Verplaetse, 2000). To reiterate, some of the characteristics of a sociocultural theory of language learning include acknowledging individual learning styles, viewing language as a social tool used to communicate, appreciating diversity among learners, considering a learner’s competence in terms of relative (not absolute) correctness, and engaging learners in using the language to accomplish a variety of tasks (Savignon, 2007). In addition to these features, absolutely central to a sociocultural perspective of language teaching is the context and

purpose of language teaching, both of which must *be defined* prior to the teaching act, as well as *define* it throughout.

The Context

The teaching context includes such questions as, What cultural values shape the students' view of education and the teacher-student relationship? What resources does a teacher have at her disposal for teaching? What are the demographics of the learners and are there social factors to be considered there? Is one teaching online or face-to-face? Once a week or every day? How much class time is available and how much homework time are learners expected to contribute before each class? These all deal with the learning context and will affect how the SL teaching principles are applied.

Concerning the context of biblical language instruction, the vast majority of it takes place within formal academic settings, usually at institutes of higher education such as a college, university, or seminary. As discussed in “Preliminary Considerations” above, this context is essentially that of a FL context in which learners are generally not able to engage with L2 speakers outside of the classroom. While this may not be as ideal as an SL context—where learners *are* able to interact with the broader culture in which the dominant language is the same as the learners' L2—it by no means prevents language acquisition from happening. It simply requires that the teacher exercises her creativity to draw from as many resources as possible—people, pictures, props, texts, videos, dialogues, relics—to construct a lively, engaging, language-rich, communicative environment that is filled with comprehensible input.

Socio-political and cultural norms must also be considered. For instance, Western cultures tend to value teacher-student interaction and teachers are often viewed as co-

learners alongside students. Upper-level classes sometimes adopt the Socratic method, in which classes tend to be smaller and are characterized by dialogue and debate, making the learning process more personal and intimate. Mistakes are to be embraced and learned from.

In Asian cultures, however, the teacher is viewed as the superior to whom students come to attain knowledge. A teacher placing himself on the level of a learner is therefore a fundamental taboo. Hui (1997) stated that in “Chinese culture, teachers are viewed as knowledge holders. If teachers do not display their knowledge in lectures, or if they play games with students or ask students to role-play in class, then they are not doing their job!” (p. 38). Further, the priority of saving face in Asian cultures means that mistakes are to be avoided at all costs. This is a difficult hurdle to overcome, considering the nature of language acquisition. These socio-political and cultural differences have rendered numerous attempts to implement Western-developed forms of CLT in countries like China (Hui, 1997) and South Korea (Li, 1998) failed endeavors. In other words, language classes in Asian cultures likely need to be more teacher-centered because of the social context. This is not only permissible, it is essential. To force these particular learners into an educational mold that rubs against the grain of their entire culture would only prove disastrous to their learning, despite what research might suggest in other cultures. However, this does not mean that the SLA research does not apply; rather, the principles must simply be adapted and implemented somewhat differently.

The following principled communicative approach for teaching the biblical languages assumes a traditional, face-to-face academic context in an English L1, Western culture that values teacher-student interaction and learner diversity. That being said, the

core of these principles applies—with some modifications—to most other contexts as well, including informal/non-academic settings, teaching online, and in many non-Western contexts.

The Purpose

Languages are learned for a variety of purposes that affect one's attitude in the learning process. Is a learner required to take this course but does not have the desire to do so? Is one learning the L2 for travel? For work? Is it an elective class? Are there political pressures for why a particular culture is forced to learn another language? There will always be a communicative need (even if it is purely for pleasure) that will drive the learning process and influence the success or failure of language acquisition.

Regarding the purpose for biblical language instruction, it can safely be assumed that anyone who learns the biblical languages does so for the purpose of reading the Bible in its original languages. What one does with that reading might vary anywhere from historical research, to linguistic analysis, to preaching a sermon but all of these “ultimate” goals begin with the learners' eyes meeting the text in order to comprehend its meaning.

As has been repeatedly emphasized, CLT's primary goal is to equip learners to be able to communicate in the L2. For this reason, many teachers of the biblical languages have objected to a communicative approach because the primary goal of biblical language instruction is to be able to *read* ancient texts, not *communicate* with others in the language. However, this line of thinking does not acknowledge that reading *is* one of the primary modes of communication! Indeed, Gruber-Miller (2006) has pointed out that “at a minimum, communication involves at least two people: a speaker and a listener, or *a writer and a reader*” (Kindle location 246, italics added). Furthermore, because the

process of reading is regarded as a generative, compositional, meaning-making activity (see Hudson, 2007, p. 264–65), reading ancient literature can, in a very real sense, be understood as a conversation between an ancient author and a modern reader. The question is, what language will the modern reader be “hearing”? Can modern readers fluently converse with this ancient author on the author’s own terms and in his own language? Or will this conversation require a translator? In other words, what language is being used to engage with and think about the text being read? Whether the modern biblical language teacher realizes it or not, his goal remains fundamentally social in nature.

It must be emphasized that the primary goal of applying SLA research to the biblical languages is *not* ultimately to have fun, to sing songs, to role play, or to be able to express how one feels, recount a past event, or explain how to build a winepress in the L2. Rather, it is about achieving a robust level of literacy that *includes*—is not solely *comprised of*—the skill of reading. In other words, the reading process cannot be decontextualized from the broader category of literacy. Kern (2000) and Gee (1998) have argued for a view of literacy that extends well beyond the mere transfer of information via reading and writing (Gee, 1998, p. 55). While reading ancient texts may be the primary goal of biblical language learners, this goal will only be met, according to Kern and Gee, in the context of a truly literate community of scholars who are able not merely to decode symbols on a page, but to converse with one another, collaborate, discuss interpretive issues, and reflect on the application of sacred texts—all *within* the languages themselves. This sphere of sociocultural interaction that involves the use of an L2 (in this case either Hebrew or Greek) is what Gee (1998) terms a (secondary) discourse, and in

order to be considered literate, one must “control” the use of the L2 in its secondary discourse (p. 56). ‘Control’ here does not necessarily mean *mastery* (i.e., “full and effortless control”); rather, one must be able to use, to function with, the L2 (p. 57). Similarly, Savignon (2007) has pointed out that the term “communicative competence” does not imply that learners will necessarily reach a native-like fluency (p. 211). Nevertheless, without the ability to converse and share ideas in the L2—to engage in social activities—one will not be truly literate in the L2, in the full sense of the term.

Therefore, the ultimate purpose of the following principled communicative methodology for teaching the biblical languages is to develop learners who are truly literate in the L2. That is, they possess a communicative competence that enables them to engage not just with one another, but with ancient authors—authors who would surely appreciate being read on their own terms.

The Applicability of Second Language Teaching Principles to the Teaching of Biblical Hebrew

To reiterate, the following evaluation of the applicability of SL teaching principles will be based on two sources of data: SLA research and the author’s personal classroom research. The hope is to create, if possible, a more principled communicative methodology for teaching the biblical languages than what has been practiced by some, and to build on the excellent work that has already been achieved by others. It should be noted again that while this particular discussion will be limited to the teaching of biblical Hebrew, the results should theoretically also apply to the teaching of Koiné Greek (or any ancient language for that matter).

Teach How to Use the Target Language in the Target Language

This principle is specifically and intentionally stated the way it is in order to highlight the fact that the ultimate goal in language learning—even biblical language learning—is functional *use* of the language. It is neither sufficient nor accurate to make the claim that one’s goal is merely reading because fluent reading skills require the automatization of lower-level processing which is best achieved through hearing and speaking the L2, and because true literacy is much more robust than the isolated skill of reading (as discussed in the previous section). The goal is *communication* between an ancient author and a modern reader, but if one does not know how to communicate with other modern learners in the L2 where negotiation of meaning *is* possible, then it will be even more difficult to communicate with ancient authors where such interaction is *not* possible.

Because many of the other nine principles stand or fall on whether or not it is possible to teach the target language in the target language, this principle will be dealt with more comprehensively than the others.

Evaluation of applicability. Skeptics have criticized the possibility of teaching ancient languages communicatively, claiming that spontaneous, novel speech in the languages simply cannot be generated because they are now static, frozen, or “dead.” In many ways, this proves to be the heart of the entire issue. While SLA research may not address this question *directly*, it does indirectly. Moreover, the classroom research is quite compelling.

To recall the discussion from Chapter 6, the work being done by various institutes, especially the Biblical Language Center (BLC), the Polis Institute, the Institute

for Biblical Languages and Translation (IBLT), and Fresno Pacific University (FPU), provides much evidence that SLA-derived principles can indeed be applied to the teaching of the biblical languages, at least to some degree. In addition to these institutes, the publication of communicative textbooks indicates that the application of CLT to the teaching of the biblical languages is not merely a fanciful idea. Further, the present author's experiences both as a student and as a teacher give further credence to the possibility of applying SL teaching principles from the field of SLA to the teaching of the biblical languages.

The fact that some institutions are implementing CLT principles so effectively firmly suggests that the present research question—Can the same language teaching principles derived from modern Second Language Acquisition research be effectively applied to the teaching of the biblical languages?—can be answered affirmatively. It is under this assumption that the remaining principles will be evaluated. Understandably, however, there are still some important questions to address regarding the current principle—teach how to use the target language in the target language.

One question to consider is whether or not a limited (or “closed”) corpus of language can feasibly be used as a full-blown “living” language? To answer this question, it is necessary to consider the nature of language and of language learning. Language is a discrete combinatorial system which simply means that there exists a finite number of language components, which, when combined together, are able to create an *infinite* number of possible expressions. A limited corpus, therefore—whether the 50,000-word vocabulary of the average modern language speaker (Hudson, 2007, p. 227) or the 9,343-word vocabulary preserved in the Hebrew Bible—does not preclude the possibility of

using a language for authentic, communicative purposes. Children, whose vocabulary is much smaller than these sizes, communicate quite effectively, constantly producing original speech that they have never heard before—indeed, speech that has never been spoken in the history of the world! Such is the creative nature of the human mind combined with the infinite complexity and versatility of language. Not only do children produce novel speech, but they also reach fluency in their L1 when their vocabulary is still only a fraction the size of an adult vocabulary, which supports the possibility of Nation’s (2007) *SL* learning principle that language learners should be fluent with what they already know at every stage of acquisition. In other words, absolutely nothing prevents modern learners of biblical Hebrew from constructing novel speech—and doing so fluently—using the given vocabulary and following the grammatical rules known for biblical Hebrew.

Others claim that the limited corpus of biblical Hebrew simply does not provide sufficient *everyday* language to be able to communicate naturally in the L2. While this is true to an extent, one might be surprised at the amount of material that *is* available for the biblical languages, as well as at the relatively small percentage of one’s total vocabulary that is actually used for everyday communication.

Concerning the size of one’s vocabulary, it is generally agreed that knowing the 2,000 most common words in any given language will enable someone to read about 80 percent of the literature he will encounter in that language (Hudson, 2007, pp. 228, 232; Nation, 2001; Schmitt & Schmitt, 2012). In the case of biblical Hebrew, however, 83 percent of the entire text can be covered with only the 498 most frequent words and knowing the 2,000 most common words of biblical Hebrew actually places one close to

95 percent comprehension, which some estimate is needed for “reading unsimplified novels for pleasure” (Hirsch & Nation, 1992, as cited in Hudson, 2007, p. 232; Schmitt & Schmitt, 2012). While there may not be a one-to-one correspondence between the 2,000 most common words preserved in the Old Testament and the 2,000 most common words ancient Israelites would have used for everyday communicative purposes, the overlap is surely significant, as it would be between any modern spoken language and its literature. It is not surprising, therefore, to find a vast amount of useful, everyday vocabulary that is contained in the Hebrew Bible.

However, possessing adequate vocabulary for communication is one thing; knowing how to *use* this vocabulary is another issue. Although it is true that many literary genres were written in a more formal style, or high register, and thus may not precisely reflect the nature of everyday speech, it must be acknowledged that the written biblical text *is* still the same language. For instance, one could read a Sunday newspaper—which includes multiple genres and *roughly* the same number of words as the Old Testament text—and learn a great deal about how the English language is used in everyday speech. The same is true for biblical Hebrew. Of course, this requires extensive search efforts by those wishing to employ CLT for teaching biblical Hebrew. Bible software such as Accordance, Logos, and Bible Works, is absolutely essential for such a task, for they allow one to perform complex searches to determine how particular syntactic/grammatical structures were used, to find collocations for specific words, to discover the morphology of obscure verb forms, to evaluate pragmatic and discourse features in particular contexts, and so on. Direct speech in the text can also be assessed for a more accurate representation of how the language was actually used to

communicate. These tools enable modern learners to ascertain to a great extent how the biblical languages were really used by native speakers, which, in turn, ought to govern their use in the “modern” ancient language classroom.

For those involved in the pioneering task of “resurrecting” the “dead” biblical languages—for which there is no living community that uses them to communicate—it unquestionably requires explicit knowledge combined with the extant examples of what can be said, in order to produce novel speech that then must become proceduralized, or automatized through repeated use (see DeKeyser, 1998). Once that explicit knowledge has become implicit and teachers have developed some measure of automaticity, they will then be able to teach that knowledge through implicit instruction to new learners. As tedious as this process is, much of the initial work has already been successfully accomplished by Buth, Rico, and others who have been hard at work for over two decades, continually growing in fluency of the biblical dialects. Consequently, beginning learners are now able to study in their immersion programs (BLC and Polis Institute, respectively) and reach an intermediate level of communicative competence in a fraction of the time it took these pioneers to reach this level. As more and more teachers and learners interact and learn, the proficiency level of the field as a whole will only continue to grow.

The present author can testify to this experience. Shortly after his six-week immersion program in Israel, he began teaching Hebrew using CLT, despite not having developed full fluency. Nonetheless, being a teacher required him to produce the L2 more than he ever had. In order to know how to speak, he sought as much L2 comprehensible input as possible (primarily in the form of recordings from the six-week ulpan) and

immersed himself in the biblical text, scouring the language for needed forms, correct structures, pragmatic uses of the L2, common collocations, and so on. These practices have continued into numerous other teaching contexts over the last several years and have made him a much more fluent speaker of biblical Hebrew, and therefore a much better reader of the Old Testament.

Before considering some examples of specific classroom activities, it should be noted that the principle of teaching the target language in the target language applies to textbooks as well as to classes. When one opens a second language textbook, the vast majority of text ought to be in the L2. If one follows the principle stated by the American Council on the Teaching of Foreign Languages (discussed in Chapter 4, section “Teach How to Use the Target Language in the Target Language”), then at least 90 percent of the material in the textbook should be in the L2 (American Council on the Teaching of Foreign Languages, May, 2010). Rico’s (2015) *Speaking Ancient Greek as a Living Language* and Ørberg’s (2010) *Lingua Latina per se Illustrata, Pars 1: Familia Romana* (2nd ed.) are prime examples of textbooks that follow this principle, though no similar textbook currently exists for biblical Hebrew.

Examples of specific classroom activities. A simple way to begin introducing a verbal language component and to progress in oral proficiency is to leverage the dialogues contained in biblical texts. Baker and Kantor (2014) have proposed a systematic way in which “to infuse ... classrooms with grammatically authentic Biblical Hebrew (BH) speech” that is also appropriate for first-year Hebrew students. They draw from texts that preserve common language functions, including “meeting a stranger on a journey (Judg 19.17–20), finding out where someone lives (2 Sam 16.3), ... finding

someone/something in a city (1 Sam 9.13) ... [or] coming before the king with a request (1 Kgs 2.20–24; 2 Sam 14.4ff)” (Baker & Kantor, 2014). They summarized the value of this particular activity:

In short, the situational contexts of specific dialogues in the biblical text dictate the setting for conversational activities conducted in class. Immersion in direct speech and dialogue at the beginning stages of a BH course provides students with critical aural input and, just as significantly, gives them the confidence to produce the language themselves. This in turn paves the way for in-Hebrew discussion of narrative BH texts, a conversational activity which is a key tool for strengthening active comprehension. Such conversations enable students to develop a much deeper understanding of the texts and equip them more completely to dive into the biblical material on their own. (Baker & Kantor, 2014)

For those either skeptical of spoken biblical Hebrew, or for those who are not confident in how to begin speaking it, this activity is an effective and authentic way in which to begin doing so. However, as stated above (see this chapter, “The Purpose”), this sort of activity is not the end goal of a communicative approach; it is merely one technique that contributes to the broader methodology.

Another way to teach how to use the target language in the target language is by compiling a list of stock phrases and classroom instructions in biblical Hebrew, including “Raise (your) hand” (הָרֵם יָדְךָ *harem yad*), “Come to the board” (בּוֹא אֶל הַלּוּיָהּ *bo 'el halluh*), “Return to your seats” (שׁוּבוּ אֶל כִּסְאוֹתֵיכֶם *shuvu 'el kis'othekhem*), “Talk to one another” (הֵישׁ לְכֶם שְׂאֵלוֹת *dabberu 'ish 'el re'ehu*), “Do you have any questions?” (הֵישׁ לְכֶם שְׂאֵלוֹת *hayesh lakhem she'eloth?*), “Open your books” (פְּתְחוּ אֶת סִפְרֵיכֶם *pithhu 'eth sifrekhem*), and so on. Indeed, there is very little that cannot be communicated in biblical Hebrew in one way or another (see this section, “constraints and limitations” below), and therefore, there is no reason why such learning opportunities should not be taken advantage of in

order to aid learners in acquiring the L2. More examples of specific classroom activities will be provided under the following principles.

Constraints and limitations. It is true that the absolute certainty of *what* vocabulary was used and *how* it was used is ultimately constrained by what is preserved in the extant biblical corpus as well as contemporaneous literature. In this respect, Greek boasts *far* more literature from which to draw in order to expand the vocabulary used in the CLT classroom.ⁱⁱⁱ “Biblical” Hebrew vocabulary, on the other hand, is more or less limited to the words contained in the Old Testament. Nonetheless, the fact that Hebrew has been used as a living language (even if only as a scholarly second language for a period) for over three thousand years certainly seems to make the enterprise feasible for Hebrew as well. Mishnaic Hebrew (i.e., Early Rabbinic Hebrew), in particular, which is not far removed from biblical Hebrew, contains a vast amount of literature from which helpful vocabulary can be drawn for language use that is still well within the scope of the L2, despite the dialectal differences. Of course, one must draw the line somewhere as to what vocabulary can be used in a biblical Hebrew curriculum and it still be called a “biblical” Hebrew class.

When there simply does not exist needed vocabulary in any of the corpora, several options are available. The use of periphrasis and circumlocution can be helpful, where ideas/objects are described in roundabout ways with known vocabulary (children are masters at this!). Also, the *sparing* use of modern Hebrew and/or neologisms can be employed for particular items that are needed for classroom use with absolutely no damage done to the biblical dialect (for a Greek example, see Rico, 2015, p. II). In fact, from a language-learning standpoint, even later dialects of Hebrew (including modern)

have tremendous benefits for the study of biblical Hebrew, only one of which is shared vocabulary. To illustrate, if a non-English L1 speaker desired to study Shakespearean literature, any modern English speaker would unhesitatingly recommend learning to speak modern English and only then learn the relatively small dialectal differences needed to comprehend Shakespeare's language more thoroughly. Analogously, learners of biblical Hebrew should not fear their language system being "polluted" by other dialects of Hebrew, given the tremendous pedagogical advantages afforded by later dialects (for more benefits on the integration of modern and biblical Hebrew, see Hornkohl, 2014, November 25).

Another constraint is the inevitable anachronistic use of some vocabulary. Words that conveyed particular historical and/or cultural conceptions in the minds of the original authors/audiences may differ from what might be communicated in the minds of modern learners. For instance, the word שַׁעַר *sha'ar* ("gate") had massive sociocultural implications in biblical times that are not conveyed by the term "gate" in English. A teacher must, therefore, communicate the full conceptual meaning of important terms like this, even if it requires a brief explanation in the L1. On a lesser scale, an object such as an עֶט *'et* ("pen, stylus") that was used for writing in biblical times certainly did not resemble the mechanical pencils, pens, or markers of modern classrooms that might be described by the same term. While the object(s) may not communicate the same precise concept, it works functionally, and, in some cases, it can even provide a source of humor which is always appreciated by learners.

Regarding *how* biblical Hebrew was used, modern understanding of issues such as pragmatics, discourse, figures of speech, idioms, etc. can only be determined by the

available evidence. While this may pose a problem in some cases, modern linguistic analyses of the discourse features and pragmatics of the biblical languages are quite sophisticated (e.g., Runge, 2010) and, when combined with the written evidence, allows modern users to be able to reconstruct spoken discourse and pragmatic use to a high degree of certainty. Of course, those modern linguists who have developed highly sophisticated linguistic descriptions of the biblical languages but who do not actually use them to communicate in the L2 are not able to test their hypotheses to see if their system of the language is indeed tenable in actual discourse (see Swain, 1985). Rather, they must rely on the sometimes scant evidence available in the biblical text. Further, one must be cautious when drawing conclusions as to how the languages were spoken from grammatical and/or semantic searches such as those described in the preceding section because they only reveal what *can* be said (positive evidence), not what *cannot* be said (indirect negative evidence), since not every word, idiom, or language structure has been preserved in the biblical text.

Related to this issue is the need within the field for some form of built-in accountability or peer review that ensures that the language being produced is, in fact, true to the biblical dialects. There have already been concerns by some biblical language scholars within (and without) the CLT movement concerning the quality/authenticity of the biblical Hebrew contained in some of the textbooks and used in some of the institutes described in Chapter 6. It is true that the quality of one's spoken biblical Hebrew will always be a work in progress and some mistakes are certainly forgivable (even modern language teachers make mistakes!), but too much sloppiness will have a negative effect on learners' acquisition and will damage the credibility of the movement at large.

Lastly, an obvious constraint on *the implementation of* (not necessarily the principle itself) teaching how to use the target language in the target language is the sheer lack of communicative ability among the *vast* majority of biblical Hebrew teachers, virtually none of whom have been taught to hear or speak the L2. For those who have already completed their academic training and have secured teaching positions, the thought of having to “relearn” the language can (understandably) be humbling, daunting, and/or unrealistic for pragmatic reasons. Nevertheless, a teacher cannot teach what he does not know.

What can teachers do to develop fluency in Hebrew? While many biblical language teachers deny the value of learning modern Hebrew for the teaching of biblical Hebrew, *everyone* who has learned to speak modern Hebrew acknowledges the massive benefits it has for developing fluency in *biblical* Hebrew, particularly for those teaching it as a living language (Hornkohl, 2014, November 25; Schultz, 2014, November 25). Considering the amount of resources available for learning modern Hebrew as a SL, acquiring modern Hebrew proves to be the most efficient way to build fluency and proficiency which can then relatively easily be transferred to the teaching of the biblical dialect. Modern Hebrew should, therefore, seriously be considered as a viable contribution to *biblical* Hebrew programs.

In conclusion, given the amount of vocabulary that is retained in the Old Testament, the ability of language users to use that vocabulary in creative contexts, the linguistic evidence of the biblical text combined with powerful search capabilities to mine its communicative usefulness, and the measure of fluency that has already been achieved by leaders in the field, it is possible for biblical Hebrew teachers to teach how to

use biblical Hebrew in biblical Hebrew. This is true particularly at beginning and intermediate levels of L2 learning, which has been effectively demonstrated by institutes such as BLC and FPU.

Utilize Implicit Instruction as Much as Possible

Evaluation of applicability. When it comes to implicit instruction, the issue has less to do with feasibility than it does with a lack of knowledge among biblical language instructors regarding how to execute it effectively in the classroom (or in the writing of curricula). It is true that some teachers of GT classes have developed jingles, clever mnemonics, or other helpful devices to aid the memorization of grammar concepts and/or vocab for their students but this is a far cry from the level of implicit instruction being advocated for here, which should comprise the *vast majority* of classroom instruction.

As an example, take one simple sentence in Hebrew: הָאִישׁ הֹלֵךְ אֶל הַדֶּלֶת *ha'ish holekh 'el haddeleth* (“The man is walking to the door”). This simple phrase can easily be learned and even used by learners in the first day of class via TPR, or in the first lesson of a textbook containing pictures and accompanied audio. Consider the amount of grammar contained in this one sentence: the use of the definite article, the masculine singular participle form (i.e., present tense) of the *qal* stem, the preposition אֶל *'el* (“to, toward”), word order for participles and prepositional phrases (issues of syntax), not to mention five lexical items that will likely stick with them forever after only a few uses because they are chunked together into one unit of meaning. These grammatical elements are typically found in a handful of different chapters in traditional grammar books, but to learn all of these elements discretely through explicit instruction not only would take more time, but likely would be more difficult to remember. The focus of all instruction,

therefore, should remain on comprehending meaning via implicit instruction, even when new grammar forms are being introduced.

Utilizing implicit instruction requires that the teacher see everything in the teaching context as a learning tool. Instruction is no longer restricted to the whiteboard, textbook, or PowerPoint slides, but “the world” becomes the classroom—the physical setting, the classroom, the teacher, the students, posters, pictures, videos, the outdoors, props, dolls, food—whatever is able to directly convey meaning in the L2 can be used for implicit instruction.

However, implicit instruction is not limited to the use of physical objects. Interaction in the language can be just as implicit and meaning-focused as describing objects or events in the classroom. The American Council on the Teaching of Foreign Languages (May, 2010) has offered helpful strategies for maintaining a focus on meaning within a communicative language class:

In classrooms that feature maximum target-language use, instructors use a variety of strategies to facilitate comprehension and support meaning making. For example, they:

1. provide comprehensible input that is directed toward communicative goals;
2. make meaning clear through body language, gestures, and visual support;
3. conduct comprehension checks to ensure understanding;
4. negotiate meaning with students and encourage negotiation among students;
5. elicit talk that increases in fluency, accuracy, and complexity over time;
6. encourage self-expression and spontaneous use of language;
7. teach students strategies for requesting clarification and assistance when faced with comprehension difficulties; and
8. offer feedback to assist and improve students’ ability to interact orally in the target language. (American Council on the Teaching of Foreign Languages, May, 2010)

By following these strategies, implicit instruction with a focus on meaning-making has the ability to take learners to a high level of language proficiency in a relatively short amount of time.

Examples of specific classroom activities. Language learning must begin with vocabulary since without vocabulary, communication in the L2 is impossible. Even from this initial stage of language learning, implicit instruction is both necessary and effective. For concrete nouns, using props, pictures, people, surroundings, and simply calling them by their Hebrew name is the most objective, direct way in which to communicate the meaning of words. Nation (2001) also suggests performing actions, providing language context clues, defining the word(s) in the L2, and even defining the word(s) in the learners' L1 when necessary. Concerning this last point, which could appear to contradict the previous principle, Nation argues that providing short, simple, direct, specific, and clear definitions rather than elaborate ones can be an efficient and tremendously helpful way to introduce basic word meanings to adult L2 learners (2001, p. 83). However, it takes numerous exposures of a word in different contexts to increase one's depth of vocabulary knowledge (Hudson, 2007, p. 233). The obvious danger is to take this to the extreme and unnecessarily introduce too much vocabulary via the L1, which cuts down on valuable time spent in the L2.

Sweet Publishing (2015–2017) has made available free Bible illustrations for most books of the Bible (<http://distantshores.org/resources/illustrations/sweet-publishing>). These are *invaluable* resources for a CLT biblical Hebrew class since they can be used for an infinite number of class activities. The pictures, which are culturally appropriate, can be labelled and used as vocabulary builders, paired with the biblical text

in order to communicate meaning implicitly, or students can be required to describe the pictures to one another in small groups or pairs.

Many grammatical structures can be taught indirectly through examples rather than directly through rules. For instance, Total Physical Response can be used not only to teach vocabulary and imperative forms (הִפִּילִי אֶת הַחֶרֶב *happili eth hacherev* [“Drop the sword!”]), but the instructor and/or students can then describe the actions that are taking place using the present tense (הִיא מִפִּילָה אֶת הַחֶרֶב *hi mappilah 'eth haherev* [“She is dropping the sword”]), and then describe what happened using the past tense (הִיא הִפִּילָה *hi hippilah 'eth haherev* [“She dropped the sword”]).

For biblical Hebrew, simple sequences of past events can be described effectively in a “story” form by using the sequential past tense (*wayyiqtol*) (הָיָא קָם וַיֵּלֶךְ אֶל הַנָּחָשׁ וַיִּכּוּ אֹתוֹ *hu qam wayyelekh 'el hannahash wayyakh 'otho wayyashav* [“He rose and went to the snake and struck it and returned”]). Contrasting that with the simple past tense (*qatal*) (הָיָא קָם וְהָיָא הֵלֵךְ אֶל הַנָּחָשׁ וְהָיָא הִכָּה אֹתוֹ וְהָיָא שָׁב *hu qam wehu halakh 'el hannahash wehu hikkah 'otho wehu shav* [“He rose and he went to the snake and he struck it and he returned”]) provides learners with an intuitive understanding of the syntactic and pragmatic use of the *wayyiqtol* in past narrative contexts. Further, to utilize the future tense (*yiqtol*) and/or sequential future tense (*weqatal*), one can construct a scenario, such as going to the temple to sacrifice, or visiting a relative in another city, or traveling to another country for war, and then ask students what they will do there (מָה תַעֲשֶׂה שָׁם? *mah ta'aseh sham?*), what they will see (מָה תִּרְאֶה? *mah tir'eh?*), what they need to bring (מָה צָרִיךְ לָהֵבִיא *meh 'aleykha lehavi?*), etc. This provides a meaningful context in which

students must use particular vocabulary or grammatical constructions such as the future tense or expressing need in order to accomplish a communicative task.

Another example consists of a simple statement and question such as שְׁמִי אֵלִיָּהוּ. שְׁמֶךָ מָה? *shemi 'eliyyahu. mah shimkha?* (“My name is Elijah. What’s your name?”), which may be taught implicitly by pointing to yourself and then to a student while shrugging your shoulders. There is no need to provide an English translation, or an explicit grammatical explanation that question words occur at the beginning of Hebrew phrases, that the vowel in שְׁ *shem* (“name”) shortens to a *shewa* or *hiriq* when a suffix is added, or that the כָּ *kha* at the end is a 2ms pronominal suffix (“your”). Learners are capable of learning more in shorter amounts of time when they focus on meaning rather than form.

Written texts can provide yet another source of implicit instruction, as learners are able to discover grammatical patterns and structures in meaningful contexts. Repeated occurrences of the same structure(s)/word(s) in various contexts help learners discover the meaning(s) on their own, and acquire them intuitively. The nature of these texts, however, must be considered (see this section, “constraints and limitations” below).

Songs can also be an excellent means of implicit instruction, and they prove to be more memorable than other genres of language. Biblical Hebrew, in particular, boasts a plethora of songs taken directly from the Old Testament text which helps not only to learn the language but also to memorize Scripture. Students tend to enjoy learning these songs.

Constraints and limitations. One limitation of the use of implicit instruction is the dearth of instructional materials designed specifically for biblical Hebrew. Many

props, for instance, that one might use are anachronistic and do not conjure up the same image that a native speaker would have had. They can and still should be used, however, as the benefits far outweigh the drawbacks.

Even more significant, though, is the lack of appropriate extensive reading material (see this chapter, “Aim for Fluency before Accuracy” below) and videos that provide the implicit instruction needed for comprehensible input. Currently, the sources of implicit instruction are, by and large, restricted to the teacher. Therefore, one of the greatest constraints on utilizing implicit knowledge seems to be limited to the lack of resources containing comprehensible input, specifically that can be used outside of class when no teacher is present.

In conclusion, while the development of more pedagogical resources that provide implicit instruction would greatly enhance the biblical Hebrew class, there is still much that can be taught implicitly. In other words, one does not need to wait to acquire props that are culturally relevant, or extensive reading materials, or biblical Hebrew videos in order to utilize a vast amount of implicit instruction.

Foster Language Awareness

Evaluation of applicability. It should be no surprise that drawing explicit attention to grammatical forms is certainly possible when teaching biblical Hebrew. The difficulty, however, is to effectively foster language awareness in a way that contributes to the comprehension of meaning rather than detracts from it. It is, therefore, important to keep Gruber-Miller’s (2006) statement in mind at the forefront of this discussion:

Certainly grammar is a topic many of us teach most explicitly in a beginning language course. And certainly, adolescent and adult students ask for and can benefit from knowledge of grammatical rules and structures. But if grammar is the primary focus of a language course, then the course will be primarily *about*

the language rather than using the language to interpret and express ideas, feelings, attitudes, and stories. It is important to put grammar in its place: it is a necessary tool, but not a sufficient one, to help language learners communicate effectively. (Kindle locations 175-178, italics original)

In order to apply this discussion to the teaching of biblical Hebrew, it is necessary to recall several questions raised in Chapter 4 regarding fostering language awareness: Which forms should one focus on? How much time should be spent on form-focused activities? And should grammar instruction should be intensive (i.e., “cover a single grammatical structure in a single lesson”) or extensive (i.e., “cover many grammatical structures in a single lesson”) (Ellis, R., 2006, p. 93).

In order to choose which forms to focus on, R. Ellis (2006) has suggested focusing on the structures that are known to cause errors in learners’ interlanguage (p. 102). For biblical Hebrew, some notoriously “difficult” concepts consist of the morphological changes among the different verbal stems, as well as the syntactic and pragmatic use of the relatively few verbal forms. These grammar issues, among others, will likely require some measure of explicit instruction at some point in the course. Though, it must be emphasized once again that much of this grammar information can be learned implicitly through language use. In other words, one does *not* need to be able to parse a verb in order to understand and use it accurately and fluently. Nonetheless, explicit instruction will help adult learners attend to certain forms and/or comprehend why certain forms appear the way they do, which can then be used to monitor their output.

By contrast, some “easy” structures for biblical Hebrew include noun endings, prepositions, adjective uses, verb suffix endings, and pronouns, among others. These

concepts generally consume entire chapters in grammar books that are, by and large, unnecessary, because they can be learned easily through implicit means alone.

Concerning how much time to spend on fostering language awareness, there is no magic formula. However, because implicit instruction results in much faster processing, and “because learners are clearly capable of learning a substantial amount of the L2 grammar without instruction” (R. Ellis, 2006, p. 88), time spent on explicit instruction should be minimal. Nation (2007) has argued that form-focused instruction—one of the four strands of an effective language course—should comprise only one-quarter of instructional time. More time than this will likely have negative effects on the acquisition process because time spent focusing on forms inherently means time away from implicit instruction where more language can be acquired. Clearly, there is a balance needed.

How does one go about fostering language awareness most effectively?

Advocates of the strong interface position recommend intensive instruction where grammar forms are presented and then practiced until they become fully proceduralized.

DeKeyser (1998), for instance, has made a case that

Grammar should first be taught explicitly to achieve a maximum of understanding and then should be followed by some exercises to anchor it solidly in the students’ consciousness in declarative form so that it is easy to keep in mind during communicative exercises. (p. 58)

Rico’s (2015) textbook, on the other hand, demonstrates how Focus on Form instruction can begin with communicative tasks and utilize implicit grammar instruction in the L2 based on those communicative activities. He beautifully integrates grammar teaching with the numerous TPR activities, dialogues, songs, communicative tasks, and written drills contained in each chapter. The focus is kept on meaning as learners have already implicitly acquired the language structures being brought to their attention. The

little explicit instruction that is contained is written *in* Greek, with *minimal* English glosses (only exercise instructions and grammatical terms). This represents an ideal example of fostering language awareness. A complete resource such as this does not currently exist for biblical Hebrew even though language awareness can be similarly fostered in a biblical Hebrew class.

In conclusion, introducing a new form or structure before a communicative activity, discussing it within a communicative activity itself, or summarizing/explaining a form after a content-based activity are all viable solutions to teaching grammar (Spada & Lightbown, 2008) so long as the focus is kept on meaning the entire time. It is likely that a combination of these approaches to teaching grammar is most useful within a biblical Hebrew class (R. Ellis, 2006).

Examples of specific classroom activities. Different types of corrective feedback—both implicit and explicit—are important for fostering language awareness (Doughty & Williams, 1998). In R. Ellis’ words, “*Implicit feedback* occurs when the corrective force of the response to learner error is masked” (2006, p. 99, italics original). Recasts, for example, involve a teacher repeating a learner’s error back to him in a corrected form that maintains the original intended meaning. Requesting clarification is another form of implicit feedback, where a teacher might simply ask: מה אָמַרְתָּ? *mah 'amarta?* (“What did you say?”), causing the learner to think about and correct the erroneous utterance. Negotiation of meaning can be a form of implicit feedback, as it usually includes several of the preceding techniques, as well as confirmation checks (לֹא תוּכַל? *he'amarta ki lo tukhal* [“Did you say you are not able...?”]) and comprehension checks (הֲבִינְתָּ? *hahavinotha* [“Do you understand?”]).

Explicit feedback may also be effective at times, particularly in the context of extensive grammar instruction; that is, when grammar questions arise spontaneously by learners (R. Ellis, 2006). One type of explicit feedback is providing negative evidence, whereby a teacher explicitly states that a certain statement is incorrect or informs learners of what cannot be said in the L2. In fact, negative evidence has been shown to be necessary for adult SL learners (Gass, Behny, & Plonsky, 2013, p. 360). For example:

- Student: מָחָר אֶכְלֶתִי לֶחֶם *mahar 'akhalti lehem* (“Tomorrow I eat/ate bread”)
- Teacher: You mean, אֶתְמֹל אֶכְלֶתִי לֶחֶם *'ethmol 'akhalti lehem* (“Yesterday I ate bread”). You can’t use מָחָר *mahar* (“Tomorrow”) with a *qatal* verb in biblical Hebrew.

Such L2 information would likely never be acquired by an adult biblical Hebrew learner without negative evidence because there is simply not enough input to come to this conclusion (as a child learning his L1 would). Simple, brief, explicit information—whether in the L1 or L2—can effectively resolve this issue.

Input enhancement is another effective way to draw attention to particular words or forms. This can be done orally simply by emphasizing certain forms through the intonation of one’s voice or in a written text by highlighting, underlining, bolding, or otherwise marking certain words in order to draw explicit attention to particular vocabulary and/or structures while the learner is reading. Many textbooks (both CLT and GT) do this to draw attention to particular forms or morphological features of words. For instance, if a teacher is wanting to draw learners’ attention to the Hebrew infinitives construct, he may color those forms in a story whose overall focus is on meaning.

Another example of fostering language awareness is through intensive instruction, where a new form is written on the board with a brief explanation before doing a communicative activity that uses that form. By becoming aware of the new form students are more likely to notice it within the communicative activity which will more likely result in the input becoming intake and ultimately transferring to acquisition and long-term retention. For example, a teacher could briefly discuss the *hifil* stem, pointing out its morphological properties, and then move into a communicative activity that incorporates words such as לְהַפִּיל *lehappil* (“to drop”), לְהַשְׁלִיךְ *lehashlikh* (“to throw”), and לְהַקִּים *lehaqim* (“to erect, raise”) that could be used together naturally in a single context such as someone erecting a graven image (לְפָסֵל *pesel*) and an enemy overturning it.

Deliberate learning of vocabulary has also been shown to be of help to language learners (Nation, 2001, 2007). However, if direct learning of vocabulary words in the L1 is used, it should be done so sparingly (i.e., not the default way to teach vocabulary) and the meaning of words should be separated from the words themselves—even if only on the opposite side of a flashcard—in order to give the brain time to retrieve its meaning before being presented with it.

Nation (2007) has suggested other forms of language-focused instruction: “pronunciation practice, using substitution tables and drills, learning vocabulary from word cards, intensive reading, translation, memorising dialogues and getting feed-back about writing” (p. 6). Doughty and Williams (1998) have offered a handful of techniques that may be employed to focus attention on forms within a communicative context. These techniques include input flood (i.e., many examples of a particular form present in either spoken or written input), specific form-dependent tasks (i.e., the task requires learners to

use a particular form for successful completion), and metatalking during dictogloss tasks. Dictogloss, in particular, is an effective technique used to teach grammar structures. The teacher reads a prepared text that includes the target structure(s), students must listen and take notes, and then they work together in groups to reconstruct a summary of the text using the grammatical structure(s). Finally, they present that summary to the class. This activity fosters language awareness while maintaining a focus on meaning.

Constraints and limitations. One problem with deciding which forms to focus on is that most (if not all) of the current teaching and past learning experiences among biblical language teachers takes place/has taken place in an environment comprised solely of explicit instruction with no L2 production, but the only way to evaluate one's interlanguage is through production. This makes it difficult to know what L2 structures cause the most consistent learner errors because teachers' assessment can be severely skewed. What might be difficult to learn explicitly may be easy to acquire implicitly and vice versa. Teachers will thus have to strategically choose which forms to teach implicitly ("easy" forms) and which to focus explicit attention on ("difficult" forms).

Another constraint on fostering language awareness is the lack of grammatical vocabulary in biblical Hebrew (in contrast to both Greek and Latin which have nearly an entire grammatical vocabulary preserved from classical times). While Focus on Form instruction does not necessarily require the use of grammatical "metalanguage," it can help adult learners synthesize the L2 system, particularly at higher levels of instruction after fluency has been attained.

Lastly, it should be noted that the tendency for most teachers, especially those who learned under a GT approach, will be to emphasize "language awareness" too

much—that is, to the degree that instruction begins to resemble the traditional approach to grammar teaching. It is thus crucial to monitor the use of form-focused instruction and maintain a focus on meaning throughout the course of instruction.

Facilitate Language Production Via Negotiated Interaction

Evaluation of applicability. Language production, as it is used here, does not refer merely to speaking scripted dialogues, parroting preset audiolingual drills, or singing songs in the L2, though each of these can have its place in CLT. Nor does it refer to the all-too-prevalent “known-answer question routines” (or Initiation-Response-Feedback) that constitute inauthentic and/or monologue exchanges (Meskill & Anthony, 2015). The kind of production aimed for in this principle comes about as learners interact “freely” in the L2 for real communicative purposes and are thereby forced to negotiate meaning until comprehension is achieved. Only through genuine, social use of the language, will true acquisition take place. Jacobs and Farrell (2001) have referred to this as cooperative (or collaborative) learning.

In order to facilitate language production via negotiated interaction it is absolutely crucial to utilize small groups frequently because teacher-oriented approaches to language teaching do not provide sufficient opportunities for learners to engage in conversation and to negotiate meaning. In fact, Varonis & Gass (1985) have shown how nonnative-nonnative partners produce more frequent negotiations of meaning than do native-nonnative partners (as cited in Kumaravadivelu, 1994, p. 34). Consequently, many of the following activities make use of small group settings or learner pairs.

Facilitating language production also requires forethought and careful/strategic planning of tasks that elicit genuine communicative purposes. Information requests

should be met with previously unknown information. Interaction should reflect authentic conversation and not merely consist of isolated language functions or speech acts. (This was one of the criticisms of the Comprehension-Based Approach and the Communicative Approach in the 1970s and 1980s.) True CLT involves higher language aspects such as discourse and pragmatics that are not included in a purely functional approach to the L2.

Examples of specific classroom activities. One way to facilitate language production via negotiated interaction is simply to place learners in pairs or small groups and provide them with pictures to describe to one another that prompt the use of specific vocab and/or language structures being learned. This can be done from the very earliest stages of language learning to the highest levels of language learning. Learners can point to objects in a picture and ask one another: *מה זה?* *mah zeh?* (“What is this?”), prompting a genuine response. Of course, more complex questions can also be asked, such as: *למה הוא ירד באניה?* *lammah hu yored baoniyyah?* (“Why is he boarding the ship?”).

Another way to facilitate language production is to ask more open-ended questions rather than simple yes-no questions, or questions with predetermined answers, which are not only not optimal for language acquisition but can sometimes be insulting or demeaning to learners’ intelligence. Questions should be genuine requests for information and the information shared ought to be previously unknown. In this way both interlocutors remained engaged in the learning process. Examples include:

- *מה עשית אתמול?* *meh 'asitta 'ethmol?* (“What did you do yesterday?”).
- *מה אתה אוהב לעשות בקיץ?* *mah 'attah 'ohev la'asoth baqqayits?* (“What do you like to do in the summer?”).

Open-ended questions can also be used to discuss authentic biblical texts:

- מה את חשבת, למה ברח יונה מלפני יהוה? *mah 'at hosheveth, lammah barah yonah millifne yehwah?* (“What do you think, why did Jonah flee from the presence of Yahweh?”).
- איך שבו אנשי נינוה מדרךם הרעה? *'ekh shavu 'anshe nineweh middarkam hara'ah?* (“How did the people of Ninevah repent from their evil way?”).

One technique that can be helpful to guide the production of such questions is Blaine Ray’s Teaching Proficiency through Reading and Storytelling (TPRS). This technique relies heavily on the use of storytelling where either authentic or made-up stories can be used. For the latter, the teacher provides large amounts of comprehensible input and guides the class in creating unique stories with learner input. The stories are heard, retold, written, and read among learners. The teacher asks lots of interactive questions that both ensure comprehension and allow learners to contribute details they understand to the story. The questions can vary in difficulty, depending on the learner. Simple yes-or-no questions can be used for learners who are struggling, whereas more open-ended and complex questions can be used for learners who are progressing quite well. Ultimately, however, all learners should be pushed toward the latter type (“Teaching Proficiency through Reading and Storytelling,” n.d.).

Dictogloss (Wajnryb, 1988, 1989, 1990, as cited in Nation, 2007), which was briefly described in the previous principle, is a common technique used to facilitate language production and negotiated interaction. First, the teacher reads a text out loud at a normal pace while students merely listen. Then, the teacher reads the same text out loud while students write down key words. Lastly, the teacher reads the same text a third time, while students write down phrases or whole sentences. The next stage of the activity is

where interaction comes into play. Students are divided into pairs or small groups and are asked to compare notes in order to reconstruct the text as best as possible. This prompts interaction and negotiation of meaning in the L2. Groups can then be combined to compare their reconstructed stories and to add any missing details. In the third and final stage, students either listen as the teacher reads the story once again while they compare their reconstructed stories with the original text, or learners read their version of the reconstructed story while others compare their versions.

Jigsaw (Kroeker & Heinrichs, 1993, as cited in Ewert, 2014) is an excellent technique for facilitating language production, and negotiated interaction in particular. The teacher divides a text (e.g., Jonah 1) into logical chunks (e.g., vv. 1–5, 6–10, and 11–16) and then divides the students into the same number of groups as there are chunks of text (about four students per group works well). Each group is assigned one of the portions from the larger text and is asked to read it and interact in the L2, discussing the main idea, and perhaps answering comprehension questions over it. Each member of that group thus becomes an “expert” on that chunk of text. Then each group member is assigned a number, beginning from 1. New groups are formed with all the 1s, all the 2s, all the 3s, etc., resulting in groups with one “expert” from each portion of the text. Each “expert” is asked to explain/teach/report on his portion of the text to the others, interacting and negotiating meaning. Finally, individual students are asked to summarize the text, or answer comprehension questions over the whole text.

Gallery Tour (Kroeker & Heinrichs, 1993, as cited in Ewert, 2014) requires students (or groups of students) to prepare a visual aid of some sort (e.g., graph, chart, or picture) that illustrates the content of an assigned portion of text. Students rotate around

the room asking questions and making comments about the pictures on sticky notes or note cards, leaving them next to the picture. After the tour, each student or group collects the cards for their picture and responds to the questions either in writing or orally to the class.

Similar to gallery tour, story boards (Hallback, 2010, as cited in Ewert, 2014) require students (or groups of students) to create story boards for texts and then share them with one another, prompting both interaction and negotiation of meaning. Similar activities can be done with the Bible Illustrations from Sweet from Sweet Publishing mentioned above (see this chapter, “Utilize Implicit Instruction as Much as Possible”).

Strip Story Activity (Gibson, 1975, as cited in Nation, 2001) fosters both interaction and fluency. Nation (2001) describes the activity:

Learners are each given a sentence to memorise from a paragraph. They then must retell their sentences to each other and decide whose sentence is first, second and so on. No writing is allowed. Because the learners must memorise their sentences, they then have to retrieve them each time they tell them to the rest of the group. Memorisation thus ensures a form of retrieval. (p. 73)

The present author has used a similar technique where half of the students were each given a Bible Illustration (from Sweet Publishing) from the book of Ruth which was being studied in class, and the other half were given strips of paper with a statement in Hebrew that described one of the pictures. None of the students could show their picture/text to other students. During the first iteration of the activity, the students with the written statement were required to read their statement to those with pictures and try to identify who had their matching illustration, while those with the pictures had to listen to see if what was being described matched the picture they had. During the second iteration, the students with the illustrations were the ones required to describe their

picture and those with the texts had to determine if the other student was describing his or her written statement. This facilitated language output and sometimes triggered negotiation of meaning.

Other techniques that facilitate language production include either a classic interview or “a game in which students must locate the person who matches a certain description by asking each other questions, thereby using language for problem solving” (Snow, 2001, p. 303). Inherent to the concept of interview is the asking and answering of questions in order to acquire unknown information about someone else. Further, the focus is kept on meaning and not form. For example, in chapter one of the book of Jonah, the sailors interrogate Jonah after the lot falls on him identifying him as the cause of the storm. They ask such questions as:

- מה-מלאכתך? *mah-melakhtekha?* (“What is your occupation?”)
- מאין תבוא? *me'ayin tavo?* (“Where do you come from?”)
- מה ארצך? *mah 'artsekha?* (“What is your country?”)
- אי-מזה עם אתה? *'e-mizzeḥ 'am 'attah?* (“Of what people are you?”)

Such questions can easily be incorporated into an activity where learners are each given an identity that includes an occupation (פָּרָשׁ *parash* [“horseman”], מַלְלָה *mallah* [“sailor”], רוֹעֵה *ro'eh* [“shepherd”]), a country (מִצְרַיִם *mitsrayim* [“Egypt”], יָוֹן *yawan* [“Greece”], יִשְׂרָאֵל *yishra'el* [“Israel”]), and a “nationality” (מִצְרִי *mitsri* [“Egyptian”], יְוָנִי *yewani* [“Grecian”], עִבְרִי *'ivri* [“Hebrew”]) and are required to interview one another. Additional elements can be included such as asking one another about items that that particular character might naturally have from his/her country of residence. This can be an excellent way to integrate cultural components into the language class as well.

The present author has incorporated language production into assessment by requiring students to produce both written and oral summaries of specific chapters from Jonah and Ruth which were studied throughout the course. During the final exam, he recorded the students' 4–6-sentence summaries and was then able to assess on how well they were able to communicate the main ideas from the text.

Constraints and limitations. Similar to the first principle—teach how to use the target language in the target language—this principle entirely depends on the instructor's and learners' ability to converse in the L2. All of the activities described above can be adapted for beginning or advanced learners and thus used to develop speaking proficiency and fluency. As discussed above (see this chapter, “Teach How to Use the Target Language in the Target Language”), there will always remain some level of uncertainty concerning how ancient speakers spoke certain phrases or communicated particular ideas. There simply does not exist enough linguistic data to reconstruct *the entire* language system of biblical Hebrew to the degree of a modern languages. Nonetheless, this does not preclude teaching what is available (which is a significant amount) through communicative means, particularly by facilitating language production via negotiated interaction.

Integrate Language Skills

Evaluation of applicability. Kumaravadivelu (1994) has argued that all four language skills should be integrated from the beginning of language instruction, since this is how literate adults learn second languages best. This principle is no less relevant for the biblical languages than it is for modern languages. Nation's (2007) four strands approach to language pedagogy provides a helpful framework for integrating the

language skills in a balanced way. For instance, he maintains that learners should be fluent with what they already know at every stage of language learning. This requires that learners speak from day one (and perhaps even begin reading and writing). The *production* of what one has learned through listening further internalizes the language and “makes it stick.” Speaking also forces learners to notice gaps in their interlanguage, which then prompts greater attention to form. Reading what one is hearing and speaking enables more accurate identification of word boundaries, a greater understanding of morphology, and more precise pronunciation. Writing forces learners to pay closer attention to spelling and morphology, further contributing to one’s interlanguage, which is then used for production. As stated above, Vandergrift (2004) argued that learning to listen and comprehend spoken language is necessary for developing automatic word recognition and increase one’s overall automaticity. Ideally, this is done through the listening of authentic speech, but in the case of biblical Hebrew, it can also be effectively accomplished via recordings of the biblical text.

This integration of language skills not only provides a much more robust knowledge of the L2, it also makes learning more efficient for adult learners because each of the skills is mutually reinforcing.

Examples of specific classroom activities. Providing written texts of material that is being learned orally/aurally during homework or in class will assist learners in integrating what they have heard and/or spoken with its written forms, thus strengthening the form-meaning connections. Obviously, one is not expected to transcribe all the interaction that takes place, but certain dialogues or scripts that have been used can be helpful sources of comprehensible input for learners in- or outside of class.

Dictogloss, which was described twice above (see this chapter, “Foster Language Awareness” and “Facilitate Language Production via Negotiated Interaction”), is an excellent activity that combines all four language skills—listening, speaking, reading, and writing. Students must listen to the teacher read the story, write down key words and phrases, discuss their notes with other learners, and then read their reconstructed texts and the original text at the end.

Jigsaw, another activity already discussed (see this chapter, “Facilitate Language Production via Negotiated Interaction” above), likewise combines all four language skills by reading the text, interacting to discuss the meaning of each chunk of text, answering written comprehension questions (optional). The repetition also makes this a helpful fluency building activity.

A very simply way to integrate language skills is simply to assign listening of recordings of the biblical text. The entire audio Hebrew Bible can be downloaded for free online. Listening with and without the text are both helpful exercises. Listening also allows learners to receive comprehensible input (assuming the text has already been learned) while doing other activities such as commuting, exercising, or doing mundane activities around the home, which is always welcomed by learners who are inevitably constrained by time. Recordings of other activities can also be of help. For instance, the present author has listened to the recordings from immersion courses and fluency workshops he has attended which has been a tremendous source of input and a valuable aid in his subsequent teaching of the languages. In light of this, a teacher may wish to record a class and assign learners to watch and/or listen to it before the next class period.

This greatly reinforces what has already been learned and may even prove to be more beneficial for language acquisition than assigning new material for homework.

Classes centered around texts should require multiple passes through the text using various forms of processing. Students should listen to the text, read the text silently and out loud, talk about the text with other students, synthesize the text in various forms, and write about it (e.g., summarize portions of it in their own words or answer comprehension questions). The integration of language skills will aid in comprehension and retention of meaning and produce a more robust understanding of the text.

Constraints and limitations. Assuming the possibility of teaching the target language in the target language (see this chapter, “Teach How to Use the Target Language in the Target Language” above), there really is no limitation to the integration of language skills. It ultimately comes down to the creativity and forethought of the instructor to plan each class in such a way that all four language skills are being utilized and integrated.

That being said, writing does tend to be the most difficult language skill for biblical Hebrew, likely because its script is so complex and different from English and possibly also due to the relative neglect of writing to the other language skills in some communicative contexts. The skill of writing, therefore, may need more attention in order to develop effective activities that engage the learners, that focus on meaning, and that are integrated with the other three language skills.

Maintain Curricular Integration

Evaluation of applicability. Typically, in a biblical studies program the biblical languages are taught in isolation from other subjects. Only at higher levels, such as

exegesis courses, do other topics like theology and historical and cultural backgrounds begin to be incorporated, though this is typically only done to the degree needed to understand the meaning of the text. However, biblical language courses function as prime opportunities to integrate aspects of history, culture, philosophy, archaeology, religion, and worldview. Indeed, a whole range of curricular topics can be integrated into the learning of the language system itself, which is best accomplished through CBI (Snow, 2001). To reiterate a point already made, CBI tasks view “language as a medium for learning content, and content as a resource for learning language” (Stoller & Grabe, 1997, p. 78). There is no reason why biblical language courses cannot and should not be filled with such curricular-integrated activities.

Examples of specific classroom activities. Following Stoller and Grabe’s (1997) Six-T’s approach (see Chapter 4), for instance, one could pick common themes found in Scripture (e.g., cult worship, warfare, agriculture, family, domestic life) or pick a certain story to cover (the book of Jonah, Ruth, the story of Sampson), around which a course may be structured. These themes and/or texts would then dictate which topics would need to be covered in order to break the larger texts into bite-sized units of instruction (e.g., sacrifice, priesthood, battle, weapons/armor, food, harvest, family, clan, tribe, genealogy). In order to create tasks, one would need to generate a list of relevant vocabulary, language functions and structures, idioms and/or expressions, and cultural concepts, as well as developing a set of materials that can be used to teach these items via communicative tasks. Meskill and Anthony (2015) have referred to this as a “chunque” of language that can be used multiple times in various and meaningful contexts to teach the language (p. 20). The goal is to understand how the language actually works in various

contexts, which can easily be exploited to teach other non-linguistic topics as well. By doing this, students would not only acquire the language, but they would also learn important aspects of the historical background and culture in which the language was spoken.

As an example, take the topic of Levitical sacrifices, most notably discussed in Leviticus 1–7. Relevant vocab for this topic might include: כֹּהֵן *kohen* (“priest”), מִזְבֵּחַ *mizbeah* (“altar”); חַטָּאת *hattath* (“sin, sin offering”), בֶּן *ben* (“son”), הֶלֶב *helev* (“fat”), דָּם *dam* (“blood”), קָרְבַּן *qarban* (“wood offering”), עֹלָה *'olah* (“whole burnt offering”), לְהַקְרִיב *lehaqriv* (“to bring, offer”), לֶאֱכֹל *le'ekhol* (“to eat”), לַחֲטֹא *lahato* (“to sin”), and so on. Language functions might include: לְהַקְרִיב קָרְבַּן לַיהוָה *lehaqriv qarban layhwah* (“to bring an offering to Yahweh”), לָשִׂים יָד עַל *lasim yad 'al* (“to lay [one’s] hand on...”), לִזְרוֹק דָּם עַל הַמִּזְבֵּחַ סָבִיב *lizroq 'eth-haddam 'al hammizbeah saviv* (“to sprinkle the blood around the altar”), and so on. Language structures include the use of imperatives followed by *weqatals*, which are characteristic of the directive discourse type found in Leviticus 1–7. Constructing an altar in class whereby students can act as priests and “perform” sacrifices using this vocabulary and these language functions and structures keeps the focus on meaning throughout the teaching process. As a pre- or post-activity, a simple description of a sacrifice in Hebrew can serve to orient learners to the practice and cultural background of sacrifices in the ancient Near East. Reading the biblical text can further integrate these cultural backgrounds with the Bible itself. Prayers of repentance and/or praise can be taken from the Psalms or other passages in order to integrate them into the sacrificial rite. Lastly, a theological discussion of sacrifice could follow (in Hebrew or

English), showing how Jesus' sacrifice on the cross compares to the Levitical sacrificial system.

Other examples of ways in which curricular integration could be manifest include teaching Hebrew discourse markers and discourse analysis in the context of Moses' or the prophets' sermons in order to highlight the theological points they were making. This could then be applied to real-life situations as students preach the text in homiletics class or in their local church. Biblical theology could be addressed when students study the Hebrew grammar of God's promises of blessing to Abraham or his promises of a new covenant to Jeremiah. With this kind of curricular-integrated approach to language learning, it seems that Hebrew classes would not only be more beneficial to students, but they would be more engaging as well.

Constraints and limitations. One hindrance to utilizing a full-fledged CBI approach in a biblical Hebrew class is the sheer lack of resources available for teaching specific themes or topics in the biblical languages. Stoller and Grabe (1997) suggest the use of a variety of resources such as videos, audiotapes, maps, graphs, photographs, and software. Because the application of CLT to the biblical languages is still a relatively new endeavor, very few people have invested in developing resources of this nature. The biblical text represents the only "content" with which to work. Even then, many topics are not discussed in enough detail in the Bible to create a full-fledged CBI unit from. This highlights the need for more resources to be developed in order to aid CBI in communicative biblical language classes.

Another constraint is that in the current state of biblical language instruction, it is not likely that seminaries or Bible colleges would be willing to utilize CBI in any of the

forms described by Stoller and Grabe (1997) or Snow (2001). Time is one reason for this. Already, biblical language requirements in biblical studies programs are minimal (in terms of the number of units) which does not leave time for incorporating additional material into the curriculum. The one class, however, in which it would be reasonable to do so (in the current biblical language system, that is) is the traditional biblical exegesis courses. These courses typically focus on one or more texts of Scripture and spend significant time reading, studying, analyzing, discussing, and applying the texts. If a teacher wished to employ at least some elements of CBI for these classes, it would be crucial, as Snow (2001) has recommended, to “seek out material which is most suitable for language teaching aims” (p. 316). The genre of narrative is the most appropriate for beginning Hebrew learners. The instructor would also need both a significant level of language fluency and a thorough knowledge of the content to be taught in order to successfully execute CBI instruction.

The last issue to discuss concerning curricular integration is the role of God’s Word as a means of language learning. Should one focus only on the language when teaching a book like Jonah, or should interpretive and theological issues that are generally reserved for exegesis classes also be raised? Stoller and Grabe (1997) stated that “themes may be viewed as little more than convenient shells for language improvement activities or as a means for serious engagement with important concepts. We believe that the need for serious engagement is a requirement of CBI” (p. 90). One problem with the latter alternative, however, is that most students at the beginning stages are not ready to “engage with important concepts” in the L2; rather, they are merely trying to comprehend the meaning of the text! Nonetheless, interpretive and/or theological discussions can still

be accomplished to some degree. While the depth of study and level of interpretation achieved may not be to the degree they are in more advanced classes, one can still ask simple questions of the text that touch on theological and interpretive issues, and engage the learners with the meaning of the text, even at the beginning stages of language learning. It is important to take advantage of these opportunities whenever one can, as doing so will aid not just the acquisition process of the language, but also understanding God's Word to a greater degree.

Maximize Learning Opportunities

Evaluation of applicability. In one sense, the greatest way in which to maximize learning opportunities has already been discussed—namely, to teach how to use the target language in the target language. Contrast this with the traditional GT approach that is conducted entirely in the L1 and thus *minimizes* learning opportunities. Furthermore, the lecture-oriented nature of GT does not maximize learning opportunities. Rather, class should be full of interaction and communicative tasks that engage the learners and immerse them in the L2. As Jacobs and Farrell (2001) have pointed out, this requires a paradigm shift from teacher-oriented teaching to learner-oriented teaching. Only if and when this shift takes place will maximizing learning opportunities become a realistic goal for biblical language classes.

Examples of specific classroom activities. In short, anything that can be said in the L2 ought to be. For instance, simple instructions such as “Open your books to...” (באו וישבו *pithhu 'eth sifrekhem l...*), “Come and sit around the board” (bo'u ushevu saviv lalluah), “Please read...” (קרא נא *qera nah...*), and, “Answer the questions” (ענה את השאלות *'aneh 'eth hashe'eloth*) should all be conducted in the L2 in

order to maximize learning opportunities. In the same vein, learners should be required to use only the L2 when asking questions and interacting with one another.

Utilizing small groups and/or paired activities is another simple way to maximize learning opportunities because it allows more learners to engage in communication.

McCarthy & O’Keeffe (2004) state that “peer-to-peer scaffolding may be just as important as expert-novice scaffolding” (p. 32). In other words, learners should not be limited to interacting only with the teacher, who is generally a fluent or near-fluent speaker of the L2, since interacting with other learners benefits their acquisition process.

Constraints and limitations. The current shortage of teaching materials available for Hebrew and Greek can potentially limit the amount of learning opportunities for the biblical languages. However, this does not necessarily mean that teachers of the biblical languages cannot still create a robust, language-rich, communicative environment; it simply means they must be more creative in how they exploit the materials they do have and assign homework assignments that follow the principles contained in the communicative approach being advocated for here.

Further, the lack of available evidence needed for knowing how to say *all* that one might need to in a classroom context constrains the ability of a biblical Hebrew teacher to maximize learning opportunities as naturally as a native speaker might be able to. As discussed above (see this chapter, “Teach How to Use the Target Language in the Target Language”), this requires the use of circumlocution to communicate what is needed in a way that learners can understand.

Aim for Fluency Before Accuracy

Evaluation of applicability. Fluency is a foreign concept for most learners (and teachers) of the biblical languages who have only been exposed to GT instruction. *Very* few ever reach a near-fluent level. Those who do comprise “the 4% of the population [who] are believed to have the skills necessary to excel at GT” (Schultz, 2014, November 25, p. 6–7), and that typically only happens (if ever) after decades of teaching the language. This brings up another point, namely, that it is generally the 4 percent of students who excel at the languages under GT who go on to become teachers of the biblical languages. This serves to perpetuate the ineffective pedagogical cycle within the field of biblical languages.

What is perhaps more sobering is the remaining 96 percent of learners of the biblical languages who will never reach a level of fluency that proves to be helpful or sustainable for long-term use. This surely indicates a deficiency within the field. The reason, as has been explained already, is pedagogical—biblical language educators typically believe they need to drill as much of the L2 grammar as they can into the language learners’ minds in the 1–3 years they are granted for Hebrew or Greek courses. This exclusive focus on grammatical accuracy, however, not only does not produce fluency, it also makes it virtually impossible to retain all the information learned during those years. To drive this point even further, consider this substantial quote by Gruber-Miller (2006) who described his first experience teaching the classical languages:

When I was first teaching, I was more concerned to “cover the grammar” and “finish the book,” and then, I thought, my students would know Latin and Greek. After all, time is short, so it was best, I thought, to focus on what the book had to offer. There were paradigms to be memorized, vocabulary to be studied, exercises to be completed, and passages to translate. Once my students completed these hurdles, I assumed (or at least hoped) that they understood the new grammar well

enough and had learned enough vocabulary to move on to the next chapter. Somehow, I expected my students, after memorizing forms, studying vocabulary, and practicing sentences, to be able to read and understand—almost magically—Latin and Greek. And if they could not read yet, I usually gave them more of the same: exercises that focused on sentence-level syntax rather than the strategies needed for reading chunks of discourse. Instead of helping my students learn to read, understand, and interpret Greek and Latin within their cultural contexts, I was focusing on accuracy at the sentence level, only one aspect of what linguists call communicative competence. In short, I was practicing a theory of language teaching and learning that did not fit with my goal of helping students to read Greek and Latin fluently and accurately, of appreciating it as a “living” language. What I needed to do was to reexamine these assumptions in the light of what I hoped my students would be able to do after they had studied beginning Latin or Greek. (Kindle locations 132–141)

Gruber-Miller pointed out the contradiction between instructors’ stated goal—developing fluent readers of the text—and their instructional practices, which are incompetent to help their students reach that goal. So what is the solution?

Schultz (2012a, November 17) has highlighted that the reason why most Hebrew and Greek learners never reach fluency is because the mode of instruction (GT) includes no aural component. Psycholinguistic research shows that in order for lower-level reading processes such as word recognition, syntactic parsing, and meaning proposition encoding to become automatized, learners must develop a phonological loop that can only happen through aural comprehensible input. When the eyes see a word, the written symbol triggers the phonological loop (i.e., what the word sounds like), which triggers the process of lexical retrieval (i.e., what the word means). In Schultz’ words, “We understand a word, or access its meaning, because we ‘hear’ it, even if only in our mind/brain and not audibly” (2016, November 16, p. 2). This process happens instantaneously and without effort for those who are fluent in the language (Scovel, 1998; Grabe, 2010). Schultz has noted that those who claim to be fluent readers, yet who cannot hear or speak the language, are merely “fast decoders” who use their L1 knowledge of the

biblical text to comprehend the L2 text (Schultz, 2012a, November 17, p. 8). As Wood (2001) has stated,

An awareness of how psycholinguistic processes contribute to fluency, and how the structure and organization of language itself leads to fluency, is enlightening in general, but what are the implications for second language teaching and learning? ... The fundamentals would be interaction, production, attending to input, and, of course, attending to formulaic languages units, all operating in an integrated way” (p. 583).

More automatization of lower-level processes via interaction, production, and attention to input has a number of benefits. Directly, learners will be able to read more material faster because their attentional resources will not be consumed with lower-level decoding of the language. Indirectly, teachers will have more class time to focus on other aspects of the language, such as discourse analysis, literary and comparative analysis, and interpretation of the text itself. Developing such fluency should be the aim of biblical language teachers who desire to impart useful language skills to their students.

Finally, it should be emphasized that even if a native-like fluency in biblical Hebrew is not attained, the automatization of these lower-level processes is still possible, even with the limited vocabulary of beginning learners. Once a learner begins to recognize and automatize morphological patterns in the L2, then this immediate recognition spreads to unknown words when encountered in texts. Having automatized the processes of morphological and syntactic parsing and meaning proposition encoding, a learner is often able to make much sense of a sentence from the context, even if the meaning of a particular word or two is unknown. A quick gloss from a lexicon or a reader immediately triggers the full comprehension of the text. This fluency will produce rich dividends for those who desire to read ancient texts.

Examples of specific classroom activities. Because fluency should be developed in all four language skills (Ewert, 2015, March 28), the following activities will focus on particular skills, which will be identified.

4-3-2 (Nation, 2001) is an excellent activity that develops spoken fluency. Learners give the same talk about a particular topic to three different learners with decreasing time limits (4 min, 3 min, 2 min). For biblical Hebrew courses, the talk can simply be a summary of a text or a story read in class, a description of a particular object, what one does on the weekend, and so on. The repetition, the familiarity of material, the focus on meaning, and the time constraint provide the needed criteria for fluency-building (Nation, 2007). Nation describes the benefits of this activity: “Studies of the 4/3/2 technique ... have shown increases in fluency during the task, but surprisingly also increases in grammatical accuracy and grammatical complexity” (Arevart & Nation, 1991, and Nation, 1989, as cited in Nation, 2007). The activity can also be modified to accommodate shorter talks: 2 min, 1 min, 30 sec.

Jigsaw, which has been discussed twice already, is not only good for facilitating language production and integrating language skills, but the repetition involved also makes this a helpful spoken fluency building activity.

Reading fluency can be developed through an activity such as oral-paired reading (Ewert, 2015, March 28), where learners are paired and given 30 seconds to read aloud as much as they are able from a given text. At the end of the 30 seconds, the teacher says, “Start over,” and they begin rereading where they started the first time, but this time they have 45 seconds to read. At the end of the 45 seconds, the teacher says, “Start over,” and they begin rereading where they started the first time once again, but this time they are

given 60 seconds to read. Each time, they are expected to read the previous material faster, and then go further in the text than they did in the previous reading. At the end of the 60 seconds, the teacher says, “Switch,” and the other partner begins reading from the furthest point reached by the first student. The process is repeated, alternating between students for a given period of time (10–20 minutes). Of course, many variations are possible. A teacher can change the times to 30 or 60 seconds each, for instance, and encourage the readers to get further and further each time. This activity should be done only with a text that is easy to comprehend—whether it’s an easy text or one learners have been working on for some time in class.

Extensive reading is another well-documented activity for developing reading fluency. It is simply the reading of lots of simple material for pleasure (Nation, 2001, 2007). Grabe (2004) noted that “extensive reading ... [supports] both reading comprehension development and reading fluency (as well as incidental learning of a large recognition vocabulary and word recognition fluency)” (p. 56). Too often, biblical language courses expose students to authentic texts early in the course that are beyond the learners’ level of competence. While there certainly are exceptions, in general, the Bible does not prove to be good extensive reading material *for beginning learners*.

Vandergrift describes a six-step process proposed by Hulstijn (2003) that may be used to automatize word-recognition using a bottom-up approach. Utilizing a written text with an audio recording, students are to “(1) listen to the recording, (2) ask themselves whether they have understood what they heard, (3) replay the recording as often as necessary, (4) consult the written text to read what they have just heard, (5) recognize what they should have understood, and (6) replay the recording as often as necessary to

understand all of the oral text without written support” (as cited in Vandergrift, 2004, pp. 13–14). This six-step process is quite applicable to helping learners understand written texts with audio supplements. Requiring learners to approach the text in this systematic way is more helpful than merely telling them to “listen and read the text five times,” for instance. It also develops listening fluency.

Playing Bingo can also develop automatic word-recognition skills and listening fluency, as learners must listen to sentences that either define or describe particular words on the Bingo board, and then scan over them quickly to find the correct word before the teacher moves on to the next description. This is best done with words from a text that is currently being learned in class.

An exercise requiring learners to identify which word in a list of four is not associated semantically and/or conceptually with the other three can provide an easy game that develops automatic lexical retrieval. A simple worksheet can be developed based on words learners already know, or that are contained in a text being studied. For example (of course, there would be no English text or transliteration!):

- נַעַר *na'ar* (“boy”) מַיִם *mayim* (“water”) אִשָּׁה *'ishah* (“woman”) נַעֲרָה *na'arah* (“girl”)

הָעָם	הַיָּם	הַיּוֹם	בָּיִת	הַיָּם	1
נִימְצָא	הַסְּפִינָה	אֲנִיָּה	הָאֲנִיָּה	הָאֲנִיָּה	2
יִרְאֶה	נִירָאוּ	נִירָאוּ	הָאֲלֵהִים	נִירָאוּ	3

A similar exercise that increases automatic word recognition consists of a chart with five columns and however many rows one desires. The furthest right cell in each row contains a Hebrew word which is copied verbatim in any one of the other four cells in the same row. The remaining three cells in that row are filled with words that are either

semantically or, more effectively, morphologically related. Students must race to identify and circle which word in the four left cells matches the word in the furthest right cell. For example:

In such an activity, at least the words in the right column should come from the text being studied in order to provide more repetition and retrieval of known vocabulary (the above words come from Jonah 1:4–5).

Constraints and limitations. Because automatic word recognition is “the most fundamental requirement for fluent reading comprehension” (Grabe & Stoller, 2002, p. 20), learners need a massive amount of comprehensible input—both aural and written—in order to develop such word recognition fluency. Yet the sheer lack of appropriate language learner literature (Day & Bamford, 1998)—that is, reading material that is appropriate for learners—presents a major limitation for developing fluent reading abilities. Buth’s (2006a, 2008a) Hebrew and Greek picture books present excellent sources of simple words, phrases, and sentences (which can also be adapted and used for interactive tasks), but they do not include extended texts. Rico’s (2015) Greek text contains longer dialogues that provide more reading material, but these are naturally conversational in nature and not narrative. This is not inherently bad, but neither is it sufficient. Overland’s (2014) textbook provides a substantial serialized story that is appropriate for beginning learners, but neither is it a sufficient amount of reading material for an entire field of learners to develop fluency. Other fictional stories have been composed by the present author and others for use in beginning classes, yet most of them are very short and are aimed for use with TPRS, not extensive reading. Further, all

material written for learning purposes must be examined carefully to ensure that it accurately reflects the language system of biblical Hebrew.

The orthography of biblical Hebrew tends to be another hurdle for would-be learners to overcome. The orthographic and phonologic differences between English and Hebrew are significant, though not insurmountable. It simply takes time and scaffolding from simple to more complex language units to build proficiency and fluency.

Perhaps the greatest constraint to the development of fluency lies not with the fact that biblical Hebrew is “dead” or “difficult” language, but with the fact that teachers are expected to get through a certain amount of material—a particular textbook or curriculum—in a given time frame, which typically leaves little time for developing fluency. Moreover, it is assumed that all of the grammar knowledge contained in a standard first year grammar book is appropriate for beginning learners. The fact is, traditional textbooks contain too much explicit grammar knowledge to be learned well in one year and not enough implicit knowledge, neither of which is helpful for beginning learners. In order to develop fluency, which Nation (2007) has suggested should comprise one-quarter of class time, teachers must necessarily “give up” some learning of new material in order to “[get] good at what is already known” (p 8). However, very few (if any) teachers have “spare” class time. As McQuinn (2016, November 16) has stated, “Cramming as much information as possible into each lesson in order to ‘cover’ all the material (whatever that means), as well as overemphasizing accuracy, actually impedes the development of reading fluency for our students” (pp. 12–13). The long-term goal must be kept in mind. While it may seem fulfilling to get through an entire textbook, it is of no use if learners still cannot read the text fluently at the end or if they forget the

information contained therein soon after learning it. Developing fluency in learners will better prepare them for effective use of the ancient texts, not to mention lay a foundation for more explicit grammar learning at a later point. A focus on fluency will also likely require curricular changes to current biblical language programs (see Chapter 8).

Closely related to the issue of curriculum is the topic of assessment. If the focus of one's class is on the development of fluency, then assessment must reflect that. In other words, one cannot drastically change the focus of instruction from *accuracy* of explicit grammar knowledge—paradigm memorization, rule memorization, isolated vocabulary—to *fluency* of language use, yet retain the same forms of assessment that assess only accuracy. Jacobs & Farrell (2001) argued that one of the reasons that the paradigm shift to CLT took place so slowly was that the forms of assessment did not reflect the changes in teaching methodology.

Perhaps the best-known and most painful example of the failure to implement holistic change in second language education is that in many cases while teaching methodology has become more communicative, testing remains with the traditional paradigm, consisting of discrete items, lower-order thinking and a focus on form rather than meaning. ... This creates a backwash effect that tends to pull teaching back toward the traditional paradigm, even when teachers and others are striving to go toward the new paradigm. (p. 13)

Because assessment has (detrimentally) become the central and dominating factor in education, and because assessment usually belongs to the “higher-ups,” it tends to function as a gravitational force pulling language teaching back to its “old ways.” Two options are possible: either the paradigm shift that Jacobs & Farrel (2001) described (see Chapter 4) must take place on a higher level than the language educators (Fullan, 2007), or language educators must find new ways to assess learning that both meet the institution's demands and also fairly evaluate the students' level of communicative

competence and fluency. In other words, if all four language skills are being taught, then all four language skills should be assessed.

Assessment should be communicative in nature, which may require the use of non-traditional assessment, such as group-oriented assessment, where a teacher can observe learners' interaction and use of the language, or even self- or peer-assessment (see this chapter, "Promote Learner Autonomy" below). Most Learning Management Systems (e.g., Moodle, Blackboard, Schoology), which are used by many institutions these days, have recording features that enable students and/or teachers to record both audio and video for assignments. This provides an easy, built-in way to assess learner output without taking up valuable class time.

Promote Learner Autonomy

Evaluation of applicability. Unlike most other subjects, students of the biblical languages enter first-year courses with virtually zero prior knowledge of the topics they will study. This reality, coupled with the all-too-common rumors of the "dreaded" biblical language courses among college and seminary students creates an unfortunate trepidation among would-be Hebrew and Greek learners. The fear and suspense of the first day of class can negatively set the tone for the rest of the year, but this need not be the case.

Kumaravadivelu (1994) noted that "steps to promote learner autonomy include psychology preparation and strategic training" (p. 40). One's affective filter, which "include[s] factors such as motivation, attitude, self-confidence, and anxiety" (Gass, Behny, & Plonsky, 2013, p. 133), is one of the greatest hindrances to language acquisition among adult SL learners (Krashen, 1982). The approach with which one

teaches the language has a great bearing on learners' attitudes and confidence, and therefore, performance. It should be no surprise by this point that CLT serves to lower students' affective filter more so than a GT. As an example, Brian Schultz, who teaches Hebrew communicatively at Fresno Pacific University, has witnessed a *300 percent increased enrollment* in his beginning Hebrew course (from an average of about 6 before he began to an average of 20 students) over the course of seven years (Schultz, 2014, November 25, p. 3). He recorded the following anecdotal quotes by students of his:

“Hebrew was the cherry on top of my college education.”

“I’m a psych major but my favorite class is Hebrew.”

“Before coming to FPU I had no idea about biblical Hebrew; today it is a major part of what FPU means to me.”

“I never thought I was capable of learning another language. Learning Hebrew has definitely been an incredible experience for me.”

“I love Hebrew—it’s my favorite class and has been the most interesting during my college years.” (pp. 3–4)

Such statements reflect an uncommon enthusiasm among learners of the biblical languages. Schultz (2014, November 25) also noted that 80 percent of his Hebrew students take his Hebrew classes as electives (p. 4). In other words, they are not required to take them for their major. Again, this is unheard of in Hebrew programs that employ GT. This evidence, though merely anecdotal, speaks volumes to the effectiveness that CLT can have on learners' affect, motivation, and anxiety.

Promoting learner autonomy also requires teaching learners how to be good learners—discovering their learning style, developing learning strategies, and taking on the responsibility of learning for themselves. Further, learners need to have some sense of freedom or choice when it comes to curricular decisions. This reflects a learner-oriented approach rather than a teacher-oriented approach (Jacobs & Farrell, 2001). As noted above, the teacher cannot be viewed as the only one with all the answers. Learners bring

numerous valuable resources to the learning environment and these can and should be exploited in the classroom.

Examples of specific classroom activities. Allowing students to choose topics to study/read that interest them (assuming it fits in within the overall course objectives) is an easy way to promote learner autonomy. Particularly at higher levels of biblical Hebrew, allowing students to choose which biblical texts they wish to read (Day & Bamford, 1998) gives them a sense of “owning” their learning and increases their interest in the course, and thus their motivation.

Utilizing small groups or pairs promotes learner autonomy since the learners become dependent on one another (and not the teacher) for learning activities to be successful. They must pool together their resources, and negotiate meaning with one another in order to accomplish tasks (Jacobs & Farrell, 2001, p. 4).

Self-assessment, while not conventional, has great benefits. According to Jacobs and Farrell (2001), self-assessment allows learners

to develop their own internal criteria for the quality of their work, rather than being dependent on external evaluation, often by the teacher, as the sole judge of their strengths and weakness. Developing these internal criteria enables learners to make informed decisions about how to move their learning forward. (p. 6)

In other words, students sense their own role in the learning process through self-evaluation. some of these techniques will go a long way in promoting learner autonomy.

Constraints and limitations. Some teachers may object to the notion of promoting learner autonomy, or, at the very least, be skeptical of its value because the only biblical language instruction they have experienced was very much teacher-oriented. Developing such learner autonomy thus demands a “loosening of the reigns,” a willingness to let learners explore and use the language, to make learner errors, and to

learn from them. The utilization of small groups is one area where this can be difficult for teachers who are used to being the “one in control,” but they must trust that learners will take on the responsibility for their learning and rise to the occasion when given the opportunity to do so. Naturally, this assumes learners have been prepared adequately. Promoting learner autonomy should never come across as the teacher merely “abandoning” the students or shirking her responsibility as a teacher.

Another possible constraint is the fact that self-assessment may not fall within an institution’s assessment guidelines, or that a teacher may not be comfortable with it simply because he has never attempted it. On the surface, therefore, there can appear to be some element of risk involved in promoting learner autonomy, but the benefits far outweigh the risks.

Ensure Social Relevance

Evaluation of applicability. As was discussed at the beginning of this chapter (see “The Purpose”), the goal of biblical language instruction is ultimately to be literate in the L2, which includes, but is not limited to, reading ancient texts as fluently as possible. In order for this to happen, however, reading must be viewed in its proper place; that is, within the larger context of communication. The *written* texts that biblical language learners *read* were once *spoken* and *heard* by real people in real social contexts. Modern readers are simply “eavesdropping” in on the conversation. In his chapter entitled “Communication, Context, and Community: Integrating the *Standards* in the Greek and Latin Classroom,” Gruber-Miller (2006) discussed the nature of communication:

Communication is something we do every time we read a text, write a letter, or discuss a problem. Communication helps us establish our individual identities,

develops our relationships with others, allows us to create communities, and shapes our view of the world. It is not limited to speaking, but more often than not involves several, if not all, modes of communication: listening, speaking, reading, and writing. (Kindle locations 152–154)

He goes on to discuss the three modes of communication as presented in the *Standards for Foreign Language Learning*—interpersonal, interpretive, and presentational (Gruber-Miller, 2006)—which align nicely with Savignon’s (1997) threefold definition of communication: “A continuous process of *expression* [i.e., presentational], *interpretation* [i.e., interpretive], and *negotiation of meaning* [i.e., interpersonal]” (as cited in Gruber-Miller, 2006, Kindle location 151, italics original). These modes of communication were all employed in the day-to-day conversation of ancient speakers, as preserved in the “speeches, philosophical dialogues, [and] historical narratives” (Gruber-Miller, 2006, Kindle location 158) that are used in ancient language classes today. In fact, *many* of these texts were originally written in order to be performed orally and heard by live audiences. How can one truly understand these texts, or the biblical prophets’ messages, or the poetic beauty of the psalmists, or the captivating narratives that were passed down orally from generation to generation, without being able to hear, speak, interact with, and respond to the messages contained in the L2? Students thus need to experience the language as performance, interact with it, and engage in social contexts that represent the original texts. In short, there is a great need for social interaction among learners of ancient languages.

Because all learning is socially mediated (Vygotsky, 1978, as cited in Hall & Verplaetse, 2000), the learning of the biblical languages must also be socially relevant. Biblical language learners share a common purpose in engaging with the biblical text. They come together in order to participate in a social environment that corporately

increases motivation and confidence in the language learning task. While there is one sense in which learners are autonomous, this must be balanced by the social nature of language learning in which learners sink or swim together (Jacobs & Farrell, 2001). There is interdependence—if one learner does not do his job, interaction/communication fails and the other learners suffer.

In order to ensure social relevance, teachers must take into account the context and purpose for which their students are learning, and make every possible effort to create a language environment that is marked by successful meaning making. This involves the social use of the language among learners in a community with a shared goal.

Examples of specific classroom activities. In order to ensure social relevance, the activities chosen for a class should align with the stated goals of the class, which, in turn, should be clearly communicated to learners at the outset. When learners come to class expecting certain modes of instructional delivery, or particular exercises, or preconceptions of what the student's role is or what the student-teacher relationship ought to look like, and then these expectations are unfulfilled, the class has become socially irrelevant and effective meaning-making becomes very difficult. Communication between the teacher and learners is therefore important to maintain throughout the course of instruction.

Constraints and limitations. One potential difficulty of ensuring social relevance in some contexts is the diverse nature and backgrounds of learners with differing views of the biblical text, which may influence how a teacher engages with the text and/or interacts with the students concerning it.

Other factors that may influence—not necessarily limit—the social interactions is the cultural, political, and social backgrounds among learners who may have differing preconceptions regarding cultural norms that inevitably come to bear on interpretation of the text or the learning process. With attention and care, however, these need not hinder the learning environment. On the contrary, if exploited properly, they will only enhance the learning experience for all learners.

Conclusion

In conclusion, both SLA research and classroom research appear to support the feasibility of a principled communicative methodology for teaching biblical Hebrew. Moreover, because biblical Hebrew affords less (extra-biblical) literature with which to work, if CLT can be successfully accomplished with Hebrew then it most certainly can with Koiné Greek as well. Certainly there are some limitations and constraints, the most significant of which is the lack of pedagogical materials—particularly language learner literature—as well as spoken fluency among most teachers of the biblical languages. However, there are a number of individuals who have reached substantial levels of fluency in the biblical dialects and there is a whole host of learners who are trailing closely behind them.

Following such an approach will not only make biblical language learning more efficient, more enjoyable, and more useful for learners, it will also enable them to reach higher levels of proficiency in language accuracy, complexity, and fluency (Skehan, 2009). Biblical language teachers whose goal is to produce fluent readers of Hebrew and Greek must seriously consider the fact that no SLA research supports GT as a viable means to acquire a second language, “dead” or not. Alternatively, the literature shows

that CLT is the most effective methodology for language teaching. To heed such research, therefore, would be a prudent decision for the field of biblical language instruction.

While the applicability of modern SLA principles has largely been shown to be a possible endeavor, there is still much room for growth. What does the future hold for CLT among the biblical languages and what is needed for the field to develop? This is the topic of the next chapter.

ⁱⁱ The author's experience extends beyond biblical Hebrew to Koiné Greek as well, including: 1) participation in FPU's/BLC's 10-day Greek fluency workshop; 2) teaching assistant at FPU: 3-unit course, co-taught 1 time; 3) Veritas Scholar's Academy: 6-unit course, taught 1 time; and 4) Grace Clovis Presbyterian Church: 3-unit course, taught 1 time.

ⁱⁱⁱ Rico (2015) has described a helpful and systematic approach to finding more useful and appropriate vocab for use in a Koiné Greek CLT classroom:

To compose [the Greek texts contained in *Speaking Ancient Greek as a Living Language*] we drew material from concordances of Apollonius Dyscolus (grammatical vocabulary), Plutarch (daily terms), and the New Testament (common vocabulary). These three corpora allow us to base the language of our texts on a vast range of literature from the first century AD. Whenever these concordances did not provide the word needed, they were supplemented by the vocabulary of the Septuagint. In some cases, such as *téléphōnon* (τηλέφωνον), we created neologisms for objects that were non-existent at the beginning of the Christian era. It thus became possible to produce texts that carry the full strength of living language. Further, we drew from the various concordances frequent idioms and ways of speaking specific to first century Greek. (p. II)

CHAPTER 8: A WAY FORWARD

Introduction

As one explores a way forward for biblical language instruction, there are several questions that must be addressed. For instance, most biblical language teachers will want to know how the proposed communicative methodology for teaching the biblical languages will have a practical effect on their students, particularly as it regards exegesis. Second, there is the question of what is needed in the field of biblical language instruction in order for an approach such as this to continue to develop and become more thoroughly consistent with the SLA literature. The third question regards the issue of curriculum implementation. Assuming one understands the value of a communicative approach and has the desire and resources to adopt it, what are some necessary questions to consider if it is to be effectively implemented in the current field of biblical language instruction, which is more or less skeptical of such a paradigm shift. Each of these questions will be answered in turn.

The “So What?” Question

There are two parts to the “So what?” question. The first part deals with the issue of *quantity*: Will teaching the biblical languages using CLT enable students to learn the languages more efficiently than they would using the traditional GT approach? This is one of the greatest objections the present author has faced regarding a communicative approach. It is contended that colleges and seminaries have only 1–3 years to teach the languages and therefore they don’t have time to teach speaking, to play games, and to do

other such “useless” or “frivolous” activities. Rather, they need to get down to the “nitty gritty,” the meaty, the substantive content—learning the grammar asap so that students can effectively engage in “responsible” exegesis. This is the goal of biblical language classes, is it not—to be able to read and exegete the biblical text?

As should be evident, this line of reasoning is ignorant of the foregoing discussion of SLA research, which absolutely and definitively demonstrates that CLT enables the brain to learn more knowledge faster. Recall N. Ellis’ (2005) empirical research into cognitive psychology, neurobiology, and psycholinguistics that implicit learning is not only faster, but it accounts for the vast majority of all knowledge, including languages. It is true, explicit instruction can expedite certain issues for adult learners who may encounter occasional “roadblocks” in their learning, but by and large, implicit instruction is the brain’s natural way of learning and acquiring languages. In other words, learning to hear and speak a language enables one to acquire the L2 faster than GT does, which, in turn, allows one to read, comprehend, and interact with L2 texts on a deeper level (including grammatical analysis). Fluency also means learners will be able to cover more material faster.

To illustrate this point, Mounce (2009), a standard GT beginning Greek textbook, introduces only 319 vocabulary words. Mounce pointed out that learning these words allows one to read the bulk of the New Testament (nearly 80 percent of all word occurrences) and then stated:

I think it is counterproductive at this point to learn more, unless you really like doing things like that. Your time is better spent reading the Bible or learning grammar. And 319 words are not very many. Most introductory textbooks for other languages have about 2,000 words. (p. 16)

To restate Mounce, he believes it is “counterproductive” to learn more than 319 words in a first-year language course! He even highlights the fact that other languages usually teach over six times as many words as he does in the same amount of time! Rather than being an occasion for trumpeting his “systematic” method over “most introductory textbooks for other languages,” Mounce ought to question why he only teaches 319 words in his textbook. Of course, in light of SLA research, the reason is because learners under a GT approach cannot possibly learn 2,000 vocabulary words without the implicit instruction that characterizes CLT.

The use of CLT explains why programs such as the Polis Institute and the Biblical Language Center have experienced such positive results from their courses. To recall Polis’ claim, after only two years of instruction students are able “to read and understand a simple ancient text with no need of a dictionary or translation” (Rico, n.d.a). Indeed, one is able to watch an MA student from Polis give a six-minute speech entirely in Koine Greek with the following title: “Imagine you are the head of the Polis Institute and that students organized a demonstration at the entrance to complain that Ancient Greek is a very difficult language. Go meet them and give a speech to react to their demonstration” (Polis Institute, n.d.). Graduates of GT biblical language programs cannot compare to this level of competence and it is highly unlikely that the student who gave that speech would fair worse on *any* form of Greek assessment than a student from a GT program. Similarly, one only needs to read the numerous testimonies of BLC students (some of whom hold PhDs in Hebrew or Greek) who have met remarkable success from BLC’s programs, including their beginning courses (Biblical Language Center, n.d.b)!

One problem, however, is that some teachers have either observed CLT executed poorly or they have attempted it themselves without adequate training, and have thus become disillusioned and ultimately turned off to either the possibility and/or the effectiveness of implementing CLT in their biblical language class(es). The minimal advantages observed or experienced does not justify the amount of effort and labor required to transition from the way one has been teaching his entire career. Nonetheless, the malpractice of something should not nullify the validity of its proper practice. This points to the need for teacher training, which will be discussed below (see this chapter, “Teacher Training”).

The second part of the “So what?” question addresses *quality*: Will teaching the biblical languages using CLT produce better biblical exegetes than the traditional GT approach currently does? It is possible—perhaps necessary—to address this question from multiple perspectives. First, from the perspective of research, while there is no empirical research that *proves* a communicative methodology will produce better exegetes than GT, there are some issues in the SLA research to consider.

For instance, research suggests that a reading rate of 200 words per minute is necessary in order to achieve full comprehension of a text’s meaning (Anderson, 2009; Grabe, 2004). Grabe (2009) matter-of-factly states that “[R]eading comprehension is *not possible* without rapid and automatic word recognition.” (Grabe, 2009, p. 23, as cited in Schultz, 2016, November 16, italics are Schultz’s). This is because when one reads slowly, syllable by syllable, “too much time lapses for one’s working memory to be able to integrate the new, incoming information with prior knowledge before it is discarded as unimportant” (McQuinn, 2016, November 16, p. 12). Fluent reading allows one to read

entire texts in one sitting, rather than mere chunks of verses (“pericopes”) that can break up the original author’s flow of thought, potentially leading to misinterpretation. If full comprehension of a text is thus necessary for accurate interpretation (i.e., exegesis) then fluency indeed is a necessary goal, which is most efficiently attained through CLT.

A higher competency in the L2 also means one is better able to discern the choices an author had at his disposal, and therefore understand the significance of the particular choice that was made. As Runge (2010) has rightly noted, when it comes to communication, “choice implies meaning” (p. 5). However, if a learner has not developed automaticity of lower-level reading skills, it is highly unlikely that her working memory will be able to process the linguistic data *and* attend to possible choices the author could have made that are *not* present in the text. In other words, automaticity allows a reader to “feel” the texture of a text—particular word choices, when something does not sound quite right, when a unique expression is employed, and so on. This ability surely makes one a better reader—and exegete—of L2 texts.

Another perspective from which to answer the question of how CLT affects the *quality* of exegesis actually addresses a more fundamental question: What *is* exegesis? While this question deserves its own treatise, a few comments are in order. First, the term ‘exegesis’ refers to the “thorough, analytical study of a biblical passage done so as to arrive at a useful interpretation of the passage” (Stuart, 2009, p. 1). Put more simply, it is the process of determining an author’s intended meaning in its original context. This seems like an appropriate goal for studying literature. Indeed, one might say it is the very same goal as other kinds of non-biblical literature. However, it should be highlighted that ‘exegesis’ courses exist *only* in the field of biblical studies and not in *any other* literature

program, including classical literature (Streett, 2011, November 20). Why is this the case? Streett (2011, November 20) has shared some helpful thoughts:

The question, “what about exegesis?” often presupposes a concept of exegesis that I find less than helpful. Much of the time, what people mean when they say exegesis is an atomistic study of a very short stretch of text, usually no more than a few lines. “Exegesis” means detailed grammatical and lexical study, determining what the logical relationships between propositions is, and then, as the crowning achievement, translating the text into English. ...

This is rather strange. ... Literary critics don’t really talk much about exegesis, nor do classicists, surprisingly. Why is that? Those groups talk a lot about interpretation and hermeneutics and context, but not “exegesis.”

I would like to propose that much of what people mean by “exegesis” is artificial, atomistic over-analysis of little bits of texts that were originally intended to be heard as wholes, not analyzed, labeled and translated. (pp. 1–2)

In other words, much of what is taught in exegesis courses is not even necessary if one is able to truly read the text. Parsing and labeling forms with linguistic metalanguage, diagramming sentences, analyzing syntax, and translating a text become unnecessary in order to comprehend the text’s deepest, fullest meaning. *Nobody* does this in his/her L1. In fact, any modern scholar would be appalled if someone else attempted to interpret his writing using the same methods taught in biblical studies courses (for a particularly poignant example of this, see Silva, 1990, pp. 11–17). Nonetheless, biblical scholars believe that this sort of exegetical process is necessary in order to comprehend ancient texts.

Some might argue that the process of exegeting a biblical text involves a theological component that other literature does not require (biblical, systematic, historical, and practical theology are all typically considered sub-components of the exegetical process). This is certainly true, but just because one is handling the inspired Word of God does not change the way language is used to communicate—either when it was written or when it is read. The massive amounts of time spent “atomistically

overanalyzing” the biblical text at the sentence-level could be better spent reading, rereading, and re-reading longer portions text, discussing meaning, finding themes, tracing developments, comparing with other texts, making connections, examining elements of literary artistry, understanding the literary, social, and historical contexts, and teasing out logical implications, all of which can be done in the L2 (Streett, 2011, November 20). Most of these processes are included in the traditional exegetical method, but they are conducted in the learners’ L1, not the L2, and what tends to happen is that students preparing a sermon or writing an exegesis paper tend to spend the vast majority of their time on the grammatical analysis/translation phase because they cannot read the text fluently. This, in turn, leaves little time for the other, non-linguistic phases of the exegetical process.

Grabe (2010) has surveyed the reading fluency research over the past 35 years and then highlighted the supportive relationship between reading fluency and reading accuracy. He has quoted Nation (1997) who stated, “Fluency is ... accompanied by improvements in accuracy and complexity” (Nation, 1997, p. 16, as cited in Grabe, 2010, p. 78). In other words, to read accurately, one must be able to read fluently, and reading fluency “only emerges[s] as an outcome of implicit learning (rather than explicit learning of aspects of language knowledge)” (Grabe, 2010, p. 73). It seems reasonable to conclude, therefore, that the better one’s implicit grasp of the L2 through CLT, the more efficient and the more reliable she will be in reading and accurately interpreting L2 texts.

What Is Needed in the Field of Biblical Language Instruction?

Just as the rise of CLT shook the field of SLA in the late twentieth century, so too will the idea of a paradigm shift towards CLT inevitably shake the field of biblical

languages as it gains more and more proponents. It is a foreign thought to most instructors of the biblical languages, and an outrageous idea to others. It is, therefore, important to identify what needs to be done within the field, especially at such a fledgling stage of its development.

Schultz (2014, November 25) has correctly identified the two major hurdles to “teaching biblical Hebrew in biblical Hebrew”: “First, a lack of oral fluency in many instructors of biblical Hebrew, and second, a lack of materials or training available to learn how to implement CLT” (p. 2). These certainly seem to be the greatest and most immediate needs in order for CLT to begin building momentum, yet there are two longer-term needs as well: time and research. Therefore, the following four needs will be addressed: 1) *materials*—to develop useful materials that are consistent with SLA principles; 2) *teacher training*—to ensure the implementation of sound CLT principles in biblical language classrooms; 3) *time*—for biblical language programs to require more units for language courses; and 4) *research*—to progress the field of biblical language instruction towards more and more effective and credible theory and practice.

Materials

Textbooks. The field of biblical languages has reached a “post-grammar book condition,” to adapt Kumaravadivelu’s (1994) term. Even the term “grammar book” reveals its misplaced priority in the biblical language classroom, at least as the main resource used for teaching and learning. In addition to GT textbooks, however, some of the textbooks described in Chapter 6 that claim to implement SLA principles fail to do so thoroughly or consistently.

To be clear, *textbooks* (not grammar books) do play a critical role in fostering a principled communicative environment for language acquisition to take place in, both for class and homework use. This is particularly true in the case of less commonly taught languages (such as the biblical languages) because pedagogical resources are usually scarce. In addition to this, the teacher typically does not have adequate training in SL teaching methods. Textbooks that provide extensive pedagogical tips for teachers are needed (Overland's [2014] textbook contains some, though even more are needed). Also, to be most helpful, textbooks must be laden with illustrations and other sources of implicit instruction. Picture dictionaries prove to be great tools for beginning learners. They could include common scenes of biblical contexts (schemas) that could be illustrated to introduce a whole slew of vocabulary related to that particular topic, context, or scene. Simple Hebrew-Hebrew lexicons would prove beneficial as learners' vocabulary begins to grow (see Rico [2015] for a prime Greek example of this).

Visual materials. In addition to textbooks, another needs is the development of visualize materials that provide implicit instruction for Hebrew and Greek classes. In one sense, a standard classroom—supplied with doors, windows, walls, desks, containers, not to mention students—can provide immense amounts of teaching “materials.” However, materials that are specific to the cultural milieu of the biblical languages go a long way in helping L2 learners identify with the L2 culture. This may include illustrated biblical texts/stories, archaeological photographs from various museums, pictures from the land of Israel, actual props (stone, shofar, sword, wineskin, culturally appropriate food, and so on), and a whiteboard with markers for those items that are physically inaccessible. Access to computers in order to utilize Bible software and online resources may be of

help. Such teaching resources are crucial. Johnson, Monk, and Swain (2000) pointed out that even if teachers are educated and trained to use CLT through in-service or other means, if their teaching environment does not change or is not conducive to the desired teaching approach, then pedagogic changes will not take place.

Language learner literature. The Bible was not written with language learners in mind. Nonetheless, all too many biblical language textbooks and courses pride themselves on introducing authentic texts to learners early on. However, no first-year German teacher would consider giving her students a reading selection from Goethe, for to do so would be largely unhelpful for learners. Day and Bamford (1998) have rightly identified the need for language learner literature that communicates to beginning learners in a way that is appropriate for them. In their words:

The point is not whether the author uses fewer words and shorter sentences (“simplification”) or more words in embedded sentences, making explicit any background suppositions (“elaboration”). The point is to express—without being patronizing, terse, or verbose—the content in a way that communicates to the audience. (p. 65)

There is a massive need for language learner literature to be written for the biblical languages. Different genres, topics, and levels of difficulty that engage learners of all backgrounds and language aptitudes would provide a start to the needed repertoire of extensive reading material, which Nation (2001) and Grabe (2010) have identified as one of the key ways to build reading fluency.

Although the above materials are need, it is also important to realize that the textbook and teaching materials do *not* dictate the pedagogical practices employed by teachers. The textbook is merely one component of a larger curriculum that involves not just a book, but classroom practices, homework, assessment, class activities, and so on.

No matter how closely the book and/or resources follow SLA principles, it does not ultimately guarantee the effectiveness of the language learning experience for learners, because the most important factor that contributes to an effective CLT class is the ability of teachers to execute it successfully.

Teacher Training

The importance of teacher training cannot be overstated. In a very real sense, success or failure in a language class depends almost entirely upon the teacher. This does not mean a teacher-oriented approach is best. Rather, it is upon the teacher to effectively create a learning environment that is characterized by the ten principles—including “Promote Learner Autonomy”—detailed in Chapters 4 and 7. All of the SLA research may be conducted and curriculum designers can apply that research and produce the greatest possible textbooks and resources, but if the teacher does not know how to properly use them to teach the target language, then all of it amounts to nothing. According to Kumaravadivelu (1994), “research reveals that regardless of what textbooks profess, it is the teacher who can succeed or fail in creating contexts that encourage meaning making in the classroom” (p. 38). Similarly, Dallaire (2006, November 19) rightly pointed out that

no textbook can replace sound pedagogy. Printed materials should be treated as servants to the teacher and not as masters of the classroom. Although they can provide a basic framework on which to develop a class, they should be treated as springboards from which creativity and ideas flow, and provide prompts for imaginative instruction in the classroom. No textbook is meant to dictate the course of actions of a teacher. (pp. 7–8)

In other words, a teacher cannot simply spoon feed material from a textbook and expect learners to benefit. It takes creative spontaneity and an understanding of principled

pragmatism (Kumaravadivelu, 1994), as discussed above (see Chapter 4, “The Postmethod Condition”).

Indeed, successful language teaching requires what Meskill and Anthony (2015) have termed “instructional conversations,” which involve the constant evaluation of student comprehension and progress, as well as the continually adjustment of instruction to meet learner needs. “It is the role of excellent language educators to craft tasks and accompanying responsive conversations so that opportunities for learning are optimized” (p. 18). No textbook can make this happen. This is because education is more than a mere transfer of knowledge, which tends to be teacher-centered (Wedell, 2003). Wedell cited Wang and Wang (2000), who expounded on this idea:

Many teachers still put more emphasis on the *delivery of knowledge about the language*, while *ignoring the development of students’ language abilities*. Classroom teaching continues to be largely *teacher centred*, which does not foster student interest or motivation for learning or develop their individuality. *Students are learning passively* only for passing examinations. (as cited in Wedell, 2003, pp. 443, 445, italics original)

According to Kumaravadivelu (2006), a postmethod pedagogy, as is being advocated for here, “is premised on a transformative teacher education program that does not merely lead to ‘the easy reproduction of any ready-made package or knowledge but, rather, the continued recreation of personal meaning’ on the part of teachers” (Diamond, 1993, as cited in Kumaravadivelu, 2006, p. 74). Teachers must be educated in how to apply postmethod principles in their specific teaching contexts in order for the material to actually be relevant and life-changing for learners. Again, this is particularly true of biblical language teachers who do not have an SLA or SL teaching background.

Teacher pre-service and in-service courses, training seminars, fluency workshops, teacher manuals, and even participating in communicative classes as learners are all ways

in which teachers may be trained to understand, embrace, and implement a principled approach to teaching the biblical languages.

Self-reflection is another helpful way to promote teacher training. For instance, by utilizing the said approach as a springboard, teachers may be creative in how they apply, expand, and integrate the principles based on their own classroom experience and continued research in the field. Kumaravadivelu (1994) has suggested one practical way to do this:

By regularly audio/videotaping their own classroom performance and by using macrostrategies as interpretive strategies, [teachers] can analyze classroom input and interaction to assess how successful they have been in facilitating negotiated interaction, in integrating language skills, in contextualizing linguistic input, and so forth. Such action research will help teachers generate empirically grounded, practice-oriented microstrategies and also enable them to develop their own practical theory of language pedagogy. (p. 43)

In addition to recording a class, co-teaching with a colleague, a TA, or an advanced student can also provide invaluable feedback as well as a sounding board to throw ideas off of (not to mention it is a tremendous pedagogical advantage for learners).

The last issue of teacher training regards fluency among biblical language teachers, which is clearly the greatest obstacle to this entire enterprise. The lack of fluent L2 teachers is what led to the Reading Approach back in the early twentieth century (see Chapter 4, “A History of Second Language Teaching: From the Nineteenth Century to the Present”); it is this very same reason that will prevent the adoption of a communicative approach among biblical language teachers today, if nothing is done about it. As has been made clear throughout this paper, the only way to learn a language is by using it. This applies no less to teachers than to students. Developing fluency will demand “becoming like a child” once again and participating in some of the programs or

utilizing some of the textbooks described in Chapter 6 (beginning courses are recommended for those with little or no communicative background). It will require embracing the vision, losing one's sense of self-consciousness, and "jumping in with both feet." The first year will undeniably be difficult but students will be greatly served. Each year thereafter, one will become more and more comfortable with the teaching methodology, not to mention more and more proficient in the L2.

As is evident, teacher training is paramount for CLT to be adopted among biblical language programs. Indeed, Wedell (2003) identified teachers as the "key players" in the process of curriculum change (p. 441; see also Hancock & Eyres, 2004 and Sharkey, 2004). Clearly, however, both materials and teacher training are needed. It is likely that a reciprocal process will be necessary. As additional materials are produced, perhaps more teachers will see the benefits and effectiveness of CLT and join the effort, and as teachers are trained, there will be more "hands on deck" to produce more materials.

What will happen when teachers are educated how to teach the biblical languages better? As time goes on, and more learners and teachers become equipped with higher levels of communicative competence in the biblical languages, the bar will be raised for others to aspire to. Jacobs and Farrell (2001) have pointed out that "the goal is for students to move toward and perhaps even beyond, the teacher's level of competence" (p. 5). Similarly, in her discussion of how to become proficient in ancient Greek, Saffire (2006) stated it even more provocatively: "If we [teachers] do our job well enough, our project will self-destruct. The next generation of classicists will be able to teach by speaking with far less difficulty than we have" (Kindle locations 2657–2658). Particularly in the field of biblical language acquisition, this is very likely to happen.

Time

More time is another component that is needed for the field of biblical language instruction. Schultz (2012b) compared biblical language program requirements at Christian liberal arts institutions with the same institutions' requirements for modern languages. He found that the more prestigious institutions among those of the Council for Christian Colleges and Universities (CCCU) require only 24 units of Greek for New Testament Greek majors, while they require roughly 44 units of French for French majors (including 12 prerequisite units) (pp. 59–60). Most institutions, however, fared much worse than this when it came to the biblical languages. Furthermore, many of the institutions do not even have a Hebrew program but only offer a few independent Hebrew classes as electives. This means that most students entering graduate school or seminary will have no Hebrew background and only some will have a little Greek. By contrast, to enter a graduate program in any modern language one is likely required already to have a BA in the L2, which then allows him to reach full fluency in the course of graduate studies.

Schultz (2012b) proceeded to address the perplexing question as to why even the best Christian institutions require only *half* the number of units that they require for modern languages at the undergraduate level, especially given the nature of the object of study—namely, the Bible—and the goal of most CCCU schools—that is, to train the next generation of biblical scholars and Church leaders (p. 61)? While there are multiple factors that influence this situation, one cannot get around the fact that as long as the institutions deem it sufficient to require only 1–2 years of Hebrew and/or Greek as preparation for life-long ministry of the Word, learners of the biblical languages have no

hope of reaching a level of proficiency that even comes near that of their modern language peers. Two three-unit courses is but a drop in the bucket when it comes to language acquisition. Indeed, Hinkel (2006) has confirmed that “FL or L2 proficiency cannot be developed when learning is limited to 1–3 hours of classroom instruction and input” (p. 114). Even two years of language study is hardly sufficient to provide learners with effective interpretive tools to handle the Bible responsibly in its original languages. These meager language requirements coupled with the ineffectiveness of the current pedagogy leave learners in a helpless state. Institutions must acknowledge this bleak situation and begin to remediate it by offering—indeed, requiring—more units of study for the biblical languages.

Research

Lastly, more research is needed in order to validate with empirical data the overwhelming amount of anecdotal and experiential evidence that currently exists among those who have attempted to implement CLT to the teaching of the biblical languages. The field needs such researched-based credibility. For instance, some who are skeptical want to see “hard evidence” that this approach to teaching will produce better exegetes before considering a departure from their GT position, yet interestingly, Schultz (2012b) has observed that

all resistance to such an approach to teaching the biblical languages is coming from those who have not or do not want to try. But to deny that such an approach is beneficial, they must discount the unanimous testimony of those who have tried it and found it to be so, as well as the broadly accepted conclusions of the science of second-language reading. (pp. 67–68)

Nevertheless, even among proponents of CLT, it would be interesting and helpful to conduct studies that demonstrate: 1) the rate of acquisition among learners in a GT class

versus the rate among learners in a CLT class, given the same time frame; and 2) whether a CLT approach does indeed lend itself to a more robust skill base that contributes to better interpretation of the biblical text. Obviously, the former of these two research questions would be easier to measure objectively.

In conclusion, while various efforts have been and are being made in order for CLT to gain traction within the field of biblical languages, there is still much work that needs to be done. Specifically, more materials are needed that are consistent with language teaching principles derived from SLA research, teachers must be trained with sound pedagogical practices, learners need more time (in terms of units) to acquire the biblical languages, and more research must be conducted to provide empirical evidence for the value of utilizing CLT for the teaching of the biblical languages. An established MA program in Ancient Language Acquisition at an institution such as FPU could prove to be a vital means of accomplishing all four of these needs, as well as equipping the next generation with Church leaders who are competent handlers of the Word of God.

The Issue of Curriculum Implementation

In addition to the foregoing discussion regarding what is needed for the field of biblical language instruction, the issue of curriculum implementation must be addressed, since an ideal biblical language program—complete with a perfectly designed curriculum and well-trained teacher—may still fail at the implementation stage, for any number of reasons.

It is widely recognized that curriculum reform does not occur easily (Rogan & Grayson, 2003; Stoyneff, 1989). Michael Fullan (2007) has noted that “change will always fail until we find some way of developing infrastructures and processes that

engage teachers in developing new knowledge, skills, and understandings” (p. 29). This goes back to teacher-training. Curriculum change involves the *reculturing* of teachers, not merely the *restructuring* of programs (p. 25). This is especially true in the field of biblical language instruction where the culture has been entirely and exclusively entrenched in GT for two centuries. A “deep reform” is clearly needed which involves more than simply adopting new materials—that is only the first dimension. There also needs to be teacher training, as well as an alteration of beliefs, or the “pedagogical assumptions and theories underlying particular new policies or programs” (p. 30). Without these three dimensions—materials, teacher-training, and alteration of beliefs—an effective and long-lasting curriculum change is unlikely to take place.

Rogan and Grayson (2003) noted that because of poor implementation, “good ideas are never translated into classroom reality” and, “as a result, a great deal of time, money, and efforts may be wasted” (p. 1172). Therefore, there needs to be a well-thought program for implementing CLT among biblical language teachers for whom a communicative methodology is a major paradigm shift—indeed, one that strikes at the very core of their profession. Gorsuch (2000) observed, “Regardless of successive educational reforms and curriculum changes, teachers’ attitudes and beliefs remain the single strongest guiding influence on instruction” (p. 678). To think that a biblical language instructor with no SLA background is both willing and able simply to adopt a communicative methodology and implement it effectively is a naive expectation at best.

Shkedi (2006) has similarly pointed out that “[c]urricular innovation is not about putting into place the latest curriculum. It means changing the cultures of teachers, classrooms, and schools, which makes the teachers’ role in the process of curriculum

development central, and very crucial” (p. 719). Because teachers play such a prominent role in the success of language classes, biblical language teachers must be trained in the theory and practice of language teaching; otherwise, all new textbooks and materials will be of no use, regardless of how well they reflect teaching principles based on SLA research.

However, even if it is the case that an instructor is both willing to implement CLT and has been trained to do so, there may be other obstacles. Johnson, Monk, and Swain (2000) conducted a study wherein Egyptian science teachers were provided significant teacher training in the U.K. and then returned to their Egyptian teaching contexts only to meet a host of other barriers, including “the resources available, the examination regime in place, and more broadly perhaps, the expectations and value placed on education in the system at large” (p. 23). They concluded that the lack of teacher education is not the problem so much as constraining external factors. Clearly, a teacher’s educational context must be both receptive and conducive for a curriculum reform to take place.

When the entire field of biblical languages has been teaching the same way for so long, change will not take place quickly or easily, and it will certainly encounter opposition at the institutional level. Fullan (2007) has addressed the complexity of reform, largely attributing it to the need for change to take place at multiple levels: the teacher, the school, the district, the state, and the national government (p. 18). (In the case of the biblical languages, the latter two or three levels may be irrelevant). In other words, if a teacher does not find herself in a context that supports such reform, the transition process will prove to be an uphill battle indeed.

Because “new meanings, new behaviors, new skills, and new beliefs depend significantly on whether teachers are working as isolated individuals or are exchanging ideas, support, and positive feelings about their work” (Fullan, 2007, p. 97), and because few instructors will likely find themselves in a context with other colleagues who share a similar vision, there exists the need for an online community to collaborate, share ideas, ask questions, exchange teaching materials and techniques, and so on. Apart from a robust support community, individuals attempting CLT will have an even more difficult road ahead of them. How does one go about fostering such deep reform?

Fullan (2007) argued that, of the three dimensions needed for “deep reform” to take place, “changes in beliefs and understanding ... are the foundation of achieving lasting reform” (p. 37). Yet these beliefs and understanding will not take place until they have experienced the reform themselves, because experiences affect beliefs. “People cannot want ‘it’ until they have tried it. The concrete experience of participating in a movement is crucial, meanings and value being formed *after the experience* not before it” (Bate, Bevan, & Robert, 2005, as cited in Fullan, 2007, p. 58, italics added). This highlights perhaps what is the most crucial need for the field of ancient language teaching—more opportunities for educating and training language teachers in both theory and practice, but in contexts where they can experience the results themselves as learners.

The materials discussed in Chapter 6 are certainly a step in the right direction as far as biblical language acquisition is concerned. Whether or not they all incorporate SLA principles consistently or optimally, they attempt to incorporate them nonetheless. The field needs more people who are open-minded enough to consider breaking from the traditional GT approach and experimenting with curricular innovation. However, no one

person will influence the field by him/herself. While a handful of isolated textbooks have emerged in the last decade or so, each one seems to be disconnected from a vibrant community that is collaborating and actively contributing to the advancement of the field as a whole. Textbooks will not, in and of themselves, lead to curriculum reform in the field of biblical language acquisition. It begins with beliefs and understanding of what needs to take place in the minds of teachers. Only then will there be a great enough demand for and the mutual support needed to produce sufficient resources for the biblical languages that consistently reflect the vast amount of research conducted in the field of SLA. This discussion is by no means expected to be the final word for biblical language pedagogy; rather, the attempt has been made to lay the issue out in light of the available evidence, and, hopefully, to offer some suggestions as to a way forward for the field of biblical language instruction.

Summary and Conclusion

The field of biblical language instruction, as it currently stands, does not generally produce proficient readers of Hebrew and Greek as defined by the field of SLA. That is, most graduates from biblical language programs are not able simply to pick up their Bible and read it for pleasure in its original languages, at a normal rate, for extended periods of time, and without frequent recourse to grammars or dictionaries. This is due largely to the field's use of GT which has remained virtually unchanged since its inception in the nineteenth century. This approach, however, only enables learners to analyze the L2 in a mechanical, conscious, and laborious manner. The field of SLA, on the other hand, has been continually developing and refining SL teaching principles based on ever-advancing research. As a result, learners of modern languages tend to reach communicative

competence relatively efficiently. This proficiency includes fluency in all four language skills. Historically, however, there has been no cross-over between the fields of SLA and biblical language instruction.

This paper has attempted to answer the question: Can the same language teaching principles derived from modern Second Language Acquisition research be effectively applied to the teaching of the biblical languages? Only recently have some pioneers been attempting such an endeavor and they have met remarkable success, including increased motivation among learners, increased reading fluency, and better long-term retention. These results provide convincing anecdotal evidence that CLT is indeed possible and beneficial for biblical language learners. The recent development of textbooks and institutions that utilize CLT principles also suggests that it is gaining recognition and adherents among the field of biblical studies.

However, as a review of these innovative textbooks and institutes demonstrates (Chapter 6), some of them do not thoroughly or consistently reflect the SLA research. That is, not all textbooks and instructors who claim to employ CLT to the teaching of biblical languages actually do so thoroughly or consistently. This reality points to the need for a more principled approach to teaching the biblical languages—one that is based on current research in SLA literature. Such an approach is characterized by teaching the target language in the target language, utilizing implicit instruction as much as possible, fostering language awareness, facilitating language production via negotiated interaction, integrating language skills, maintaining curricular integration, maximizing learning opportunities, aiming for fluency before accuracy, promoting learner autonomy, and ensuring social relevance. Together these principles represent an orientation towards

language teaching that the field of SL teaching refers to as Communicative Language Teaching.

Research suggests and experience demonstrates that implementing CLT in biblical language programs will efficiently produce learners who are truly literate in Hebrew and Greek and who are thus equipped with communicative competence, which includes, but is not limited to, fluent reading skills. Such proficiency will enable learners to more effectively and more accurately peer back into history and learn from the biblical authors, as they engage them in conversation on their own terms and in their own language.

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